

From Ballots to Borders: The Influence of Political Regimes on Global Trade Policies ^{*}

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Abstract

Are left-wing governments protectionist? This study empirically investigates whether electoral victories by left-wing parties lead to the adoption of protectionist trade policies. Using a regression discontinuity design, we analyze 1,064 national elections (both presidential and legislative) across multiple countries from 1945 to 2018. Our findings reveal that left-wing administrations implement significantly more protectionist measures by increasing import tariffs and reducing import volumes while promoting exports to achieve trade surpluses. The results demonstrate important variations across political systems: left-wing governments in presidential systems exhibit stronger protectionist tendencies for imports, parliamentary systems show the highest tariff increases under left-wing leadership, and semi-presidential systems uniquely decrease all three measures of trade flows (exports, imports, and trade-to-GDP ratios), contrasting with the pro-export policies adopted in the other two systems.

^{*}I am deeply grateful to my advisor, Marcos Y. Nakaguma, and Pierluca Pannella. I also extend my sincere thanks to Professors Vítor Possebom and João Paulo Pessoa for their valuable feedback and their patience in addressing my questions throughout the research process.

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1 Introduction

The effects of economic decisions on political outcomes are well-explored in the field of political economy. The political business cycle literature examines how governments adjust monetary and fiscal policies to influence election results. Policy choices often depend on political orientation: Left-wing parties typically advocate for increased spending and growth, while right-wing parties prioritize reduced spending, balanced budgets, and lower inflation. Therefore, it is reasonable to expect these ideological differences to also manifest in the trade policies adopted by left- or right-leaning parties.

International trade can generate heterogeneous and redistributive effects among various societal groups. The impacts of new international trade policies might favor certain sectors or groups while disadvantaging others, particularly in the short term. Consequently, legislators aiming for election or re-election pay significant attention to trade measures. Thus, political parties typically craft their trade platforms to reflect their ideological preferences and those of their electoral bases, aligning their trade stances with their broader economic commitments. Against this backdrop, an important question arises: Do parties also differentiate themselves based on their trade policy positions?

As noted by [Milner and Kubota \(2005\)](#), the political economy perspective can approach this issue from an alternative angle by asking: “What determines trade policy?” A common understanding associates left-wing parties and governments with more protectionist trade agendas, including higher tariffs and stringent import restrictions, to protect domestic industries. In contrast, right-leaning parties and governments favor pro-trade measures promoting an open economy. However, rigorous causal evidence remains scarce.

Despite the importance of the political economy of trade, few studies have been conducted on the link between the political economy and trade. Methodological challenges, particularly endogeneity, make it hard to establish clear causal relationships, as economic conditions and institutional factors can simultaneously influence electoral outcomes and trade policies. Robust econometric techniques, such as regression discontinuity designs (RDD) and instrumental variable approaches, are necessary to assess the impact of political orientation on trade policy accurately. Furthermore, [Milner and Judkins \(2004\)](#) note that partisanship in trade policy is often neglected due to the dominance of two prevailing theories. Specifically, interest group theories suggest trade outcomes are driven by economic interest groups rather than political

parties. Moreover, the hegemonic stability theory posits that a nation’s international position largely determines its trade policy, thereby reducing the influence of partisan ideologies.

Building on this gap, this study aims to empirically assess whether left-wing governments adopt more protectionist policies when in office than their non-left counterparts. Specifically, the research seeks to answer the question: Do left-wing parties implement significantly more protectionist trade policies during their tenure? Further, two additional questions guide this analysis. First, does the type of election—presidential or legislative—affect the nature and scope of trade policies that parties adopt? Differences might emerge even under the same ideological orientation. Second, do domestic political institutions, such as party structures and electoral rules, influence how parties position themselves on trade policy? For example, presidential systems may enable more decisive trade policy shifts than parliamentary or semi-presidential systems, where significant policy changes often require broader coalitions and consensus.

To mitigate these methodological difficulties and contribute to the literature on the political economy of trade policies, this paper employs an RDD, a robust quasi-experimental approach ideal for addressing the causality issues inherent in electoral studies. The RDD leverages the quasi-random nature of narrowly won or lost elections, effectively minimizing biases typical of traditional econometric techniques. By focusing exclusively on elections decided by close margins, this approach provides more precise estimations of how left-wing electoral victories causally influence subsequent trade policies.

Our empirical strategy builds on the electoral dataset of [Girardi \(2020\)](#), merged with detailed trade flows from the Gravity Database ([Conte et al., 2022](#)), tariff data from the CEPII Trade Production Database ([Mayer et al., 2023](#)), and macro indicators from the Global Macro Database ([Müller et al., 2025](#)). The running variable is the left-wing margin of victory (or defeat), while outcome variables measure changes between pre-election and post-election periods in tariff levels, imports-to-GDP ratios, exports-to-GDP ratios, and trade openness (exports plus imports as a percentage of GDP). We track these indicators over a four-year horizon following elections, differentiating between presidential versus legislative election effects, and a heterogeneous analysis across political systems.

We present [Figure 1](#) to provide a descriptive entry point for comparing parties’ stances on trade policy across 1,064 presidential and legislative elections in 120 coun-

tries between 1945 and 2018.¹ Our visualization disaggregates ideological positioning by institutional context, revealing distinct patterns across regime types. In Presidential systems (Figure 1b), the ideological divide over trade policy is most pronounced, with right-wing parties advocating extensive liberalization while left-wing parties support protectionist measures, though both tend to be more pro-trade than their counterparts in other systems. Parliamentary systems (Figure 1c) demonstrate more moderate positions probably due to coalition-building imperatives, with a steady convergence toward greater liberalization since the 1990s, interrupted only by minor post-2008 crisis fluctuations. Semi-presidential systems (Figure 1d) demonstrate alternating periods of divergence, especially before 1990, and near convergence due to reduced post-Cold War polarization and increased participation in multilateral institutions like the WTO and EU. These systems often show deviations from traditional ideological lines, influenced by the historical political context of countries such as France, Poland, and post-Soviet states. Historical legacies and specific interests, like French agricultural protectionism, may drive right-wing parties to adopt unexpectedly protectionist stances in these cases.

Overall, from 1945 to 2018, there is a clear trend across all parties toward more open trade agendas. These findings indicate that political parties do indeed differ in their trade positions, and the structure of the political system can have varying effects on the trade policies adopted by left-wing governments.

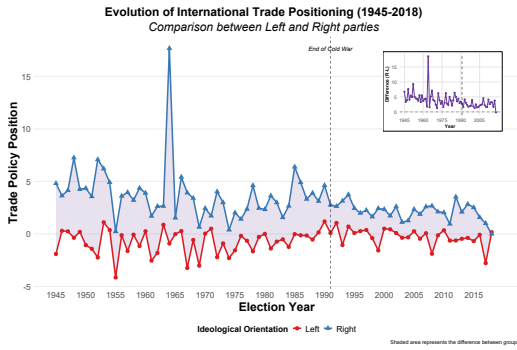
Turning to causal evidence, our findings reveal a clear and compelling effect of left-wing governments on international trade dynamics. On average, left-wing administrations adopt more protectionist measures by raising tariffs, reducing imports, and generally lowering trade openness, especially in presidential elections. Interestingly, the effect on exports differs significantly based on institutional contexts: while presidential elections won by left-wing parties typically lead to a decline in exports relative to GDP, legislative victories by these parties often produce an increase in exports, thus improving the country’s trade balance.

Moreover, the analysis highlights meaningful variation across political systems.

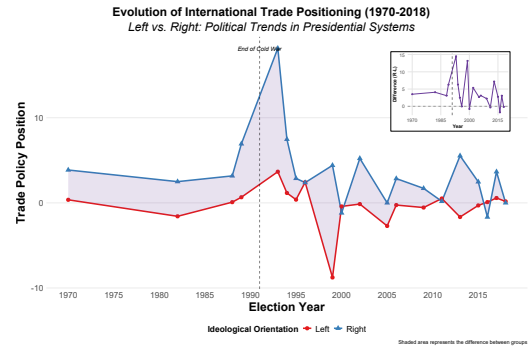
¹Figure 1 presents our sample’s average trade policy positions, disaggregated by partisan orientation across countries and years. Parties are categorized as either left- or right-wing based on the *rile* scale, as detailed by Lehmann et al. (2024). The trade position variable is calculated as: Trade Position = (per401 + per407) – (per406 + per412), corresponding to free market economy, anti-protectionism, pro-protectionism, and controlled economy, respectively, also defined by Lehmann et al. (2024). Higher values indicate a stronger orientation towards free trade. Each data point represents the average position of all parties contesting elections in a given year, rather than focusing solely on the winning parties.

Figure 1. Partisan Differences in Global Trade Policy: Left vs. Right Parties (1945–2018)

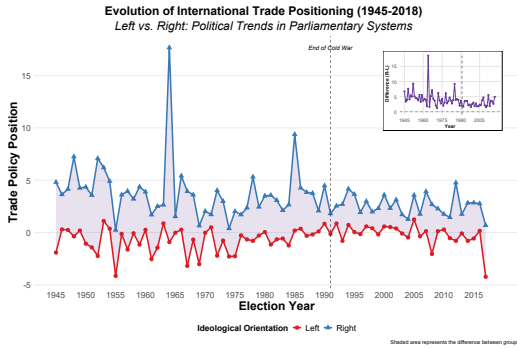
(a) All Political Systems and Elections



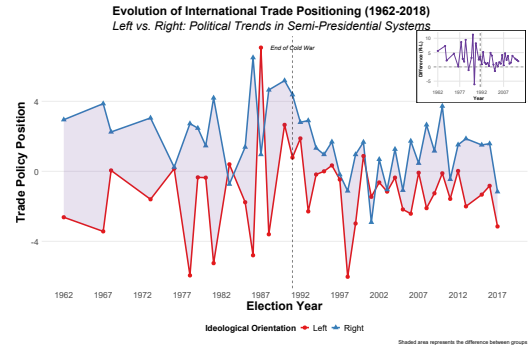
(b) Political System: Presidential



(c) Political System: Parliamentary



(d) Political System: Semi-Presidential



Notes: Figure 1a through Figure 1d illustrate partisan differences in trade policy positions across political systems. The vertical axis represents the average trade policy position score for left-wing and right-wing parties, while the horizontal axis shows the time period covered in our analysis (1945–2018). The shaded area highlights the magnitude of policy divergence between parties of opposing ideologies. The inset graphs quantify this left-right differential over time, demonstrating temporal variation in partisan trade policy polarization. Data Source: [Lehmann et al. \(2024\)](#)

In presidential regimes, the adoption of protectionist tariffs by left-wing governments aligns closely with strategies reminiscent of import substitution industrialization, which aim to reduce imports and foster domestic industries. Conversely, parliamentary systems exhibit different dynamics. Despite implementing substantial tariff increases—likely facilitated by historically lower baseline tariff rates in certain sectors—these countries, largely European and integrated into the European Union, experience simultaneous growth in both exports and imports. This outcome likely reflects lower transportation costs and deep-rooted historical and institutional ties within Europe, facilitating intra-European trade despite protective measures targeting external markets. These nuanced results underscore the complex interplay between political ideology, institutional design, and trade policy outcomes. Finally, semi-presidential systems displayed the most protectionist policies, increasing tariffs, reducing exports, imports, and trade-to-GDP, showing that historical political legacies play a significant role under this system.

This study represents one of the first comprehensive applications of the RDD methodology to analyze left-wing policies in international trade contexts. While recent work by [Marx et al. \(2024\)](#) also examined the effects of elections on economic variables, their study focused on electoral turnovers and did not specifically examine left-wing policy outcomes like ours. By isolating and quantifying the causal effects of left-wing electoral outcomes on trade policy across diverse political and institutional settings, this research contributes significantly to academic discussions on the political determinants of international trade, emphasizing the crucial roles of political ideology and institutional structures in shaping global trade interactions.

The remainder of this study proceeds as follows. [Section 2](#) reviews relevant literature, emphasizing the underutilization of RDD in trade policy studies. [Section 3](#) describes the databases employed. [Section 4](#) explains the RDD approach, variable construction, and model specifications. [Section 5](#) presents the empirical findings, with robustness and falsification tests discussed in [Section 6](#). Finally, we discuss our findings in [Section 7](#) and [Section 8](#) concludes the analysis.

2 Literature Review

Traditional theories in the field of trade policy often overlook the impact of political parties and their positions on trade. This suggests that the influence of politics on trade policy is relatively minor, with factors such as interest groups, a country’s posi-

tion, and its size playing a more significant role than the internal political dynamics that may conflict with international trade policies. [Milner and Judkins \(2004\)](#) highlights that questions about partisanship in trade policy are often overlooked in the political economy literature because two dominant theoretical traditions minimize the relevance of political preferences in understanding a country’s trade policy position. First, interest group theories, such as specific factors models, argue that partisanship does not matter since trade policy emerges from the preferences and influence of various interest groups that each party represents. Thus, the nature and power of these economic groups dictate trade policy rather than partisan considerations. Secondly, the hegemonic stability theory suggests that a country’s size is the key factor influencing its trade policies.

Two complementary theoretical frameworks explain the diminished importance of partisanship in determining trade policies across political systems. Within factor mobility theory, trade preference formation depends critically on mobility levels within a country’s economy. As discussed by [Hiscox \(2001\)](#), under high factor mobility conditions, the Stolper-Samuelson model predicts party unification along class lines, with shared trade interests within socioeconomic groups. Conversely, in low mobility environments, the Ricardo-Viner model better explains the resulting political dynamics by predicting intra-class divisions between export-oriented and import-competing sectors, even within similar factor groups. This sectoral fragmentation not only intensifies inter-party disputes but also significantly undermines internal party cohesion. Contemporary economies increasingly exhibit characteristics of the Ricardo-Viner model, creating internal party divisions where influential interest groups ultimately shape trade policies more decisively than partisan ideology ([Hiscox, 2001](#); [Milner and Judkins, 2004](#)).

This domestic factor analysis complements the systemic perspective offered by hegemonic stability theory (HST). As [Milner and Judkins \(2004\)](#) explains, the HST theory posits that a country’s position in the international system—whether as a hegemon, middle power, or small state—fundamentally determines its national trade preferences, thereby constraining the policy range available to domestic political parties. Under this framework, significant trade policy cleavages emerge primarily between countries occupying different positions in the international hierarchy rather than between parties within the same nation.

Due to the focus on the factors model and HST in the debate on the political economy of trade, the study of partisanship in trade policies has not developed sig-

nificantly. The existing literature on understanding the impacts of partisanship and elections on trade is limited, primarily concentrating on the economies of the US and the UK. Those studying cross-national partisanship and trade are even fewer, but recent studies have found that partisanship can affect international trade policies. These studies propose that party stances on trade can be emerged from the interaction of ideological cleavages, institutional design, and global economic integration. [Milner and Judkins \(2004\)](#) found that ideological cleavage emerges as a determining factor, with left-wing parties in advanced industrial economies demonstrating greater protectionist inclinations compared to right-wing parties, reflecting the persistence of historical class divisions in contemporary democracies. The authors found that political institutions exert significant influence on this dynamic, with presidential systems inducing both left and right parties to adopt more favorable positions toward free trade, although they paradoxically intensify partisan conflict over these policies. Moreover, the electoral system also presents systematic effects: plurality (majoritarian) rules frequently associated with two-party systems promote more liberalizing positions compared to proportional representation systems, which tend to allow more protectionist positions, particularly among left-wing parties.

Contrary to popular belief, [Milner and Judkins \(2004\)](#) found that political parties in countries with lower levels of development tend to adopt a more pro-trade agenda. Additionally, political parties in countries with higher levels of American economic influence often employ more pro-trade rhetoric. Furthermore, globalization plays a crucial role in shaping the positions of these parties on international trade. As economies become more integrated, the historical differences among political parties diminish, leading them to be more favorable toward trade openness. These findings align with the discussion in [Figure 1](#), where similar patterns are observed in the graphs.

Although [Milner and Judkins \(2004\)](#) examined the trade policy agendas of political parties rather than their specific trade policy implementations, their study underscores the significant impact that political parties and elections can have on international trade. This insight was crucial in paving the way for further research in this area. For instance, [Dutt and Mitra \(2005\)](#) examines how governmental ideology affects trade decisions through a Heckscher-Ohlin model featuring a two-sector, two-factor economic framework. This theoretical perspective predicts that left-wing governments typically adopt protectionist trade policies in capital-abundant countries, whereas they pursue pro-trade policies in labor-abundant countries. [Dutt and](#)

Mitra (2005) empirical findings support these predictions, indicating that left-wing governments favor pro-trade measures in labor-rich economies and protectionism in capital-rich contexts. Additionally, the influence of political ideology on trade policy appears more pronounced in democratic countries than in authoritarian regimes, where ideological effects, though less common, can sometimes be substantial.

Previous studies have been crucial in highlighting the significance of political parties and elections, as well as their impact on international trade. However, endogeneity in the estimation process has made it challenging to establish a clear causal relationship between politics and the economy. To address these issues, more recent empirical research that investigates the causal links between electoral outcomes and various political or economic indicators has frequently employed the Regression Discontinuity Design (RDD) methodology. This method leverages the natural discontinuity in election results at a specific threshold, such as a candidate's margin of victory, to allow for credible causal inference. By comparing candidates who narrowly win with those who narrowly lose, RDD minimizes selection bias and enhances the reliability of causal estimates.

Given concerns about the validity of RDD in electoral contexts, particularly regarding potential electoral manipulation or incumbent advantages, Eggers et al. (2015) analyzed over 40,000 close electoral contests across ten countries. Their extensive investigation found limited evidence of systematic manipulation or incumbent advantage significant enough to undermine the fundamental assumptions of RDD methodology. These findings affirm the general suitability and validity of RDD in electoral research. However, they caution researchers to carefully assess contexts where electoral manipulation or incumbency advantages might exist, potentially impacting methodological rigor and inference quality.

Although the RDD is frequently employed to estimate the causal effects of electoral outcomes on various political and economic variables, its application within the field of international trade remains relatively uncommon. Previous studies employing RDD methods in international trade have typically relied on geographic and cultural discontinuities to investigate the causal effects of various factors on trade flows. An illustrative example of utilizing RDD methodology in international trade, albeit outside of an electoral context, is provided by Gopinath et al. (2011). They applied RDD to examine the border-related trade costs between the United States and Canada, specifically focusing on price differences for identical goods across national borders. Their analysis revealed that national borders create significant price gaps, indicating

substantial trade frictions and associated costs.

Recent research has begun to explore the application of the regression discontinuity design within the political economy of trade, although it is not yet widely utilized. For example, [Marx et al. \(2024\)](#) analyzes the causal impact of electoral turnovers on economic indicators, including trade intensity (measured by the trade-to-GDP ratio). The authors justify their use of RDD by emphasizing that electoral turnovers are typically not random, often occurring in response to economic downturns, which makes it challenging to attribute subsequent economic outcomes directly to electoral results. The RDD approach mitigates these endogeneity concerns by focusing specifically on closely contested elections where incumbents narrowly win or lose.

Their findings suggest that electoral turnovers have a significant impact on economic performance across various dimensions, notably international openness, democratic governance, and inflation control. Regarding trade openness specifically, electoral turnovers lead to substantial increases in trade intensity, with an effect size of approximately 0.249 standard deviations (or 3.387% of GDP when evaluated with non-standardized outcomes). Additionally, they find marked increases in imports-to-GDP (0.175 standard deviations) and exports-to-GDP (0.246 standard deviations). Electoral turnovers are also associated with greater diversification of trade partners, as evidenced by rising Herfindahl indices for both import and export partner shares, reflecting intensified engagement in global trade networks.

While [Marx et al. \(2024\)](#) examined the effects of electoral turnovers on various economic outcomes at the national level, much of the existing research utilizing RDD to explore electoral impacts has focused primarily on local (municipal or regional) elections across multiple countries ([Fujiwara et al., 2011](#); [Cerqua et al., 2024](#)). Another national-level contribution comes from [Girardi \(2020\)](#), who studied the effects of left-wing electoral victories on financial markets. This study found that a left-wing electoral victory significantly lowers stock market valuations in the short term, while the effects on sovereign bond markets remain minimal. Specifically, close electoral victories by left-wing parties are associated with an average decrease of approximately 13 to 15 percentage points in real share prices, with the most substantial decrease—around 5 to 7 percentage points—occurring immediately after the election results are announced. These effects are more substantial and persistent when the winning left-wing party proposes more radical economic policies.

The studies by [Marx et al. \(2024\)](#) and [Girardi \(2020\)](#) are pioneering contributions within the literature, employing RDD with large, cross-country datasets to causally

link national-level electoral outcomes with economic and policy variables.

Building on this literature, our research applies a similar close-election RDD framework to investigate how the accession of left-wing administrations influences international trade policies at the national level. Specifically, this study examines whether left-wing governments systematically alter trade flow, tariff rates, and trade-to-GDP ratios during their tenure. Furthermore, the analysis aims to empirically test the widely-held belief that left-wing administrations tend to decrease openness to international trade, impose higher tariffs to protect domestic industries, and seek a favorable trade balance by increasing exports while reducing imports. To the best of our knowledge, this research represents the first application of RDD methodology to explore these questions within a comprehensive cross-country dataset.

3 Data

This analysis relies on four primary databases: an elections database, a tariffs database, and two trade flows databases. The elections database, developed by [Girardi \(2020\)](#), covers 1,064 presidential and legislative elections in 120 countries from 1945 to 2018, which was possible to build our running variable (*left margin*) for presidential and legislative elections in these 120 countries. The trade flows dataset is derived from the Gravity Database ([Conte et al., 2022](#)), which compiles a range of variables helpful in evaluating the impact of left-wing governments on trade. Each entry in the Gravity Database corresponds to a unique combination of exporting country, importing country, and year, containing detailed information on trade flows (IMF, Comtrade, BACI)², as well as geographic and cultural ties, trade agreements, and macroeconomic indicators. These variables serve as essential controls and fixed effects in the analysis, providing a necessary foundation for understanding shifts in the import and export patterns.

The analysis of the impact of left-wing governments on tariffs uses data from the CEPII Trade and Production Database (TradeProd) ([Mayer et al., 2023](#)), which provides extensive bilateral trade data and trade protection measures for 160 countries across nine industrial sectors from 1966 to 2020. This database combines trade information from Comtrade and industrial production statistics from UNIDO, with tariff data sourced from the World Bank’s World Integrated Trade Solutions (WITS). This broad temporal and sectoral coverage allows for a robust evaluation of left-wing

²UN Commodity Trade Statistics Database (COMTRADE)

policies on trade and reliable econometric estimations.

To complement the analysis, the research also employs the use of the Global Macro Database (GMD) (Müller et al., 2025), an open-source database comprising macroeconomic data from major organizations like the IMF and the World Bank. It includes annual data on 46 key variables for 243 countries from 1086 to 2024. Relevant variables include GDP, inflation, trade balances, and exchange rates.

3.1 Elections Database

Relying on the replication files from Girardi (2020), which aggregate data from various sources (Volkens et al., 2018; Armingeon et al., 2018; Swank, 2013; Girardi, 2019; Seki and Williams, 2014; Cruz et al., 2016; Baker and Greene, 2011; Coppedge, 1997), we rebuild the database of worldwide national elections. As a result, the data includes legislative/congressional and presidential elections spanning from 1945 to 2018.

The primary source for the legislative elections data was Volkens et al. (2018), who developed the Manifesto Project Database (MPD). The MPD contains information on 719 legislative elections across 56 countries from 1945 to 2017. It details the number of legislative seats won by each party, their ideological classifications, and other information used to construct the running variable left margin, defined as twice the difference between the percentage of seats held by left-wing candidates and 50% in legislative elections³. Using data from Volkens et al. (2018); Armingeon et al. (2018); Swank (2013) and the code developed by Girardi (2020), we calculated the share of seats won by (center-)left parties in legislative elections. Parties identified as “Socialist”, “Social-Democratic”, and “Ecologist” were included in the (center-)left category.

We replicated the code based on Girardi (2020) to determine the proportion of left-wing cabinet members in the first government formed after each election. From this, we constructed a dummy variable that indicates whether the government is left-leaning following the election. This variable is essential because there is not always perfect compliance in congressional elections, and it will be utilized in the first-stage regressions. Following the criteria established by Girardi (2020), we classify a government as left-leaning if at least two-thirds of its cabinet members belong to left-wing parties.

Similarly, we built the final presidential elections dataset based on the works of Girardi (2020, 2019). Girardi (2020) elections dataset spans from 1945 to 2018 and

³Left Margin for Legislative Elections: $Left\ Margin = 2 \times (Left\ Share\ of\ Seats - 50\%)$

aggregates information from several sources, providing detailed information on political parties, candidates, and the share of votes received. Based on this information, we established the running variable for presidential elections, defined as the difference between the popular vote share of the first (center-left) candidate and that of the first non-left candidate⁴. Only the second-round vote shares were taken into account when a run-off election took place (Girardi, 2020, p. 231).

To ensure the integrity and relevance of our analysis, we implemented selected exclusions from the final dataset that may potentially undermine the validity of the running variable. We excluded from the final dataset any presidential elections not decided by popular vote, those held in pure parliamentary systems, and legislative elections in the same month as a presidential election under a presidential system. After applying these exclusions, our final dataset comprises 374 presidential elections and 690 legislative elections, for which we were able to construct the left’s margin running variable following the procedures described by Girardi (2020)⁵.

Below, Figure 2 illustrates the geographic distribution, while Table 1 summarizes descriptive statistics of our elections dataset before merging with trade policy variables. The dataset includes electoral events under three political systems: Presidential, Parliamentary, and Semi-presidential. Detailed statistics per political system are in Appendix A.

Figure 2 identifies regions where left-wing parties hold stronger electoral influence, suggesting areas potentially receptive to left-wing trade policy shifts. Specifically, presidential systems in the Americas and Africa show frequent left-wing electoral successes. Parliamentary systems highlight Sweden, Australia, and the UK, whereas semi-presidential systems prominently feature Portugal and France.

Conversely, Figure 2b identifies regions where left-wing parties frequently experience electoral setbacks, notably Colombia, Costa Rica, and Cyprus (presidential systems), Denmark, Belgium, and the Netherlands (parliamentary systems), and France and Russia (semi-presidential systems). Overall, left-wing defeats exceed successes, underscoring regional variations in electoral support.

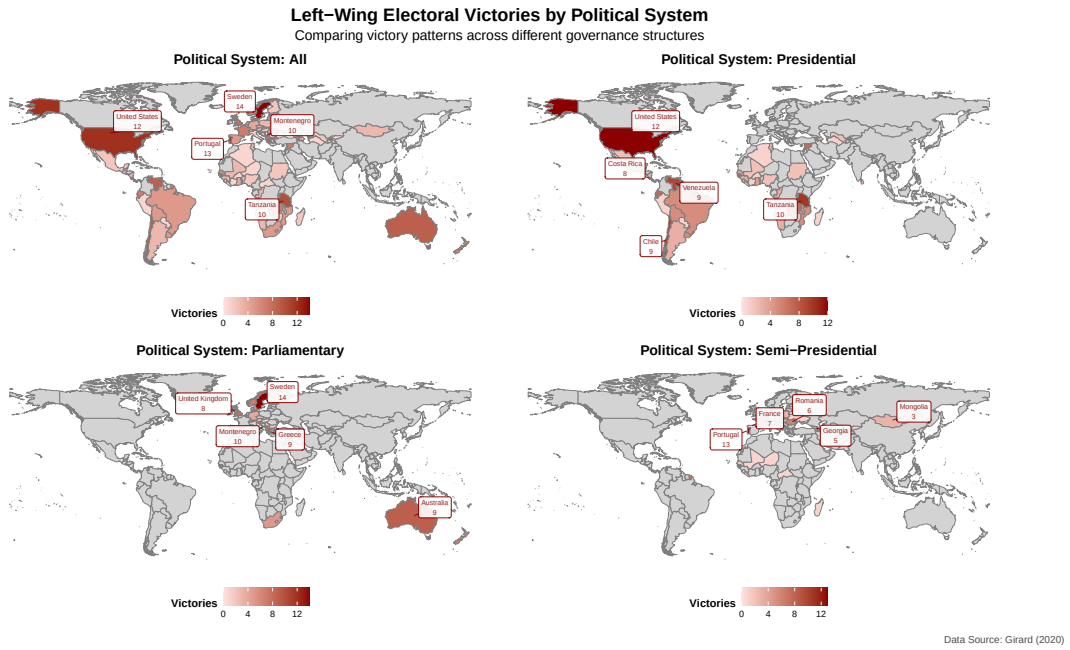
Table 1 reports 342 left-wing electoral victories (191 presidential and 151 legislative) and 722 defeats (183 presidential and 539 legislative). The variable indicating whether a left-wing government was formed post-election reveals the establishment of 366 left-wing governments, a figure exceeding the number of elections won by left-wing

⁴Left Margin for Presidential Elections: $Left\ Margin = Vote\ Share_{Left} - Vote\ Share_{Non-Left}$

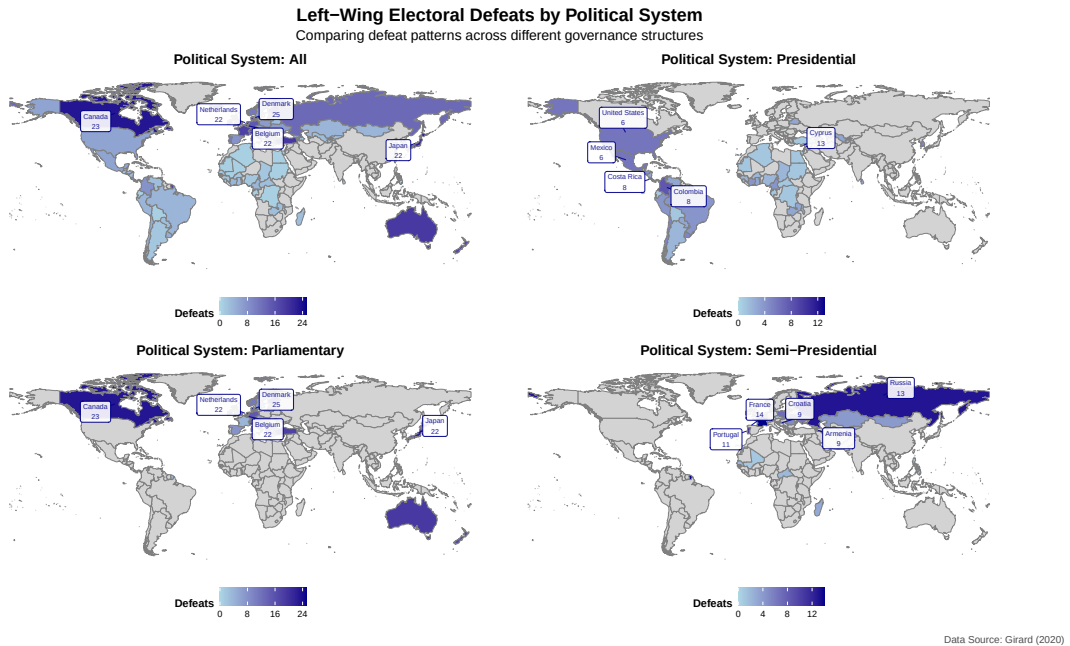
⁵For a detailed explanation of the dataset and its specifications, please read Girardi (2020)

Figure 2. Left-Wing Electoral Outcomes (1945–2018)

(a) Left-Wing Electoral Victories



(b) Left-Wing Electoral Defeats



Notes: Figure 2a and Figure 2b illustrate left-wing electoral outcomes across our sample (1945–2018). Red regions indicate left-wing victories, while blue regions represent left-wing defeats. Labeled countries highlight the five nations with the highest frequency of left-wing electoral victories and defeats, respectively. The geographic distribution demonstrates significant regional variation in left-wing electoral performance throughout the analyzed period. Data Source: Girardi (2020)

parties. This discrepancy primarily arises due to imperfect compliance in legislative elections, where coalition dynamics after elections can result in left-wing or right-wing governments irrespective of the electoral outcome.

There are 322 elections in presidential systems (Table A1): 283 presidential elections and 39 congressional elections, with left-wing parties winning slightly more elections. In contrast, parliamentary (Table A2) and semi-presidential (Table A3) systems have fewer left-wing victories.

These preliminary statistical findings indicate that presidential systems might experience stronger effects due to their executive structure and larger victory margins for left-wing parties.

3.2 Gravity Dataset

To estimate the impact of left-wing governments on trade flows, we employed the Gravity database developed by [Conte et al. \(2022\)](#). This database compiles variables from multiple sources, including import and export data from Comtrade⁶, the International Monetary Fund (IMF)⁷, and BACI⁸. In addition, it includes information on geographical factors like inter-country distances and contiguity, as well as data on trade agreements such as membership in GATT, WTO, the European Union, and other regional trade agreements.

The Gravity database covers the period from 1948 to 2020, encompassing trade information from 248 countries, some of which were active for only part of the analyzed period. Each observation within the dataset corresponds uniquely to an exporter-importer-year combination. Annual trade flow data were reported by either the exporter or the importer country. To minimize biases stemming from missing values in our regression analysis, we adopted a methodological approach by prioritizing data reported by importers, filling gaps with exporter data only when importer data were unavailable. Specifically, preference was given first to importer-reported IMF and Comtrade data, respectively. If these were unavailable, BACI data were used, and as a last resort, exporter data from IMF and Comtrade filled any remaining gaps.

Furthermore, trade data for 2021 and 2022 were directly retrieved from Comtrade and subsequently merged with the existing Gravity dataset, thereby extending the

⁶Trade flow data reported to the United Nations Statistical Division’s Commodity Trade Statistics Database from 1962 to 2020

⁷IMF data from 1948 to 2020 provided by the Direction of Trade Statistics (DOTS)

⁸The BACI trade flows database from 1996 to 2020, constructed by [Gaulier and Zignago \(2010\)](#) and sourced from the CEPII’s BACI dataset

Table 1. Descriptive Statistics — Presidential, Parliamentary, and Semi-Presidential Systems

All Political Systems (Pres, Parl, Semi-Pres)	Obs	Mean	S.D.	Min	Max
<i>All Elections</i>	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
<i>Left Margin (%)</i>					
All Sample	1064	-14.48	41.23	-100.00	100.00
Left Margin ≥ 0	342	29.53	30.15	0.00	100.00
Left Margin < 0	722	-35.33	26.87	-100.00	-0.29
<i>Left Victory: I[Left Margin ≥ 0]</i>					
All Sample	1064	0.32	0.47	0.00	1.00
I[Left Margin ≥ 0]	342	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
I[Left Margin < 0]	722	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
<i>Left Government after Election</i>					
All Sample	1045	0.35	0.48	0.00	1.00
Left	366	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
Non-Left	679	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
<i>Left-wing cabinet members (%)</i>					
All Sample	517	32.02	39.37	0.00	100.00
Left $\geq 2/3$	121	95.21	9.51	66.67	100.00
Left $< 2/3$	396	12.71	20.02	0.00	66.67
<i>Presidential Elections</i>					
<i>Left Margin (%)</i>					
All Sample	374	3.88	48.64	-98.00	100.00
Left Margin ≥ 0	191	40.38	34.40	0.01	100.00
Left Margin < 0	183	-34.21	27.49	-98.00	-0.60
<i>Left Victory: I[Left Margin ≥ 0]</i>					
All Sample	374	0.51	0.50	0.00	1.00
I[Left Margin ≥ 0]	191	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
I[Left Margin < 0]	183	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
<i>Left Government after Election</i>					
All Sample	374	0.51	0.50	0.00	1.00
Left	191	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
Non-Left	183	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
<i>Left-wing cabinet members (%)</i>					
All Sample	2	62.50	53.03	25.00	100.00
Left $\geq 2/3$	1	100.00	—	100.00	100.00
Left $< 2/3$	1	25.00	—	25.00	25.00
<i>Legislative Elections</i>					
<i>Left Margin (%)</i>					
All Sample	690	-24.44	32.56	-100.00	82.05
Left Margin ≥ 0	151	15.81	15.13	0.00	82.05
Left Margin < 0	539	-35.71	26.68	-100.00	-0.29
<i>Left Victory: I[Left Margin ≥ 0]</i>					
All Sample	690	0.22	0.41	0.00	1.00
I[Left Margin ≥ 0]	151	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
I[Left Margin < 0]	539	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
<i>Left Government after Election</i>					
All Sample	671	0.26	0.44	0.00	1.00
Left	175	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
Non-Left	496	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
<i>Left-wing cabinet members (%)</i>					
All Sample	515	31.90	39.33	0.00	100.00
Left $\geq 2/3$	120	95.17	9.54	66.67	100.00
Left $< 2/3$	395	12.68	20.04	0.00	66.67

Notes: The election data spans from 1945 to 2018 and includes three different political systems: Presidential, Parliamentary, and Semi-presidential. The term “Left Margin” refers to the margin of victory or loss for left-wing parties in an election. “Left Government” is a dummy variable that indicates whether a government is left-leaning after the election. “Left Cabinets” represents the share of cabinet positions held by left-wing parties.

temporal coverage of our final dataset to span from 1948 to 2022. This methodological decision aligns with best practices in international trade research literature, which widely recognizes importer-reported data as more reliable. This reliability arises because customs authorities in importing countries generally exercise greater scrutiny regarding the origin of imported goods to accurately determine applicable tariff rates (Gaulier and Zignago, 2010). Consequently, our primary empirical analysis is based on combined importer-reported trade flow data.⁹

Table 2 summarises the trade data prior to merging with the elections file. Panel A reports bilateral flows in three normalisations: the nominal value of exports from i to j in year t ; exports scaled by the exporter’s GDP, $GDP_{i,t}$; and exports scaled by the importer’s GDP, $GDP_{j,t}$. Panels B and C present country-level aggregates of exports ($X_{i,t}$) and imports ($M_{j,t}$), respectively.

Table 2. Descriptive Statistics for International Trade Data

Gravity Database: Pre-Merge	Obs	Exp	Imp	Mean	S.D.	Min	Max	Years
Panel A. <i>Bilateral</i>	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
<i>Combined Data</i>								
Trade Flow Level	1,395,854	249	249	300.1 M	3.9 B	0.0030	575.7 B	75
Trade/GDP (Orig.)	1,283,649	221	249	0.0026	0.0287	3.60e-13	21.95	74
Trade/GDP (Dest.)	1,280,415	249	221	0.0040	0.1323	3.10e-13	63.58	74
Panel B. <i>Aggregate</i>								
<i>Exports</i>								
Total Exports (Level)	14,164	249	—	29.6 B	131.5 B	591	3.4 T	75
Exports-to-GDP	11,434	221	—	0.2890	0.4161	2.48e-05	22.06	74
<i>IMF – Imports</i>								
Total Imports (Level)	14,079	—	249	29.8 B	134.8 B	530	3.3 T	75
Imports-to-GDP Ratio	11,368	—	221	0.4486	2.37	3.84e-05	83.44	74

Notes: The table reports descriptive statistics, including the number of observations (Obs), mean, standard deviation (SD), minimum (Min), and maximum (Max) across the available years (Years). *Obs* refers to the number of trade observations. *Exp* and *Imp* indicate the number of unique exporting and importing countries, respectively. All trade values are in current of US\$. K indicates thousands of US\$, M indicates millions US\$, B indicates billions of US\$, and T indicates trillions of US\$. *Total Exports (Level)* corresponds to untransformed export flows reported by the IMF and Comtrade. *Trade/GDP* ratios denote trade flows divided by the GDP of the respective country.

The descriptive statistics presented in Table 3 were obtained after merging our data with the elections dataset. These statistics focus on key aggregated outcome variables: $\Delta \text{Aggreg Exp-to-GDP}_{i,t}$ and $\Delta \text{Aggreg Imp-to-GDP}_{j,t}$. These variables represent the change in the export-to-GDP and import-to-GDP ratios from the pre-

⁹Supplementary analyses utilizing separately reported IMF and Comtrade importer data produced statistically significant results consistent with the primary findings derived from combined importer data, thus affirming the robustness of our approach.

electoral year ($h - 1$) to each of the four post-electoral years ($t = h + 1, \dots, h + 4$; see [Section 4.2](#)).

Despite significant variation across countries, a consistent ideological pattern emerges in international trade flows. Countries where left-wing parties lost elections (*Left Margin* < 0) systematically demonstrate greater increases in trade openness. Non-left governments consistently exhibit higher average growth rates in both export and import volumes, with differences in export means ranging from 0.18 to 0.70 percentage points across the four post-electoral years. This divergence is particularly evident in the fourth year post-election, where non-left administrations show export growth averaging 1.58 percentage points, substantially exceeding the 0.88 percentage point average for left-wing governments. Similar patterns appear on the import side, with left-leaning governments showing an average rise in imports-to-GDP of only 0.33 percentage points in the first year, compared to 0.60 for non-left governments. Notably, left-wing governments display higher volatility in trade flows, particularly regarding imports (standard deviation of 12.88 at $t=4$ versus 7.79 for non-left regimes). Taken together, this evidence points to a modest but consistent tilt toward greater trade openness under non-left administrations, while left-wing governments appear to pursue more protectionist strategies that gradually dampen exports and imports—a finding that recurs across data sources, normalizations, and time horizons.

Finally, we present below the descriptive statistics for the Trade-to-GDP ratio. [Table 4](#) reveals a different pattern in how political ideology affects trade openness across different political systems. Non-left governments generally show larger increases in the Trade-to-GDP ratio (2.62 percentage points four years after election) than left-wing governments (1.73 percentage points four years after election). However, this relationship dramatically reverses when examining different institutional contexts. In presidential elections, where we have presidential and semi-presidential systems, left-wing governments consistently generate higher trade openness increases, on average, than their non-left counterparts, while parliamentary systems display the opposite pattern. Parliamentary elections generally foster greater trade openness regardless of ideology, with left-wing parliamentary governments showing the most modest increases.

Table 3. Descriptive Statistics for Country-Level Export and Import Data After Merging with Election Sample

Gravity: Post-Merge	Obs	Elec.	Count.	Mean	S.D.	Min	Max	Years
Post-Election: $t = 1$	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
$\Delta\text{Exp-to-GDP}$								
<i>All Elections</i>	965	965	115	0.6483	5.95	-48.99	43.65	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	309	309	81	0.5275	6.58	-48.99	30.25	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	656	656	102	0.7052	5.64	-38.87	43.65	69
$\Delta\text{Imp-to-GDP}$								
<i>All Sample</i>	965	965	115	0.5144	7.84	-75.52	65.26	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	309	309	81	0.3340	10.31	-75.52	65.26	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	656	656	102	0.5994	6.36	-53.02	33.79	69
Post-Election: $t = 2$								
$\Delta\text{Exp-to-GDP}$								
<i>All Sample</i>	963	963	115	1.03	6.46	-50.57	52.64	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	307	307	81	0.8522	6.89	-50.57	30.43	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	656	656	102	1.11	6.26	-20.34	52.64	69
$\Delta\text{Imp-to-GDP}$								
<i>All Sample</i>	963	963	115	0.6018	8.10	-83.13	63.77	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	307	307	81	0.3955	10.18	-83.13	63.77	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	656	656	102	0.6983	6.93	-54.43	40.52	69
Post-Election: $t = 3$								
$\Delta\text{Exp-to-GDP}$								
<i>All Sample</i>	960	960	114	1.12	6.85	-50.37	48.12	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	307	307	81	0.9738	7.60	-50.37	30.20	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	653	653	101	1.18	6.48	-33.11	48.12	69
$\Delta\text{Imp-to-GDP}$								
<i>All Sample</i>	960	960	114	0.6823	8.67	-90.49	60.56	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	307	307	81	0.2550	11.24	-90.49	60.56	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	653	653	101	0.8832	7.16	-56.91	35.34	69
Post-Election: $t = 4$								
$\Delta\text{Exp-to-GDP}$								
<i>All Sample</i>	959	959	114	1.36	7.66	-49.96	39.80	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	307	307	81	0.8824	8.47	-49.96	33.23	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	652	652	101	1.58	7.24	-24.68	39.80	69
$\Delta\text{Imp-to-GDP}$								
<i>All Sample</i>	959	959	114	0.9796	9.71	-94.99	78.58	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	307	307	81	0.8449	12.88	-94.99	78.58	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	652	652	101	1.04	7.79	-70.62	52.47	69

Notes: The table reports descriptive statistics for changes in aggregated exports/imports to GDP between the year before an election ($t - 1$) and the year after ($t + 1$). “Obs” refers to the number of observations with valid (non-missing) values; “Elec.” indicates the number of unique election events; “Count.” shows the number of distinct exporter or importer countries. All ratios are expressed in percentage points (pp). “All Elections Sample” includes all observations; “Left Margin ≥ 0 ” and “Left Margin < 0 ” refer to elections won by left-wing and non-left parties, respectively.

Table 4. Descriptive Statistics for Country-Level Trade-to-GDP ratio Data After Merging with Election Sample

<i>Gravity: Post-Merge</i>	Obs	Elections	Countries	Mean	S.D.	Min	Max	Years
<i>All Elections</i>	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
<i>T = 1: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Sample</i>	965	965	115	1.16	11.37	-89.74	72.61	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	309	309	81	0.8615	13.60	-89.74	72.61	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	656	656	102	1.30	10.16	-73.49	65.12	69
<i>T = 2: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Sample</i>	963	963	115	1.63	12.05	-76.57	88.01	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	307	307	81	1.25	13.21	-76.57	74.52	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	656	656	102	1.81	11.47	-59.88	88.01	69
<i>T = 3: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Sample</i>	960	960	114	1.80	12.88	-82.86	81.72	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	307	307	81	1.23	14.99	-82.86	72.46	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	653	653	101	2.07	11.77	-59.78	81.72	69
<i>T = 4: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Sample</i>	959	959	114	2.34	14.29	-109.90	76.66	69
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	307	307	81	1.73	17.64	-109.90	76.66	68
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	652	652	101	2.62	12.40	-53.65	72.07	69
<i>Presidential Elections</i>								
<i>T = 1: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Presidential</i>	353	353	79	0.7704	13.87	-89.74	72.61	59
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	175	175	57	1.29	15.80	-89.74	72.61	52
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	178	178	66	0.2603	11.69	-73.49	46.54	48
<i>T = 2: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Presidential</i>	352	352	79	0.5873	14.08	-76.57	74.52	59
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	174	174	57	1.19	15.98	-76.57	74.52	52
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	178	178	66	-0.0001	11.94	-59.88	48.78	48
<i>T = 3: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Presidential</i>	350	350	78	0.8126	15.59	-82.86	72.46	59
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	174	174	57	0.9770	17.66	-82.86	72.46	52
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	176	176	65	0.6501	13.29	-59.78	40.03	48
<i>T = 4: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Presidential</i>	349	349	78	1.44	17.97	-109.90	76.66	59
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	174	174	57	1.72	20.71	-109.90	76.66	52
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	175	175	65	1.16	14.81	-53.65	53.62	48
<i>Legislative Elections</i>								
<i>T = 1: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Legislative</i>	612	612	55	1.39	9.64	-46.39	65.88	68
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	134	134	34	0.3029	10.05	-36.24	65.88	61
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	478	478	52	1.69	9.51	-46.39	65.12	68
<i>T = 2: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Legislative</i>	611	611	55	2.23	10.68	-45.85	88.01	68
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	133	133	34	1.33	8.36	-38.98	18.61	61
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	478	478	52	2.49	11.23	-45.85	88.01	68
<i>T = 3: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Legislative</i>	610	610	55	2.36	11.01	-38.53	81.72	68
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	133	133	34	1.56	10.58	-38.53	58.29	61
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	477	477	52	2.59	11.12	-29.56	81.72	68
<i>T = 4: ΔTrade-to-GDP (pp)</i>								
<i>All Legislative</i>	610	610	55	2.85	11.65	-74.37	72.07	68
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	133	133	34	1.73	12.61	-74.37	51.63	61
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	477	477	52	3.16	11.36	-33.50	72.07	68

Notes: The table displays descriptive statistics for trade-to-GDP data after merging with the elections dataset. Specifically, the post-merger data shows changes in the aggregated trade-to-GDP ratio from one year before an election (t-1) to the following four years. Additionally, the sample includes all political systems: Presidential, Semi-Presidential, and Parliamentary. "Obs" denotes valid observations, "Elections" indicates unique election events, and "Countries" refers to distinct countries. Values for $\Delta\text{Trade-to-GDP (pp)}$ are expressed in percentage points. "All Elections" includes all observations; "Presidential" is limited to presidential elections, while "Legislative" focuses on Legislative elections. The category *Left Margin* ≥ 0 includes elections won by left-wing parties, and *Left Margin* < 0 includes those won by non-left parties.

While the descriptive statistics offer valuable insights, they cannot establish causal relationships between political ideology and trade policy outcomes due to significant economic and political transformations of the 1980s and 1990s. These decades saw major events such as the dissolution of the Soviet bloc, widespread economic liberalization, the formation of the World Trade Organization, and numerous transitions from authoritarian to democratic governance, complicating efforts to isolate ideological effects.

Given these challenges, employing an RDD becomes essential. RDD leverages closely contested elections as quasi-random experiments, effectively controlling for confounding factors and providing a rigorous means to identify real causal effects between political ideology and trade openness, particularly given the contrasting patterns observed across presidential and parliamentary systems.

3.3 CEPII Trade Production Database (TradeProd)

Understanding the impact of left-wing governments on trade policies involves analyzing adjustments to tariff structures. Left-wing administrations have often been linked to protectionist policies, which may include higher tariffs aimed at protecting domestic industries from international competition. To evaluate this association empirically, the study utilizes data from the CEPII Trade and Production Database (TradeProd). This database contains comprehensive bilateral trade and tariff data for 160 countries across nine industrial sectors, covering the years 1966 to 2020. TradeProd combines international trade flows from Comtrade, industrial production data from the UNIDO database, and tariff information from the WITS.

The nine industrial sectors analyzed are classified according to the two-digit ISIC (International Standard Industrial Classification) revision 3: Food (15-16), Textiles (17-19), Wood-Paper (20-22), Chemicals (23-25), Minerals (26), Metals (27-28), Machinery (29-33), Vehicles (34-35), and Other manufacturing (36).

TradeProd provides annual bilateral trade data in millions of US dollars, compiled from three different reporting approaches: import country declarations, export country declarations, and a combined measure utilizing import data supplemented by export reports where import data is unavailable. Regarding tariffs, the database includes three distinct measures: Most-Favored Nation (MFN) tariffs (standard rates applied by WTO members absent preferential agreements), preferential tariffs (reduced rates from preferential trade agreements), and a combined tariff measure. This combined measure represents the minimum tariff rate effectively applied, calculated

as the lower value between MFN and preferential tariffs, ensuring a conservative estimate of the actual tariff rates¹⁰. For our estimation purposes, we have chosen to use the combined tariff data, as it is the most comprehensive and aims to reflect the actual tariffs applied by countries.

The present descriptive statistics show a weighted tariff measure aggregated at the country level to represent the actual tariff rates applied annually by each country. Below, we present [Table 5](#) with descriptive statistics, displaying the descriptive statistics for aggregated country-year level of weighted average tariff rate¹¹ for pre-merge and post-merge data. Panel A presents descriptive statistics (in percentage terms) for pre-merger aggregated tariffs calculated using our weighted average methodology detailed in [Section 4.2.1](#). Panel B displays our key outcome variable, Δ Aggregated Tariff Weighted (percentage points), which measures tariff policy changes following elections. This variable quantifies the magnitude of tariff adjustments implemented during a government’s four-year term compared to the baseline year preceding the election.

[Table 5](#) reveals a notable pattern where countries with presidential elections implement significantly larger tariff reductions (0.51 percentage points four years after the election) compared to those with legislative elections (0.35 percentage points). This difference likely reflects the historical context in which these elections operate: presidential elections are more prevalent in developing economies that underwent significant economic liberalization during the 1980s and 1990s, whereas legislative elections are predominant in developed economies within our sample that historically adopted more liberal trade policies. This context helps explain why presidential elections show larger reductions and greater volatility in tariff policies (standard deviations of 2.99 versus 1.06 in legislative elections by year 4).

3.4 Global Macro Database(GMD)

To further complement the analysis, the study incorporates the *Global Macro Database* (GMD), a comprehensive and openly accessible dataset containing aggregated macroeconomic indicators for 243 countries. The GMD compiles and harmonizes macroeconomic data from major international institutions, including the IMF, World Bank, and OECD, spanning a broad historical period. Specifically, the analysis utilizes external sector variables (exports and imports in local currency units), and nominal

¹⁰For additional information on MFN and preferential tariff rates, visit the [WITS website](#).

¹¹See [Section 4.2](#) for further details.

Table 5. Descriptive Statistics for Aggregated Weighted Tariffs in the Importing Country

<i>Aggregated Imp-Ind-Level</i>	Obs	Elections	Imp	Mean	S.D.	Min	Max	Years
Panel A. Pre-Merge	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
Aggregated Weighted Average Tariff (%)	7,992	—	166	10.9	11.5	0.00	101.32	55
Panel B. Post-Merge								
All Elections								
T = 1: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Sample	820	820	104	-0.15	1.05	-18.41	7.20	52
Left Margin ≥ 0	260	260	74	-0.16	1.38	-18.41	6.20	51
Left Margin < 0	560	560	94	-0.14	0.86	-9.08	7.20	52
T = 2: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Sample	820	820	104	-0.22	1.46	-18.27	16.84	52
Left Margin ≥ 0	260	260	74	-0.26	1.54	-18.27	6.17	51
Left Margin < 0	560	560	94	-0.21	1.43	-16.29	16.84	52
T = 3: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Sample	810	810	104	-0.29	1.70	-20.94	16.84	51
Left Margin ≥ 0	257	257	74	-0.32	1.89	-17.10	9.37	50
Left Margin < 0	553	553	94	-0.28	1.60	-20.94	16.84	51
T = 4: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Sample	801	801	104	-0.41	2.00	-28.43	16.84	50
Left Margin ≥ 0	255	255	73	-0.40	2.10	-18.18	9.37	49
Left Margin < 0	546	546	94	-0.41	1.95	-28.43	16.84	50
Presidential Elections								
T = 1: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Presidential	309	309	68	-0.18	1.54	-18.41	7.20	48
Left Margin ≥ 0	150	150	51	-0.21	1.75	-18.41	6.20	45
Left Margin < 0	159	159	58	-0.15	1.33	-9.08	7.20	44
T = 2: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Presidential	309	309	68	-0.26	2.19	-18.27	16.84	48
Left Margin ≥ 0	150	150	51	-0.33	1.94	-18.27	6.17	45
Left Margin < 0	159	159	58	-0.19	2.40	-16.29	16.84	44
T = 3: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Presidential	300	300	67	-0.32	2.49	-20.94	16.84	47
Left Margin ≥ 0	147	147	51	-0.38	2.35	-17.10	9.37	44
Left Margin < 0	153	153	57	-0.27	2.64	-20.94	16.84	43
T = 4: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Presidential	295	295	67	-0.51	2.99	-28.43	16.84	46
Left Margin ≥ 0	145	145	50	-0.50	2.62	-18.18	9.37	43
Left Margin < 0	150	150	57	-0.52	3.32	-28.43	16.84	42
Legislative Elections								
T = 1: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Legislative	511	511	55	-0.13	0.58	-5.58	1.99	51
Left Margin ≥ 0	110	110	33	-0.09	0.55	-3.13	1.99	46
Left Margin < 0	401	401	52	-0.13	0.59	-5.58	1.23	51
T = 2: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Legislative	511	511	55	-0.20	0.73	-5.33	1.99	51
Left Margin ≥ 0	110	110	33	-0.16	0.69	-3.37	1.99	46
Left Margin < 0	401	401	52	-0.22	0.75	-5.33	1.91	51
T = 3: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Legislative	510	510	55	-0.27	0.95	-7.04	3.29	51
Left Margin ≥ 0	110	110	33	-0.23	1.02	-4.92	3.29	46
Left Margin < 0	400	400	52	-0.28	0.94	-7.04	2.95	51
T = 4: ΔAggreg Tariff (pp)								
All Legislative	506	506	55	-0.35	1.06	-6.93	3.14	50
Left Margin ≥ 0	110	110	33	-0.27	1.10	-4.90	3.14	46
Left Margin < 0	396	396	52	-0.37	1.05	-6.93	2.58	50

Notes: The table displays descriptive statistics for tariff data before and after a merger. Specifically, the post-merger data shows changes in the aggregated weighted tariff rate from one year before an election (t-1) to the following four years. Additionally, elections are identified in the importing country, and the sample includes all political systems: Presidential, Semi-Presidential, and Parliamentary.. "Obs" denotes valid observations, "Elections" indicates unique election events, and "Imp" refers to distinct importers. Values for Δ Aggregated Tariff Weighted (pp) are expressed in percentage points, while (%) represents percentages for the pre-merge data. "All Elections" includes all observations; "Presidential" is limited to presidential elections, while "Legislative" focuses on legislative elections. The category *Left Margin* ≥ 0 includes elections won by left-wing parties, and *Left Margin* < 0 includes those won by non-left parties.

Gross Domestic Product (GDP at current market prices).

Employing the GMD enables a robust examination of left-wing governments’ impact on trade openness and macroeconomic stability from 1944 to 2022, covering 1,064 elections.

4 Methodology

The primary objective of this study is to assess the causal effect of left-wing electoral victories on trade. Specifically, it examines how these electoral outcomes affect the trade-to-GDP ratio, tariff policies, and international trade flows in countries governed by left-wing parties. The analysis addresses these effects at both aggregated (country-level) and disaggregated (sectoral and bilateral) dimensions, providing a comprehensive understanding of the influence that political orientation has on trade policies and economic openness.

To achieve this, we employ a regression discontinuity design (RDD) (Hahn et al., 2001; Imbens and Lemieux, 2008; Lee and Lemieux, 2010; Keele and Titiunik, 2015; Cattaneo and Titiunik, 2022). This method highlights the discontinuity in treatment probability at a specific cutoff, allowing us to isolate treatment effects. As noted by Cattaneo and Titiunik (2022), the RDD involves three key components: a score, a cutoff, and a treatment assignment rule.

This design assigns units a score, and treatment is provided only to those scoring above the cutoff. The RDD capitalizes on the abrupt change in treatment probability at this threshold, enabling us to analyze causal effects for units near the cutoff by using those just below as a control group for those just above, assuming comparability under specified conditions.

In this context, the continuity of potential outcomes assumption posits that near the cutoff point, where the left-wing candidate narrowly wins or loses, there are no systematic differences between countries on either side, apart from the presence of a left-wing government. The assumption of a smooth transition implies that other factors influencing outcomes (trade variables) change gradually as the vote margin crosses zero. Consequently, the treatment assignment is essentially random, as even slight changes in vote shares can determine the winning candidate.

Confounding variables—such as economic conditions, institutional quality, or cultural factors—are assumed not to change abruptly at the cutoff. Therefore, any observed differences in trade variables following the election are likely attributable

to the change in government rather than pre-existing differences. This randomness introduces exogenous variation, enabling us to isolate the effect of political orientation on trade policies. Thus, the local average treatment effect (LATE) captures the causal effect for countries where the left-wing candidate narrowly won or lost.

As noted by [Cattaneo and Titiunik \(2022\)](#), the primary concern with any Regression Discontinuity Design (RDD) is the potential for units to strategically alter their scores to be assigned to their preferred treatment conditions. This could lead to a discontinuous change in observable and unobservable characteristics at or near the cutoff, potentially confounding causal conclusions.

In this context, concerns about biases stemming from anticipation effects may emerge, similar to those encountered when using traditional event studies in electoral analysis. However, the RD-based event study applied here demonstrates the ability to mitigate such biases. According to [Girardi \(2020\)](#), this approach remains unbiased as long as ex-ante probabilities and other confounding factors do not exhibit a jump at the threshold. If these ex-ante probabilities fluctuate at the threshold, our estimates may have the correct direction but could underestimate the true magnitude of the causal effect.¹²

Consequently, this methodology appears well-suited for our analysis. It can reliably estimate the average causal effect of left-wing victories on countries' trade policies on a global scale.

4.1 Regression-Discontinuity Design: Understanding Scores, Sharp and Fuzzy approaches

The running variable is the margin of victory or loss for the (center-)left. For legislative elections, it is calculated as outlined below:

$$\text{Left Margin} = 2 \times (\text{Left Share of Seats} - 50\%). \quad (1)$$

The left share of seats in [Equation 1](#) reflects the share of seats won by (center-)left parties in legislative elections. Further, the two reflect the difference in seat distribution between left and non-left parties. A positive result indicates a left-leaning majority in congressional seats. Conversely, a negative result indicates left-leaning parties held a minority of legislative seats.

Although the left parties achieve a majority in legislative seats, it does not nec-

¹²For a formal proof, please refer to ([Girardi, 2020](#), Appendix A)

essarily always lead to a left-led congressional government because it is not unusual for center-left or left-wing parties not to ally and form a coalition. In fact, they may be part of an alliance with non-left parties, and the Congress will be non-left-led even with the majority achieved by (center-)left parties. That is, left-wing parties do not hold two-thirds of the cabinet members. Therefore, the government is not left-leaning. As our goal is to learn about the effect of receiving the treatment, we account for *imperfect compliance* in legislative elections. We employ a Fuzzy Regression Discontinuity Design (RDD) when the estimation contains both legislative and presidential elections, and the estimation analyses focus only on legislative elections. Cattaneo and Titiunik (2022) explain that Fuzzy RDD occurs when the treatment assigned does not match the treatment received by some units. This can happen when units assigned to treatment do not receive it, or those in the control group do receive it.

Our analysis assumes that the probability of a left victory in legislative elections experiences a discrete change at the cutoff but not a complete jump. The Fuzzy RDD estimand is the ratio of the change in the outcome variable at the threshold to the change in the probability of receiving treatment at that threshold. Specifically, the numerator compares average outcomes for units just above and just below the threshold, while the denominator assesses the likelihood of treatment for those same units. This ratio isolates the causal effect of treatment on the outcome for individuals affected by the threshold, known as compliers. In this context, the numerator represents the effect on trade variables when a left-leaning government comes to power, and the denominator indicates the chance of a left-leaning government being formed when (center-)left parties secure a legislative majority.

In contrast, presidential elections are analyzed under the premise of “*perfect compliance*”, implying that the election of a left-leaning president invariably results in the establishment of a left-oriented government¹³. This premise facilitates applying a Sharp Regression Discontinuity Design (RDD) for analyzing presidential elections. Unlike the Fuzzy RDD framework, in the Sharp RDD context, the treatment assignment aligns perfectly with the treatment received across all units, indicating flawless compliance.

The running variable pertinent to presidential elections is defined as follows:

$$Left\ Margin = Vote\ Share_{Left} - Vote\ Share_{Non-Left} \quad (2)$$

¹³Excluding presidential elections not determined by popular vote—such as those within parliamentary systems—bolsters the credibility of this assumption.

Here, the Left Margin quantifies the victory (or loss) margin between the leading (center-)left candidate and the foremost non-left candidate. The Vote Share corresponds to the percentage of votes garnered by leftist and non-leftist candidates, respectively.

4.2 Trade Variables Metrics

We outline our methodological approach to defining the outcome variables within the estimation framework. This analysis examines the impact of left-wing governments on trade policies, with a particular focus on the trade-to-GDP ratio, tariff levels, and trade flows (imports and exports). We conduct this assessment using aggregated data at the country-year level for overall trade flow variables and tariff rates. Furthermore, we analyze disaggregated data at the pair-country level for trade flows and at the country-industry-pair level for tariff rate analyses over a four-year period following elections ($h = 1, 2, 3, 4$). This approach enables us to capture the dynamic changes in trade policy enacted by left-wing administrations during their tenure. Detailed definitions and measurements of these trade-related variables are provided below.

4.2.1 Δ Tariff Rate

We begin by defining the dependent variable for tariffs. Let j represent the importer, i the exporter, t the election year, m the imports at the bilateral level, and k the specific industry, as previously defined in [Section 3.3](#). Thus, the $tariff_{j,i,k,t}$ is the rate imposed by country j on imports from country i in industry k during the election year t .

The analysis can distinguish between two types of effects: a direct (first-order) effect and an indirect (second-order) effect. The first-order effect measures how the election of a left-wing government in country j impacts the tariffs that country j imposes on imports from country i in industry k , denoted as $Tariff_{j,i,k}$. This captures the immediate policy adjustments made by newly elected left-wing governments on their own tariff structures in a specific industry. Conversely, the second-order effect measures how the election of a left-wing government in country j impacts the tariffs that country i imposes on imports of industry k from country j , denoted as $Tariff_{i,j,k}$. This examines the reciprocal response of trading partners to political shifts in their counterparts. This refined distinction allows for a comprehensive understanding of tariff dynamics, capturing both the direct policy changes by countries

with new left-wing governments and the strategic responses these changes produce from their trading partners.

We assess tariff outcomes using both disaggregated and aggregated methodologies. The disaggregated approach (Equation 4) focuses on examining bilateral country-industry tariff changes, whereas the aggregated method (Equation 5) calculates the weighted average tariff changes at the country level.

In our aggregation process, we utilize standard weights based on the export interests of other countries, rather than import weights, to avoid undervaluing prohibitively high tariffs. These weights reflect the global export significance of each industry for period $t - 1$, thereby ensuring both economic relevance and the avoidance of bias associated with import weights (WTO, 2007). Additionally, we use pre-election weights to eliminate any potential influence of post-election policy effects, ensuring the integrity of our estimations. The methodological formulas for both disaggregated and aggregated variables are presented below in Equation 4 and Equation 5.

First, we define each industry k 's share of total world exports in year $t - 1$:

$$w_{k,t-1} = \frac{\sum_i \sum_j x_{i,j,k,t-1}}{\sum_i \sum_j \sum_k x_{i,j,k,t-1}} \quad (3)$$

Here, the numerator $\sum_i \sum_j x_{i,j,k,t-1}$ sums exports of industry k from all exporters i to all importers j . The denominator $\sum_i \sum_j \sum_k x_{i,j,k,t-1}$ sums exports across every industry k , ensuring the weights across k sum to one.

We then incorporate this weight into the aggregation of tariff changes. The disaggregated tariff change for each exporter i , importer j , and industry k is defined as the difference in tariffs between year $t + h$ and year $t - 1$, as follows:

$$\Delta \text{Tariff}_{j,i,k} = \text{Tariff}_{j,i,k}^{t+h} - \text{Tariff}_{j,i,k}^{t-1}, \quad \text{where } h = 1, 2, 3, 4. \quad (4)$$

Finally, we form importer j 's aggregated tariff change by applying $w_{k,t-1}$ across its N_j exporters:

$$\Delta \text{Tariff}_j^{\text{agg}} = \sum_k w_{k,t-1} \left[\frac{1}{N_j} \sum_{i=1}^{N_j} \text{Tariff}_{j,i,k}^{t+h} - \frac{1}{N_j} \sum_{i=1}^{N_j} \text{Tariff}_{j,i,k}^{t-1} \right], \quad h = 1, 2, 3, 4 \quad (5)$$

Equation 4 measures the impact of left-wing governments on tariffs at a disaggregated level, capturing the average effect on tariffs at the bilateral (country-pairs) and industry-specific level. Positive estimates for the first-order effect ($\Delta \text{Tariff}_{j,i,k}$)

indicate that left-wing governments tend to increase tariffs, reflecting a more protectionist trade policy at the industrial level. Conversely, positive estimates for the second-order effect ($\Delta Tariff_{i,j,k}$) would imply that trading partners raise their tariffs on imports originating from countries governed by left-wing administrations. Negative estimates, however, suggest that left-wing governments lower tariffs, signaling increased openness to international trade, while negative second-order estimates indicate that partners similarly reduce their tariff rates in response.

Equation 5 provides aggregated measures of these effects, summarizing tariff adjustments across industries and trading partners. This aggregate analysis measures both the direct effect ($\Delta Tariff_j^{agg}$)—the weighted average tariff change implemented by a left-wing government across sectors—and the indirect effect—the overall tariff adjustments imposed by all trading partners collectively. Thus, the aggregated approach may offer a comprehensive evaluation of how left-wing governments influence tariff policies domestically and internationally.

This research focuses exclusively on the first-order effect, examining how left-wing administrations adjust tariff policies upon assuming office. Although the second-order effect, how other countries respond to these tariff adjustments, is not analyzed here, it remains a significant area of inquiry. Analyzing second-order effects could reveal potential retaliatory actions by trading partners against tariff increases implemented by left-wing governments or indicate convergence in trade policies if both countries reduce their tariffs following elections and tariff changes.

4.2.2 Δ Exports-to-GDP and Δ Imports-to-GDP

This section analyzes the effect of left-wing governments on trade flows, specifically examining how exports and imports relative to GDP change when such governments take office. A common assumption is that left-leaning administrations tend to adopt policies that restrict imports to protect domestic industries while promoting exports to achieve a favorable trade balance. To empirically assess this hypothesis, we constructed four outcome variables: exports-to-GDP and imports-to-GDP ratios at both disaggregated (bilateral - country-pair-level) and aggregated (country-level) analyses.

Let $x_{i,j}$ denote bilateral exports from country i (the exporter) to country j (the importer), and let $m_{j,i}$ denote the corresponding bilateral imports. Additionally, let X_i represent the total (aggregated) exports of country i and M_j the total imports of country j . Define t as the election year. The changes in these trade variables are

measured relative to GDP, as shown in the following equations:

$$\Delta \left(\frac{X_{i,j}}{\text{GDP}_i} \right) = \left(\frac{X_{i,j}^{t+h}}{\text{GDP}_i^{t+h}} \right) - \left(\frac{X_{i,j}^{t-1}}{\text{GDP}_i^{t-1}} \right), \quad h = 1, 2, 3, 4 \quad (6)$$

$$\Delta \left(\frac{X_i^{\text{agg}}}{\text{GDP}_i} \right) = \sum_j \left(\frac{X_{i,j}^{t+h}}{\text{GDP}_i^{t+h}} \right) - \sum_j \left(\frac{X_{i,j}^{t-1}}{\text{GDP}_i^{t-1}} \right), \quad h = 1, 2, 3, 4 \quad (7)$$

$$\Delta \left(\frac{m_{j,i}}{\text{GDP}_j} \right) = \left(\frac{m_{j,i}^{t+h}}{\text{GDP}_j^{t+h}} \right) - \left(\frac{m_{j,i}^{t-1}}{\text{GDP}_j^{t-1}} \right), \quad h = 1, 2, 3, 4 \quad (8)$$

$$\Delta \left(\frac{M_j^{\text{agg}}}{\text{GDP}_j} \right) = \sum_i \left(\frac{m_{j,i}^{t+h}}{\text{GDP}_j^{t+h}} \right) - \sum_i \left(\frac{m_{j,i}^{t-1}}{\text{GDP}_j^{t-1}} \right), \quad h = 1, 2, 3, 4 \quad (9)$$

Equation 6 captures changes in the export-to-GDP ratio at the bilateral level, measuring how exports from one country to another evolve after an election in that country. Equation 7 aggregates these changes across all trade partners, providing a broader perspective on how total exports respond to political shifts.

Conversely, Equation 8 and Equation 9 focus on import dynamics, identifying elections in the importer j . These equations evaluate how exports from various partners shift before and after a left-wing government assumes office. The aggregated import equation offers insight into the overall import behavior of the country affected by the electoral outcome.

These measures allow for a systematic evaluation of whether left-wing governments significantly alter trade flows by increasing or decreasing exports and imports during their tenure.

4.2.3 Δ Trade Openness

To complement our analysis of international trade policies under left-leaning administrations, we adopt the classical trade openness measure—the trade-to-GDP ratio. This ratio is computed by summing a country’s aggregate exports (X) and imports (M) and dividing the result by its GDP. Letting t denote the election year, we assess the change in trade openness by comparing the ratio in the year preceding the election ($t - 1$) with that in subsequent years ($t + h$ for $h = 1, 2, 3, 4$). Formally, this measure is defined as follows:

$$\Delta \text{Openness}_{i,t} = \left(\frac{X_i^{t+h} + M_i^{t+h}}{\text{GDP}_i^{t+h}} \right) - \left(\frac{X_i^{t-1} + M_i^{t-1}}{\text{GDP}_i^{t-1}} \right), \quad h = 1, 2, 3, 4 \quad (10)$$

Within the framework of our regression discontinuity design (RDD), a positive estimate indicates an increase in a country’s openness to international trade following a left-leaning election, whereas a negative estimate suggests a decrease.

4.3 Regression-Discontinuity Estimation Techniques

We outline our estimation strategy for the Fuzzy RDD, following [Girardi \(2020, p.236\)](#) methodology. This approach starts by estimating the probability of a leftist government emerging post-election when (center)-left parties win. We then perform a regression analysis to assess the government’s impact on trade variables.

For illustration, consider country i participating in election e at time t , while exporting to country j . We will estimate the trade variables over a h -period horizon using the following econometric specification:

$$D_{i,e} = \beta Z_{i,e} + g(x_{i,e}) + \eta_{i,e}, \quad (11)$$

$$\Delta y_{i,j,e,t+h} = \gamma_h Z_{i,e} + f^h(x_{i,e}) + \varepsilon_{i,j,e,t+h}, \quad h = -1, \dots, 4 \quad (12)$$

[Equation 11](#) shows the first-stage regression linking the left’s electoral margin to forming a left-leaning government. [Equation 12](#) outlines the reduced-form regression analyzing the outcome variable dynamics in relation to the left’s margin. Here, $D_{i,e}$ indicates whether a left government is established, and $x_{i,e}$ represents the margin of victory or defeat for the left. The variable $Z_{i,e}$ equals 1 if $x_{i,e} \geq 0$ and 0 otherwise. We assess changes in the outcome variable $\Delta y_{i,j,e,t+h}$ from time $t - 1$ to $t + h$ (see [Section 4.2](#)). Finally, $f^h(\cdot)$ and $g(\cdot)$ are non-linear functions approximated with triangular kernel-weighted local linear regression.

Utilizing [Equation 11](#) and [Equation 12](#), we can determine our key parameter of interest for each time horizon h under consideration. As a result, the local average treatment effect (LATE) attributed to a left-wing electoral victory is defined as $\frac{\gamma_h}{\beta}$.

4.4 Specifications

The analysis employs three estimation strategies to identify the causal effects of left-leaning governments on trade outcomes. First, we estimate a baseline model for each trade variable, as outlined in [Section 4.2](#) and formalized in [Equation 12](#).

Second, we extend the baseline specification by including year fixed effects together with either country fixed effects (for disaggregated analyses) or region fixed effects (for aggregated analyses). These fixed effects specifically pertain to the countries

and regions where the elections occurred, thereby controlling for general time trends across all observations and capturing unobserved time-invariant heterogeneity.

To define our region fixed effects, we account for the long period under examination (1945–2022) by treating Post-Soviet countries as a distinct category, as suggested by [Raciborski \(2008\)](#) and aligned with the United Nations Statistics regions. Consequently, our analyses distinguish seven regions: Europe, America, Africa, the Middle East, Asia, Oceania, and the Post-Soviet region. This approach offers a more precise means of isolating regional heterogeneity and invariant characteristics.¹⁴

Finally, we implement the robust and bias-corrected regression discontinuity (RD) estimator developed by [Calonico et al. \(2014\)](#). This methodological approach incorporates MSE-optimal bandwidth selection, exhibits reduced sensitivity to bandwidth choices, and corrects for potential bias through higher-order polynomial adjustments and robust variance estimators. In disaggregated and aggregated analyses, standard errors are clustered at the country level to account for possible intra-country correlations.

5 Results

This section presents the empirical relationship between left-wing electoral victories and international trade policies. We first demonstrate the significant discontinuity in cabinet formation when left-wing parties secure majorities in the legislature, validating our regression discontinuity design. Our analysis then examines two key questions: how left-wing governments affect national trade positions overall, and how these effects vary across different political systems.

We present estimation tables that illustrate the average causal effect of left-wing administrations on trade openness, tariff policies, and trade flows (imports and exports) during the four years after elections (denoted as $h = 1, 2, 3, 4$). In our estimation tables, we report the robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level, while the reported coefficients are the conventional estimated coefficients. This methodological approach aligns with standard practices in the empirical literature. Further, all coefficients are reported in percentage points to facilitate interpretation.

¹⁴We opted for region fixed effects, rather than country fixed effects, in the aggregated analyses because a number of countries in the panel have only a single election, which would otherwise remove them from the analysis. Nevertheless, we obtain even stronger results with consistent signals when estimating the outcome variables with time and country fixed effects than when estimated using year and region fixed effects.

Our primary analysis focuses on aggregated national-level effects, while complementary disaggregated analyses of bilateral trade flows are detailed in [Appendix D](#). These disaggregated results consistently support our main findings, although they show smaller average causal effects due to the pair-specific nature of bilateral trade relationships.

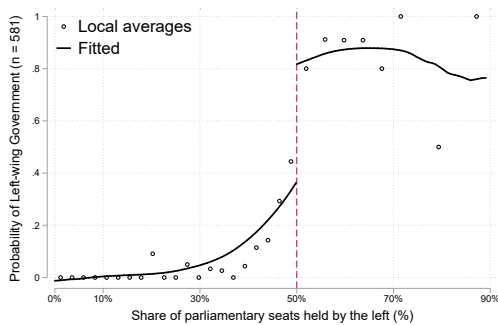
5.1 First Stage Regressions

The first-stage regression in [Figure 3](#) reveals a discontinuity triggered by left-wing majority victories in legislative (congressional) elections. Specifically, the probability of forming a left-led government increases sharply when left-wing parties surpass the threshold of holding more than half of the legislative seats.

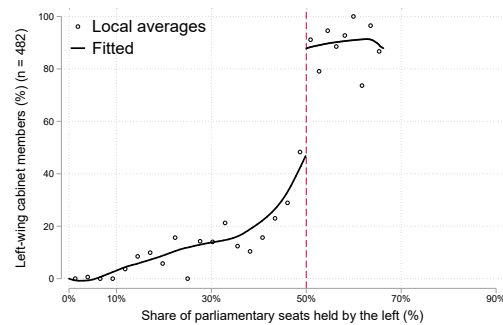
[Figure 3a](#) highlights this discontinuity, illustrating the notable rise in the likelihood of establishing a left-leaning cabinet once (center-)left parties achieve a seat majority above 50%. Complementing this result, [Figure 3b](#) shows a corresponding increase in the proportion of left-wing members within the first cabinet formed following the election.

Figure 3. Threshold Discontinuities in Parliamentary Elections

(a) Probability of Left-Led Government



(b) Cabinet: Left-Wing Members(%)



Notes: [Figure 3a](#) presents the probability of a left-led government when left-wing parties won the majority in parliament, while [Figure 3b](#) illustrates the proportion of left-wing cabinet members within the government formed post-election, alongside the percentage of left-wing members overall. Both figures are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression, employing a robust bias-corrected estimator and clustering standard errors by country of origin. The graph highlights the discontinuity in parliamentary elections.

*

To validate the robustness of our RDD, we performed two essential manipulation tests: the [McCrary \(2008\)](#) test and the [Cattaneo et al. \(2020\)](#) test. The results of both tests are reported in [Appendix B](#) and indicate no statistically significant

discontinuity in the distribution of the running variable at the electoral threshold. These findings support the internal validity of our empirical strategy, confirming that the assignment around the cutoff remains quasi-random. Importantly, these tests consistently suggest an absence of systematic manipulation of electoral margins, a fundamental prerequisite for credible causal inference in our RDD framework. The consistency of this evidence across both presidential and legislative election settings reinforces the reliability of our approach, affirming that political agents are unable to manipulate their position relative to the critical electoral threshold precisely.

5.2 Tariff Responses to Left-Wing Electoral Victories

Since tariff policies represent a key indicator of a government’s orientation toward international trade, they are an ideal metric for assessing the impact of left-wing electoral victories on trade policies. We employ the regression discontinuity design (RDD) methodology outlined in [Section 4.3](#), using [Equation 4](#) for our disaggregated bilateral-level analysis and [Equation 5](#) for the aggregated country analysis. The following analysis focuses on aggregated country effects to identify macroeconomic patterns, while disaggregated bilateral effects are detailed in [Section D.1](#).

Our analyses employ the combined tariff measure that captures the effective tariff rate imposed by countries on their trading partners, based on the minimum of preferential and Most Favored Nation (MFN) tariffs. This approach yields conservative estimates of trade barriers.

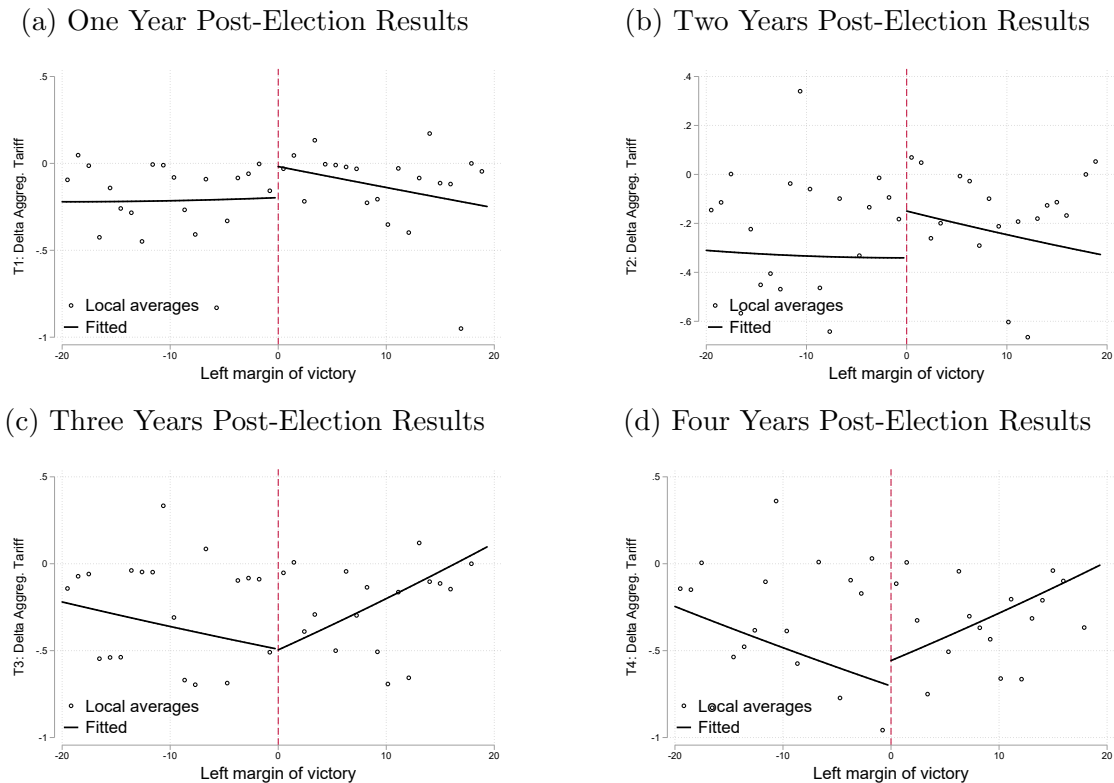
5.2.1 First-Order Tariff Effects Under Left-Wing Governments

We begin by examining how left-wing governments in importing countries (country j) adjust the aggregated tariff imposed across all nine industrial sectors. This tariff is calculated at the country-year level and weighted by each sector’s share, as specified in [Equation 5](#). This standard-weighted aggregation method emphasizes economically important sectors while minimizing potential distortions from sectors with minimal trade activity.

[Figure 4](#) reveals a positive discontinuity at the electoral threshold, indicating that countries systematically implement higher tariffs following left-wing electoral victories. This pattern is consistent across both presidential and legislative elections (see [Figure C1](#) and [Figure C2](#)), suggesting a robust relationship between left-wing governance and increased protectionism regardless of election type. Although visual

analysis clarifies this positive effect, we quantify it using three regression specifications, as described in [Section 4.4](#). We differentiate between presidential and legislative elections to understand how left-wing control of the Executive compared to the Legislature may lead to different protectionist responses.

Figure 4. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties and Aggregate Tariff Rate Adjustments (1966–2020)



Notes: [Figure 4a](#) to [Figure 4d](#) depict the response of import aggregate tariffs across industries following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in aggregated industry-specific tariffs during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

*

The estimated effects of left-wing governments on tariff policies reveal substantial heterogeneity across elections. In the full sample, left-wing administrations generate tariff increases of 0.08-0.40 percentage points in the baseline model, with remarkably consistent effects when year fixed effects are included. This pattern intensifies in presidential elections, where the impact ranges from 0.09 to 1.08 percentage points,

becoming most pronounced in year 4. Legislative elections, however, demonstrate remarkably stronger effects, reaching up to 1.50 percentage points two years after the election. These magnitudes are especially striking when contrasted with the negative dependent variable means (ranging from -0.15 to -0.41 for all elections), indicating that while global tariffs generally declined during this period, left-wing governments systematically reversed this liberalization trend.

The heterogeneity in tariff effects between presidential and legislative systems reveals institutional influences on left-wing trade policy implementation. Legislative elections show notably higher tariff increases, reflecting historical transitions in sample countries (post-Soviet states implementing EU structures, African and Latin American nations pursuing liberalization) and institutional factors. Further, left-wing legislative majorities may also signal broader societal protectionist preferences, as left-wing candidates consistently advocate more protectionist positions (Figure 1). These institutional dynamics will be examined further in Section 7.

Table 6. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Tariff Rates: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1966–2020, TPe: Data from WITS)

Outcome: h (years)	Change in Aggregated Tariff Rates between t-1 and t+h								
	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	0.25 (0.31)	0.40 (0.33)	0.14 (0.36)	0.27 (0.37)	0.46*** (0.22)	0.43*** (0.21)	0.19 (0.45)	0.89** (0.73)	0.36 (0.49)
+2	0.30 (0.40)	0.32 (0.43)	-0.04 (0.44)	0.18 (0.54)	0.14 (0.30)	0.14 (0.31)	0.85 (0.69)	1.50** (1.00)	0.76 (0.62)
+3	0.08 (0.55)	0.19 (0.60)	0.18 (0.60)	0.09 (0.74)	0.38 (0.46)	0.57* (0.47)	0.57 (0.64)	1.45* (1.31)	0.99 (0.88)
+4	0.30 (0.71)	0.40 (0.74)	0.16 (0.80)	0.43 (1.01)	0.81** (0.58)	1.08*** (0.59)	0.20 (0.58)	0.97 (1.06)	0.53 (0.72)
First stage	0.57*** (0.09)	0.49*** (0.08)	0.50*** (0.09)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.27 (0.15)	0.16 (0.10)	0.19 (0.11)
Out. Mean: h = 1	-0.15	-0.15	-0.15	-0.18	-0.18	-0.18	-0.13	-0.13	-0.13
Out. Mean: h = 2	-0.22	-0.22	-0.22	-0.26	-0.26	-0.26	-0.20	-0.20	-0.20
Out. Mean: h = 3	-0.29	-0.29	-0.29	-0.32	-0.32	-0.32	-0.27	-0.27	-0.27
Out. Mean: h = 4	-0.41	-0.41	-0.41	-0.51	-0.51	-0.51	-0.35	-0.35	-0.35
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	816	816	816	309	309	309	507	507	507
Eff. obs	403	358	288	197	154	163	230	196	145

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the import aggregated tariffs adopted by the country after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and “All Elections”) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. “First stage” refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. “Eff. obs” denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. “Out. Mean” is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

5.3 Trade Flow Responses to Left-Wing Electoral Victories

We begin by plotting the RDD estimates for $h \in \{1, 2, 3, 4\}$ years post-election, employing the exports-to-GDP and imports-to-GDP metrics defined in [Section 4.2.2](#). Following this visual inspection, we analyze the aggregated trade-flow variables to quantify the average causal effect of left-wing governments on export and import dynamics.¹⁵

5.3.1 Exports-to-GDP Responses

[Figure 5](#) displays a positive discontinuity in the exports-to-GDP ratio under left-wing administrations. This effect strengthens over time, with the most pronounced positive discontinuity occurring in the third year following the election.

The evidence in [Table 7](#) shows a statistically significant relationship between left-wing governance and export performance. These statistical findings align with the discontinuity patterns observed in the RDD plots. Analysis of the aggregate sample indicates that left-wing administrations increase exports-to-GDP by a magnitude of 1.67 to 4.35 percentage points, with statistical significance most pronounced in specifications controlling for time fixed effects. These findings suggest that left-leaning governments implement policies conducive to enhanced export performance.

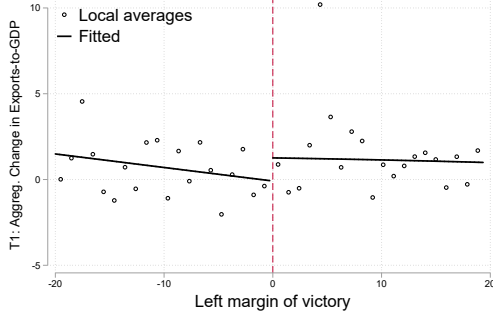
Legislative elections display stronger effects with left-wing electoral victories associated with increases in exports-to-GDP ratios ranging between 3.98 and 18.44, depending on the model specification. This effect maintains statistical significance throughout the four-year post-election period, indicating persistent export-promotion policy implementation. Notably, legislative elections in the sample are predominantly concentrated in European countries, where geographical proximity, established trade agreements, and cultural affinities likely amplify the export-enhancing effects of left-wing policies.

The econometric results indicate a distinct temporal pattern in presidential elections: an initial positive effect on the exports-to-GDP ratio manifests in the year immediately following the election, but this effect systematically diminishes and ultimately reverses direction in subsequent years. This temporal evolution suggests the presence of significant implementation lags in export promotion policies under left-wing presidential administrations.

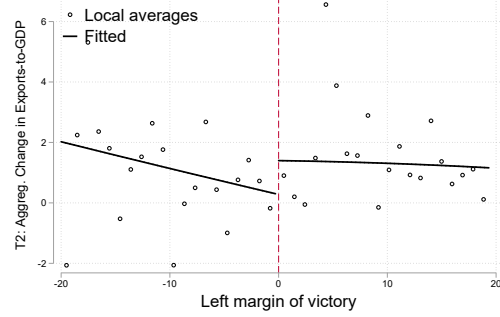
¹⁵Using importer-only IMF and Comtrade data (see [Appendix H](#)) produces equivalent RDD estimates.

Figure 5. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties and Aggregated Changes in Exports-to-GDP ratio (1948-2022)

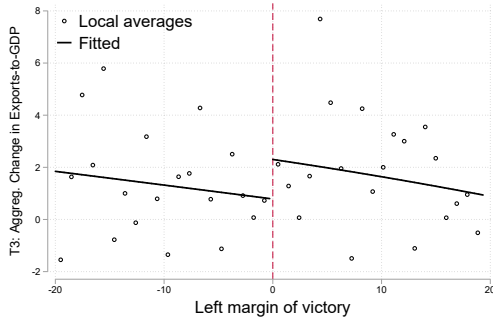
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



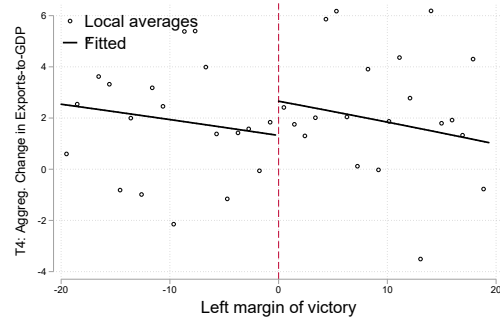
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Panels Figure 5a to Figure 5d depict the response of aggregated exports-to-GDP ratio following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in exports-to-GDP ratio during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

*

Our findings confirm that left-wing governments pursue pro-export policies across political systems, consistent with their strategy of achieving favorable trade balances. The contrast between presidential and legislative elections reveals that while left-wing executives initially promote exports, these effects are more modest than under legislative majorities and evolve differently over time, often diminishing or reversing in later years. This heterogeneity suggests that institutional structures fundamentally condition policy outcomes, as theorized by Milner and Judkins (2004) and illustrated in Figure 1.

Table 7. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Trade Combined)

Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Exports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	1.67 (1.75)	4.17*** (1.78)	3.31* (2.02)	0.76 (1.56)	4.20*** (1.53)	3.10** (1.46)	3.98 (4.77)	12.35** (7.86)	7.31 (6.89)
+2	1.10 (1.72)	3.54** (1.66)	3.70** (1.78)	-0.46 (1.48)	-0.16 (1.37)	-1.18 (1.35)	4.18 (5.19)	18.44*** (10.54)	14.71 (8.50)
+3	1.92 (2.27)	4.16** (2.23)	3.25 (2.19)	-0.04 (1.82)	0.25 (1.57)	-1.32 (1.51)	5.96 (6.25)	16.57*** (9.33)	11.99 (9.04)
+4	1.81 (2.61)	4.35* (2.66)	2.74 (2.50)	1.01 (2.70)	1.95 (2.50)	0.58 (2.41)	4.02 (6.43)	14.95** (11.29)	7.66 (7.66)
First stage	0.57*** (0.09)	0.49*** (0.07)	0.47*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.31** (0.14)	0.17 (0.09)	0.19 (0.10)
Out. Mean: h = 1	0.65	0.65	0.65	0.62	0.62	0.62	0.66	0.66	0.66
Out. Mean: h = 2	1.03	1.03	1.03	0.67	0.67	0.67	1.24	1.24	1.24
Out. Mean: h = 3	1.12	1.12	1.12	0.75	0.75	0.75	1.33	1.33	1.33
Out. Mean: h = 4	1.36	1.36	1.36	0.99	0.99	0.99	1.57	1.57	1.57
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	960	960	960	353	353	353	607	607	607
Eff. obs	489	460	377	178	125	127	281	247	210

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated exports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All Elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. "Out. Mean" is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

5.3.2 Imports-to-GDP Responses

Visual evidence from [Figure 6](#) summarizes the aggregate impact of left-wing governance on import behaviors. Notably, [Figure 6a](#) through [Figure 6c](#) illustrate that, according to the baseline model, imports exhibit a slight downward trend in the first three post-election years, with a marginal positive adjustment in the fourth year.

Turning to [Table 8](#), baseline estimates for the pooled election sample demonstrate a consistent pattern of adverse import effects. It suggests that a reduction in the import-to-GDP ratio characterizes the average causal effect of left-leaning governments on imports.

In presidential elections, left-wing victories lead to statistically significant decreases in imports-to-GDP ratios, with effects intensifying from -1.75 percentage points in the first year to -6.72 percentage points by the fourth year (significant at the 1% level), in the specification including time and region fixed effects. This

effect is economically substantial when compared to the dependent variable mean.

Conversely, legislative elections exhibit inconsistent and statistically non-significant effects, with point estimates suggesting an initial negative impact on imports-to-GDP, transitioning to positive effects in the subsequent years, though large standard errors hinder definitive conclusions.

The analysis of tariffs and exports, now complemented by import findings, sheds light on the trade strategy employed by left-wing governments. These administrations typically maintain higher tariffs while actively promoting exports and tend to lower imports-to-GDP ratios, especially when a leftist executive is in power. Over time, these effects become more pronounced and reveal a strong inclination toward protectionism. However, when left-wing parties hold a majority in the legislature, the impact on imports is notably more variable, exhibiting both increases and decreases across different analyses.¹⁶

5.4 Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Trade Openness

In the final stage of our analysis, we estimate the effect of left-wing administrations on the trade-to-GDP ratio, defined in [Section 4.2.3](#). For robustness, we replicate these estimates with data from the GMD ([Müller et al., 2025](#)). The analysis using GMD data is reported in [Section H.3](#) and consistently corroborates our primary findings across data sources.

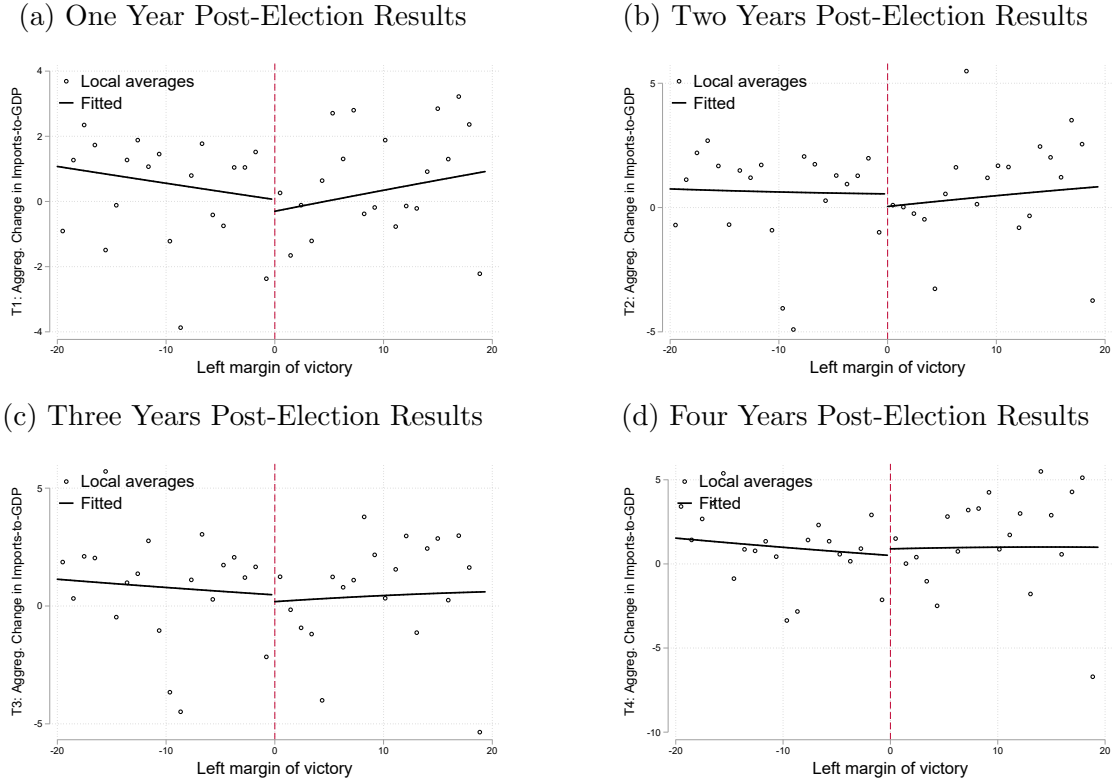
[Figure 7](#) highlights the overall change in trade openness for the pooled sample, revealing a generally positive effect of left-wing governments. However, this aggregate effect primarily reflects legislative elections, where trade openness progressively increases throughout left-wing administrations. Presidential election plots ([Figure C4](#)) show a modest initial positive effect, which subsequently becomes negative. Conversely, legislative election plots ([Figure C3](#)) indicate sustained positive effects.

[Table 9](#) summarizes these results numerically. While left-wing administrations generally increase openness across all elections, legislative elections mainly drive this effect.

When the analysis is restricted to presidential elections, the decline in openness becomes substantially more evident, with the effects growing stronger and statistically significant over time. The most rigorous specification with year and region fixed effects shows modest initial effects (1.02 percentage points in year 1) intensifying to

¹⁶Robustness is confirmed by additional analyses using importer-only IMF and Comtrade data, as noted in [Section H.2](#) and [Section D.3](#), which yield consistent results.

Figure 6. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties and Aggregated Changes in Imports-to-GDP ratio (1948-2022)



Notes: Panels Figure 6a to Figure 6d depict the response of aggregated imports-to-GDP ratio following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in imports-to-GDP ratio during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

Table 8. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Imports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Trade Combined)

Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	-0.79 (1.48)	0.21 (1.45)	-0.24 (1.45)	-0.58 (1.84)	0.08 (1.36)	-1.75 (1.27)	-2.09 (3.26)	-0.55 (3.76)	-1.73 (3.73)
+2	-0.86 (1.69)	0.51 (2.04)	1.34 (1.82)	-3.57* (2.23)	-3.11** (1.98)	-4.63*** (1.95)	0.12 (3.80)	4.28 (5.15)	3.11 (4.15)
+3	-0.56 (1.81)	-1.76 (2.39)	-0.25 (2.00)	-3.06 (2.29)	-3.41** (1.84)	-4.85*** (1.86)	0.59 (3.93)	0.16 (8.60)	1.64 (6.39)
+4	0.19 (2.11)	-0.31 (2.23)	-0.57 (2.08)	-1.63 (2.41)	-3.28** (1.67)	-6.72*** (1.68)	0.29 (4.38)	2.31 (8.50)	-0.76 (6.81)
First stage	0.57*** (0.09)	0.49*** (0.07)	0.49*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.30* (0.14)	0.17 (0.09)	0.19 (0.10)
Out. Mean: h = 1	0.51	0.51	0.51	0.15	0.15	0.15	0.73	0.73	0.73
Out. Mean: h = 2	0.60	0.60	0.60	-0.08	-0.08	-0.08	1.00	1.00	1.00
Out. Mean: h = 3	0.68	0.68	0.68	0.07	0.07	0.07	1.04	1.04	1.04
Out. Mean: h = 4	0.98	0.98	0.98	0.45	0.45	0.45	1.28	1.28	1.28
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	960	960	960	353	353	353	607	607	607
Eff. obs	511	458	468	158	132	139	280	227	213

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country’s aggregated imports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and “All Elections”) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. “First stage” refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. “Eff. obs” denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. “Out. Mean” is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

substantial reductions by year 4 (-6.09 percentage points, significant at the 5% level). This effect represents more than four times the baseline mean of 1.44 percentage points, indicating a fundamental reversal of typical trade patterns. These outcomes align with previous reduced import and export patterns, indicating that left-wing presidential administrations tend to adopt protectionist policies, which often require time to show their economic effects.

On the other hand, the left-wing Congress tends to generate positive effects on trade openness, although these estimates demonstrate lower precision. The impact of these effects becomes significant in the second and third years post-election, with increases of 22.56 and 19.74 percentage points, respectively, when accounting for year fixed effects and significant at the 5% and 10% levels. However, this statistical significance diminishes when full controls are applied. Together with earlier analyses of imports-to-GDP and exports-to-GDP, these findings indicate that a left-wing Congress significantly boosts exports while keeping import levels relatively stable.

These results likely reflect trends in developed countries with parliamentary political systems, especially those represented by European nations in our sample.

Our findings underscore significant heterogeneity in how political structures shape the trade policy outcomes of left-wing governments. While left-wing Presidents typically implement protectionist policies that tend to reduce exports, imports, and overall trade openness, their parliamentary counterparts appear to pursue export-oriented strategies that enhance economic openness despite similar ideological orientations. This difference likely stems from regional context: legislative elections in our sample predominantly occur in European countries where geographical proximity, historical relationships, and established trade agreements facilitate trade openness. Conversely, presidential elections are concentrated in Latin American and African countries, where economic integration faces greater challenges due to geographic distance from major markets and historical protectionist trends that limit economic integration opportunities.

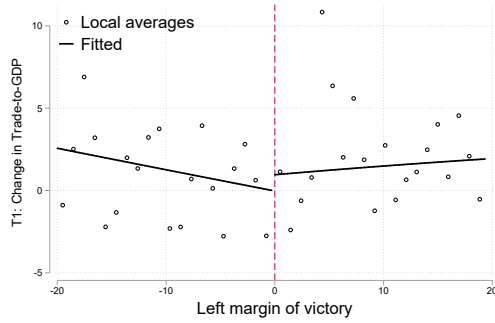
Table 9. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Trade Openness: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined Data)

Outcome: h (years)	Change in Trade Openness between t-1 and t+h								
	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	0.82 (2.49)	4.97** (2.54)	3.00 (2.53)	0.55 (2.55)	4.33* (2.62)	1.02 (2.53)	1.68 (7.16)	11.59* (9.83)	5.30 (8.20)
+2	0.00 (2.82)	4.90* (3.18)	4.72 (3.12)	-4.35* (3.11)	-3.05* (2.58)	-5.60*** (2.58)	4.52 (8.00)	22.56** (14.45)	16.09 (11.14)
+3	1.12 (3.42)	4.00 (3.84)	3.81 (3.71)	-2.81 (3.55)	-2.67 (2.79)	-5.98*** (2.75)	6.33 (9.28)	19.74* (16.46)	11.18 (14.18)
+4	1.79 (3.78)	4.43 (4.02)	3.15 (3.89)	-0.79 (4.09)	-1.27 (3.29)	-6.09** (3.12)	4.02 (9.82)	17.77 (18.00)	6.14 (11.77)
Out. Mean: h = 1	1.16	1.16	1.16	0.77	0.77	0.77	1.39	1.39	1.39
Out. Mean: h = 2	1.63	1.63	1.63	0.59	0.59	0.59	2.23	2.23	2.23
Out. Mean: h = 3	1.80	1.80	1.80	0.81	0.81	0.81	2.36	2.36	2.36
Out. Mean: h = 4	2.34	2.34	2.34	1.44	1.44	1.44	2.85	2.85	2.85
First stage	0.57*** (0.09)	0.48*** (0.07)	0.48*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.30* (0.14)	0.17 (0.09)	0.19 (0.10)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	960	960	960	353	353	353	607	607	607
Eff. obs	495	430	427	169	122	124	266	232	208

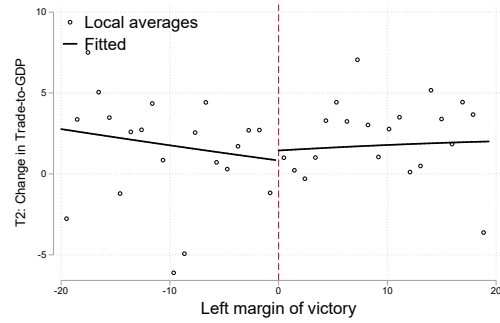
Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated Trade Openness after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All Elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. "Out. Mean" is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Figure 7. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties and Changes in Trade-to-GDP ratio (1948-2022)

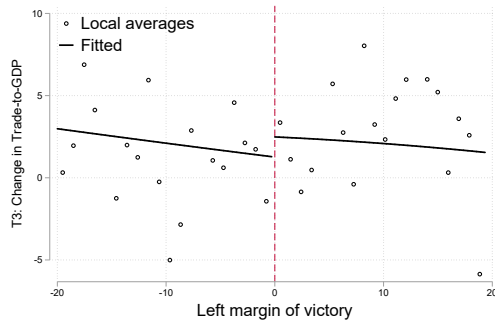
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



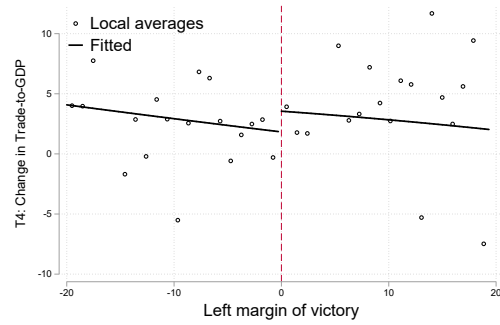
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure 7a to Figure 7d depict the response of trade-to-GDP ratio following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in trade-to-GDP ratio during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

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5.5 Heterogeneous Effects by Political Systems

Previous analyses demonstrate that left-wing governments generally implement more protectionist trade policies. However, the variation in these effects may stem from differences in political systems and not only from election types. As [Milner and Judkins \(2004\)](#) theorizes, the institutional framework also impacts policy implementation intensity and consistency. [Figure 1](#) illustrates this heterogeneity empirically: parliamentary systems display relatively stable trade positions across the ideological spectrum, while presidential and semi-presidential systems exhibit greater volatility in party positioning on trade openness.

To examine whether institutional context systematically moderates the effect of left-wing governance on trade policies, this section disaggregates analysis across three political systems—Presidential, Semi-Presidential, and Parliamentary. This approach assesses whether the protectionist tendencies identified in the main findings vary in magnitude and pattern according to institutional structures that differ in executive power concentration, coalition requirements, and policy implementation capacity.

Given the reduced sample sizes in this disaggregated analysis by systems, the empirical strategy employs decade rather than year fixed effects in the primary estimations, presenting three model specifications: (i) a baseline model without fixed effects; (ii) a model with decade fixed effects; and (iii) a model with both decade and region fixed effects.

5.5.1 Δ Tariff

The empirical results reveal significant heterogeneity in how left-wing governments influence tariff policies across political systems, with all three regimes demonstrating distinct patterns that counteract the global trend toward trade liberalization. Parliamentary systems exhibit the most pronounced protectionist response, with substantial tariff increases ranging from 0.19 to 0.99 percentage points, characterized by rapid escalation in the second year post-election and sustained elevation through year four. Presidential systems display more moderate but consistent tariff increases (0.17-0.61 percentage points). Notably, when presidential elections are analyzed without distinguishing between political systems ([Table 6](#)), the estimated coefficients appear larger than when Presidential and Semi-Presidential systems are examined separately. Semi-presidential regimes demonstrate the weakest and most inconsistent tariff responses (-0.15 to 0.32 percentage points) despite strong first-stage coefficients.

These divergent patterns reflect institutional variations in policy implementation capacity and political dynamics across systems. Parliamentary governments may benefit from more consolidated legislative support that facilitates expeditious policy enactment, potentially explaining their ability to reverse liberalization trends rather than merely mitigate them, as observed in the Multifiber Arrangement and CAP protectionist agreements. The magnitude of these effects becomes particularly significant when contrasted with the negative outcome means across all systems, indicating that while the global tendency moves toward decreasing tariffs, left-wing governments systematically implement protectionist measures. The results for both presidential and parliamentary systems converge with previous analyses examining election types, further reinforcing the conclusion that institutional contexts significantly constrain or enable left-wing governments' ability to enact their preferred trade policies.

Table 10. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Tariff Rates by Political System: Fuzzy RDD for Parliamentary and Semi-Presidential and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1966–2020, TPe: Data from WITS)

Outcome: h (years)	Change in Aggregated Tariff Rates between t-1 and t+h								
	Semi-Presidential			Presidential			Parliamentary		
+1	0.11 (0.16)	0.08 (0.17)	0.15 (0.18)	0.33 (0.49)	0.43 (0.47)	0.42 (0.50)	0.22 (0.50)	0.19 (0.65)	0.35 (0.70)
+2	0.31 (0.29)	0.19 (0.26)	0.32* (0.23)	0.20 (0.69)	0.24 (0.69)	0.30 (0.69)	0.59 (0.50)	0.86 (0.81)	0.81* (0.69)
+3	0.00 (0.25)	-0.12 (0.24)	-0.15 (0.32)	0.17 (0.97)	0.19 (0.97)	0.22 (0.96)	0.61 (0.77)	0.73 (0.96)	0.99 (1.18)
+4	-0.05 (0.67)	0.23 (0.60)	-0.15 (0.47)	0.61 (1.34)	0.54 (1.35)	0.51 (1.33)	0.75 (0.65)	0.45 (0.79)	0.87 (0.98)
First stage	0.80*** (0.12)	0.83*** (0.11)	0.83*** (0.08)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.28 (0.16)	0.20 (0.13)	0.20 (0.13)
Out. Mean: h = 1	-0.03	-0.03	-0.03	-0.26	-0.26	-0.26	-0.14	-0.14	-0.14
Out. Mean: h = 2	-0.11	-0.11	-0.11	-0.36	-0.36	-0.36	-0.20	-0.20	-0.20
Out. Mean: h = 3	-0.16	-0.16	-0.16	-0.43	-0.43	-0.43	-0.27	-0.27	-0.27
Out. Mean: h = 4	-0.23	-0.23	-0.23	-0.67	-0.67	-0.67	-0.36	-0.36	-0.36
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	159	159	159	228	228	228	396	396	396
Eff. obs	64	58	58	132	132	129	186	166	180

Notes: . The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for parliamentary and semi-presidential) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. "Out. Mean" is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

5.5.2 Δ Exports-to-GDP

Table 11 reveals distinct patterns in how left-wing electoral victories affect exports-to-GDP across different political systems. While presidential and parliamentary systems show increases in exports under left-wing governments, semi-presidential systems demonstrate significant negative effects. In presidential systems, left-wing governments achieve a 3.83 percentage point increase in the first year, substantially outperforming the 0.43pp average for all countries in this category. Parliamentary systems exhibit positive effects that gradually increase through year three (reaching 5.9 percentage points in the specification with time-region fixed effects). In stark contrast, semi-presidential systems show significant negative effects, peaking at -6.50 percentage points in the second year.

These heterogeneous findings help explain why previous results in Table 7 showed negative effects for presidential elections in years 2-3, likely driven by semi-presidential system elections within that sample. The contrasting patterns align with institutional differences reflected in the first-stage results: perfect compliance in presidential systems (coefficient=1.00), strong compliance in semi-presidential systems (0.87), and weaker compliance in parliamentary systems (0.33). Notably, countries in our semi-presidential category are primarily Post-Socialist nations and France, which historically promotes protectionist policies in specific industries. Overall, these findings support the idea that left-wing governments adopt policies to achieve positive trade balances, while demonstrating that the direction and effectiveness of ideologically driven policies depend significantly on the institutional structures through which they are implemented.

Table 11. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Exports by Political Systems: Fuzzy RDD for Parliamentary and Semi-Presidential Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Trade Combined)

Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Exports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	Semi-Presidential			Presidential			Parliamentary		
+1	-3.97* (2.49)	-4.85*** (2.26)	-2.65 (2.31)	3.00 (2.03)	3.83** (1.87)	3.24* (1.79)	2.17 (4.37)	2.73 (5.98)	2.59 (6.14)
+2	-5.25 (3.65)	-6.50*** (2.99)	-4.78 (3.29)	1.46 (1.72)	1.49 (1.63)	1.20 (1.52)	2.51 (3.91)	4.41 (5.40)	4.24 (5.67)
+3	-3.19 (4.25)	-5.29** (3.10)	-4.89* (3.08)	2.41 (2.03)	2.53 (2.08)	1.76 (1.96)	3.39 (5.31)	5.88 (6.74)	5.90 (6.96)
+4	-0.32 (5.06)	-2.21 (4.79)	-7.53*** (3.62)	3.85 (3.08)	3.96 (3.12)	3.25 (2.98)	2.03 (6.27)	4.11 (6.78)	4.36 (6.86)
First stage	0.84*** (0.12)	0.87*** (0.12)	0.85*** (0.09)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.33** (0.14)	0.27 (0.14)	0.25 (0.14)
Out. Mean: h = 1	1.64	1.64	1.64	0.43	0.43	0.43	0.45	0.45	0.45
Out. Mean: h = 2	1.73	1.73	1.73	0.64	0.64	0.64	1.02	1.02	1.02
Out. Mean: h = 3	2.27	2.27	2.27	0.43	0.43	0.43	1.20	1.20	1.20
Out. Mean: h = 4	3.02	3.02	3.02	0.57	0.57	0.57	1.34	1.34	1.34
Decade FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	161	161	161	269	269	269	492	492	492
Eff. obs	82	83	71	142	140	140	242	229	210

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated exports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for parliamentary and semi-presidential) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. "Out. Mean" is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

5.5.3 Δ Imports-to-GDP

Table 12 reveals that left-wing administrations reduce imports-to-GDP ratios across all political systems, though with varying intensities. Presidential systems display the strongest import contraction, with coefficients closely matching those in Table 8. Semi-presidential systems display similar decreasing patterns to presidential systems. Parliamentary systems demonstrate a more problematic pattern, with estimations for left-wing governments indicating slight, inconsistent decreases.

When considered alongside export patterns, these findings substantiate that left-wing governments in presidential systems pursue positive trade balances through export promotion and import restriction. However, this behavior appears less consistent in parliamentary systems, where the evidence is more ambiguous. Parliamentary systems under left-wing governance show substantial export increases but only marginal, noisy decreases in imports. Finally, the semi-presidential system displays the most

protectionist tendencies, decreasing both exports and imports.

Table 12. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Imports by Political System: Fuzzy RDD for Parliamentary and Semi-Presidential Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Trade Combined)

Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	Semi-Presidential			Presidential			Parliamentary		
+1	-0.62 (2.37)	-0.31 (1.96)	-0.70 (3.31)	-0.70 (2.25)	-1.54 (2.22)	-1.59 (2.20)	-3.19 (4.16)	-3.43 (4.07)	-3.23 (3.75)
+2	-5.46 (4.64)	-4.12 (4.24)	-2.62 (4.50)	-3.00 (2.43)	-3.15* (2.34)	-2.24 (2.33)	-0.07 (4.52)	1.51 (4.42)	1.60 (4.37)
+3	-4.02 (3.85)	-2.85 (3.99)	-1.83 (5.61)	-3.20 (2.84)	-2.91 (2.54)	-2.32 (2.51)	-0.64 (4.20)	-0.23 (4.06)	-0.37 (4.50)
+4	0.29 (4.21)	0.28 (3.82)	1.30 (3.00)	-3.67 (3.24)	-4.35** (3.03)	-4.54** (2.81)	-1.02 (5.16)	0.65 (4.62)	0.60 (5.36)
First stage	0.84*** (0.12)	0.87*** (0.12)	0.99*** (0.08)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.30 (0.17)	0.27 (0.14)	0.27 (0.13)
Out. Mean: h = 1	0.78	0.78	0.78	0.22	0.22	0.22	0.54	0.54	0.54
Out. Mean: h = 2	1.39	1.39	1.39	-0.31	-0.31	-0.31	0.82	0.82	0.82
Out. Mean: h = 3	1.96	1.96	1.96	-0.43	-0.43	-0.43	0.82	0.82	0.82
Out. Mean: h = 4	2.81	2.81	2.81	-0.25	-0.25	-0.25	1.06	1.06	1.06
Decade FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	161	161	161	269	269	269	492	492	492
Eff. obs	71	100	45	126	113	112	194	231	230

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated imports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for parliamentary and semi-presidential) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. "Out. Mean" is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

5.5.4 Δ Trade-to-GDP

Table 13 reveals striking differences in how left-wing governments affect trade openness depending on the political system they operate within. Semi-presidential systems show the strongest protectionist tendencies under left-wing leadership. These governments reduce trade openness by a substantial 10.34 percentage points, compared to the sample average of just 2.41 percentage points. This dramatic difference highlights how powerfully ideology shapes economic policy in these systems, which are common in post-socialist countries. Presidential systems also exhibit protectionist tendencies, though less dramatically, with trade openness decreasing by 1.59 percentage points by the second year of left-wing governance. This aligns with our earlier finding that left-wing presidential administrations pursue trade surpluses by promoting exports

while restricting imports.

Parliamentary systems follow a notably different pattern. While they initially show a decrease in trade openness during the first year of left-wing governance, they pivot to expansion in the second year, with a significant 3.26 percentage point increase. This delayed shift toward greater openness might reflect either the time needed to build consensus among coalition partners or simple administrative delays in implementing new trade policies. These contrasting outcomes across systems show how political institutions fundamentally shape how left-wing economic ideologies translate into actual trade policies, with parliamentary systems ultimately proving more compatible with trade liberalization than their counterparts.

Table 13. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Trade Openness by Political System: Fuzzy RDD for Parliamentary and Semi-Presidential Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined Data)

Outcome: h (years)	Change in Trade Openness between t-1 and t+h								
	Semi-Presidential			Presidential			Parliamentary		
+1	-3.47* (2.98)	-3.88* (2.95)	-4.86 (4.15)	2.50 (3.34)	3.14 (3.26)	2.46 (3.15)	-0.34 (6.23)	-0.80 (8.45)	-0.46 (8.15)
+2	-10.34* (6.41)	-10.72** (6.10)	-7.00 (6.73)	-1.59 (3.43)	-1.59 (3.36)	-1.36 (3.24)	3.26 (7.97)	5.68 (8.50)	6.42 (9.48)
+3	-7.83 (6.44)	-8.04 (5.86)	-4.20 (6.64)	-0.64 (4.38)	0.42 (4.32)	0.04 (4.12)	4.07 (8.88)	5.12 (8.86)	5.38 (10.39)
+4	-1.47 (4.20)	-6.40 (4.78)	-4.67 (3.80)	-0.12 (5.38)	1.27 (5.33)	-0.07 (4.78)	1.32 (8.55)	3.77 (9.86)	4.86 (10.83)
First stage	0.86*** (0.12)	0.87*** (0.11)	0.97*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.33** (0.14)	0.27 (0.14)	0.26 (0.13)
Out. Mean: h = 1	2.41	2.41	2.41	0.65	0.65	0.65	0.99	0.99	0.99
Out. Mean: h = 2	3.12	3.12	3.12	0.33	0.33	0.33	1.83	1.83	1.83
Out. Mean: h = 3	4.23	4.23	4.23	0.00	0.00	0.00	2.03	2.03	2.03
Out. Mean: h = 4	5.83	5.83	5.83	0.31	0.31	0.31	2.40	2.40	2.40
Decade FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	161	161	161	269	269	269	492	492	492
Eff. obs	104	102	48	129	126	124	237	230	225

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated Trade Openness after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for parliamentary and semi-presidential) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. "Out. Mean" is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Our analysis reveals systematic variation in how left-wing governments implement trade policies across different political systems. While the aggregate analysis confirms that left-wing administrations generally adopt more protectionist trade measures,

institutional structures significantly mediate these effects and their magnitudes.

Presidential systems under left-wing governance implement strategically asymmetric interventions, promoting exports while restricting imports, consistent with the hypothesis of executive power concentration facilitating direct implementation of import substitution policies. Parliamentary systems demonstrate more moderate trade policy shifts in imports, maintaining greater economic openness despite the highest tariffs, reflecting institutional and regional characteristics. Semi-presidential systems, predominantly comprising post-socialist economies, display the most pronounced protectionism, substantially reducing overall trade openness. These systematic variations shed light on how institutional structures fundamentally condition the translation of left-wing economic ideology into policy outcomes.

The mechanisms through which institutional frameworks condition these heterogeneous effects, including the influence of geographic factors, historical trade integration, and pre-existing international agreements, will be examined in depth in the [Section 7](#).

6 Robustness and Falsification Tests

To validate our empirical findings, we implemented four complementary robustness checks. First, we evaluated whether post-Socialist countries disproportionately influenced our estimates. Second, we addressed potential outliers through systematic exclusion and winsorization procedures. Third, we tested alternative bandwidth selection criteria to ensure optimal model specification. Fourth, we re-estimated our core models using alternative datasets and outcome metrics, and we incorporated more comprehensive fixed-effects specifications alongside additional control variables. All tables and figures related to these robustness checks are presented in the Appendix for clarity and readability.

6.1 Left-Wing Trade Policy: Excluding Post-Socialist States

Post-socialist states underwent extraordinary economic transformations in the 1990s, transitioning from centrally planned to market economies through rapid liberalization and policy adjustments upon EU accession. We conducted additional analyses excluding these countries (approximately 20% of our sample) to determine whether these unique transitions distort our understanding of left-wing trade policy effects. This approach isolates the relationship between political ideology and trade protec-

tionism under more stable institutional conditions, with detailed results available in [Appendix E](#).

[Table E1](#) demonstrates that tariff effects remain consistent when excluding Post-Socialist states, though legislative election coefficients are slightly lower. The fundamental relationship persists: left-wing governments adopt protectionist policies despite declining global tariffs.

For exports-to-GDP ([Table E2](#)), estimates remain consistent across political systems and election types, confirming our previous findings. Presidential election results align with those in [Table 11](#), suggesting that previously observed negative effects were likely driven by semi-presidential systems in Post-Socialist countries. Legislative elections consistently show left-wing governments increase exports-to-GDP by reaching 5.42pp, three years after the election in the baseline model.

The imports-to-GDP analysis ([Table E3](#)) reveals that left-wing governments generally show reduced import ratios across regions, with presidential elections consistently producing the most substantial declines. The trade-to-GDP findings ([Table E4](#)) corroborate our earlier results from [Table 9](#) and [Table 13](#), confirming systematic institutional heterogeneity: left-wing executive authorities consistently decrease overall trade openness, while left-wing legislative majorities significantly increase trade openness despite implementing the highest tariff increases on imports.

Our findings presented in [Appendix E](#) consistently support our primary results, with one significant exception: presidential elections now exhibit positive associations between left-wing administrations and exports-to-GDP ratios. This observation aligns with expectations, as indicated in [Table 11](#), where Post-Socialist states, particularly within the semi-presidential sample, displayed negative coefficients. The exclusion of these states reveals a positive impact of left-wing governments on exports in presidential systems, offering a partial explanation for the results outlined in [Table 7](#). These findings affirm the robustness of our results.

6.2 Addressing Influential Observations

To validate our findings against potential outliers, we conducted robustness checks using winsorizing and trimming at three percentile thresholds—(1, 99), (3, 97), and (5, 95)—with comprehensive results available in [Appendix F](#).

Our analyses consistently reveal that left-wing governments implement nuanced trade policies that vary by political system. In legislative elections, left-wing victories reliably increase exports-to-GDP and overall trade-to-GDP ratios. Import effects,

however, present a special interpretation: legislative results show import increases ([Table 8](#)), while parliamentary systems exhibit decreases ([Table 12](#)), a pattern persisting across all robustness adjustments.

Presidential elections display different patterns. We observe reductions in trade flows alongside tariff increases, with important system distinctions. Export reductions appear primarily in semi-presidential systems, while purely presidential systems under left-wing leadership show increased exports-to-GDP despite higher tariffs and lower imports-to-GDP and trade-to-GDP ratios.

When examining all elections together, results show moderate increases in exports and the trade-to-GDP ratio, with decreases in imports-to-GDP accompanied by higher tariffs. These findings suggest that left-wing governments often implement trade policies that selectively manage trade flows while using tariffs as a policy instrument.

These patterns remain consistent across all robustness specifications, supporting our conclusion that left-wing governments generally adopt differentiated approaches to trade policy that balance protectionist measures over imports and domestic industries with export promotion strategies.

6.3 Alternative Approaches to Bandwidth Selection and Specifications

Sensitivity analysis comparing the baseline RDD model ([Section 4.3](#)) to four alternative bandwidth specifications confirms the stability of results across different methodological choices. While the primary analysis employs the common MSE-optimal bandwidth from [Calonico et al. \(2014\)](#), additional tests examined: (i) separate MSE-optimal bandwidths for each side of the threshold; (ii) MSE-optimal bandwidth for the sum of regression estimates; (iii) common CER-optimal bandwidth; and (iv) distinct CER-optimal bandwidths for each side of the cutoff. Findings remain consistent across all bandwidth specifications, validating that results are robust to bandwidth selection criteria. Detailed results are presented in [Appendix G](#).

6.4 Robustness Across Different Election Types and Time Horizons

The results presented in [Section 5](#) demonstrate robust effects of left-wing administrations on trade policies across multiple dimensions. To ensure the validity of our findings, we implemented an extensive set of robustness checks encompassing varied samples, specifications, and data sources.

Our baseline analysis studied trade effects across three distinct electoral classifications: (i) all elections, (ii) presidential elections, and (iii) legislative elections, with further disaggregation by political system type. Each configuration was subjected to two fixed effects specifications: (i) time fixed effects, and (ii) time and region fixed effects.

To address potential data concerns, we replicated our analyses using three alternative datasets: (i) IMF importer data (1948-2020), (ii) Comtrade importer data (1962-2020), and (iii) GMD database (1944-2022). These results, presented in [Appendix H](#), consistently confirm our primary findings.

Additional robustness checks include analyses with varying sample time horizons and disaggregated trade metrics, available in [Appendix D](#). Across all specifications and four key trade policy indicators—(i) trade openness (Trade-to-GDP), (ii) tariff rates, (iii) exports-to-GDP, and (iv) imports-to-GDP ratios—consistently found that left-wing administrations implement more protectionist policies, characterized by higher tariffs, increased exports-to-GDP, decreased imports-to-GDP, and reduced overall trade openness.

While some heterogeneity exists across election types and political systems, the core findings remain stable throughout all robustness checks, confirming the systematic relationship between left-wing governance and trade policy orientation.

7 Discussion

Although a few landmark studies (e.g., [Milner and Judkins \(2004\)](#); [Dutt and Mitra \(2005\)](#)) suggest that partisanship shapes trade policy, systematic evidence remains thin. To fill this gap, we estimate the average causal effect of left-wing victories on trade variables. Two questions guide the study: (i) Does policy change and its magnitude depend on which branch the left controls—the executive or the legislature? (ii) Do presidential, parliamentary, or semi-presidential constitutional rules amplify or dampen those partisan effects?

The All-Elections results indicate that left-leaning administrations raise tariffs significantly, but the highest tariffs are associated with legislative wins. Under these legislations, exports and the trade-to-GDP ratio generally increase, while the impact on imports is mixed due to the balance between high tariffs and regional integration, like in the EU.

In contrast, left-leaning executives typically see a sharp decline in imports and

reduced overall trade openness, despite occasional temporary export increases. Overall, Congress-led left governments prefer a “protective openness” approach, whereas presidential left-wing administrations lean towards traditional import substitution policies, but both support pro-export policies.

Understanding these divergent trade patterns requires a historical context, knowledge of regional trade agreements, and an examination of the political systems’ incentive structures. The following sections will analyze presidential, parliamentary, and semi-presidential regimes, highlighting how these institutional frameworks shape the translation of left-wing preferences into trade outcomes.

7.1 Presidential Systems: Mechanisms, Evidence, and Implications

Presidential systems provide institutional frameworks that enable left-wing executives to implement trade policies more directly and faster than other political systems. The concentration of authority in the executive branch allows presidents to translate ideological preferences into concrete trade measures with fewer coalition-building requirements, particularly in the short term.¹⁷ Consequently, left-wing presidents consistently implement strategic trade interventions to increase exports while decreasing imports.

Our findings reveal a strategic approach by left-wing presidents: they consistently increase tariffs while substantially reducing imports-to-GDP ratios, effects that intensify over time as policies evolve. Simultaneously, presidential systems show significant export growth (nearly six times above the average dependent variable mean). This pattern shows an asymmetric intervention strategy, promoting positive trade balances rather than simple protectionism, aligning with import substitution industrialization (ISI) approaches.

When considering tariffs, the regional and historical context helps explain why left-wing governments operating under presidential systems typically implement lower tariff increases than those in legislative or parliamentary systems. This trend can be traced back to the extensive liberalization efforts undertaken by developing countries with presidential systems during the 1980s and 1990s. An example is the 1989 election in Brazil, where Fernando Collor’s victory triggered significant liberalization, resulting in a reduction of nominal tariffs by about 30 percentage points across key sectors, following decades of protectionist policies (Dix-Carneiro and Kovak, 2017).

¹⁷Recent tariff policy changes under Donald Trump’s administration demonstrate this mechanism, illustrating how presidential authority can facilitate fast adjustments to international trade policies.

Regional tariff differentials further explain these cross-system variations. In 2022, preferential tariffs averaged 2.7% in Europe versus 6.0% in South/Central America and 9.5% in Sub-Saharan Africa.¹⁸ The elevated baseline tariff levels in Latin America and Africa suggest that further significant increases often do not meaningfully alter market dynamics for countries in these regions, which already operate at inherently higher tariff thresholds. The recent trade tensions between China and the United States illustrate this phenomenon.

Finally, multilateral institutions such as the WTO can attenuate sharp changes in trade policy across political systems, moderating the implementation of dramatic adjustments to countries' trade policies.

In sum, presidential systems enable left-wing governments to implement distinctive trade strategies characterized by asymmetric interventions, tariff increases, substantial import restrictions, and export promotion. This pattern reflects institutional advantages in policy implementation, historical liberalization contexts, and regional economic conditions.

7.2 Parliamentary Systems: Mechanisms, Evidence, and Implications

Parliamentary systems create a distinctive institutional environment that fundamentally shapes how left-wing governments implement trade policies. Unlike presidential systems, where executive authority enables direct policy implementation, parliamentary governance requires broader coalition support, systematically moderating ideological preferences through institutional constraints. This structural feature explains the lower first-stage compliance coefficients observed in parliamentary elections (0.33). Despite these constraints, empirical analysis reveals a striking pattern: left-wing parliamentary governments implement the highest tariff increases across all political systems while increasing exports-to-GDP and overall trade-to-GDP ratios.

This seemingly contradictory combination of protectionism and trade promotion constitutes what we define as “protective openness”, an approach that selectively shields strategic domestic industries while pursuing broader economic integration. This pattern challenges conventional assumptions associating parliamentary systems with uniformly liberal trade policies, regardless of political orientation. Conventional wisdom would suggest that high tariffs should reduce trade flows across borders. However, despite implementing these higher tariffs, left-wing parliamentary governments show inconsistent effects on imports-to-GDP, sometimes increasing or decreasing,

¹⁸For further details, see [CEPII Region Profiles](#).

while maintaining robust export performance. This apparent contradiction reflects the sample’s unique characteristics of parliamentary countries, particularly the complex interplay between institutional structures, sector-specific protections, and the historical integration among European countries that facilitates trade despite tariff barriers.

To understand this “protective openness”, it is essential to note that while parliamentary systems exist across many continents, the most significant number are in Europe within our sample. Thus, the context from that region partially drives the results. Following the Cold War, many post-socialist nations underwent profound market liberalization. Estonia exemplifies this transition, eliminating nearly all tariffs during the 1990s but later adjusting them upward upon joining the European Union to align with the EU’s common trade policy framework (Fund, 1998). These outlier cases partially explain the high tariff increases associated with left-wing legislative majorities and, consequently, with left-wing parliamentary governments.

Building on these historical cases, our analysis reveals that under left-wing legislative governments, import tariffs increased by 1.50 percentage points, directly contradicting the general trend of decreasing tariffs (average decrease of 0.20 percentage points) observed across the sample. Even after excluding post-socialist countries from the analysis, higher tariff increases under legislative elections persisted, though with lower magnitudes. This consistent pattern in legislative elections indicates that structural factors beyond transition economies may influence parliamentary system results.

These structural factors become evident when examining sectoral policies in European parliamentary systems. Despite Europe’s general pro-trade orientation, specific sectors, especially agriculture and textiles, consistently maintain protectionist measures. The EU’s Common Agricultural Policy and the Multifiber Arrangement exemplify these targeted protectionist practices contributing to the overall tariff increases observed in the data (Kirmani and Wong, 1997). Recent analysis from 2022 reinforces this sectoral heterogeneity: while South and Central America imposed 9.5% tariffs on food and agriculture, Europe averaged 18.3%, significantly above the global average of 11.9%.¹⁹ This sectoral policy approach clarifies how parliamentary systems can pursue broader economic integration while maintaining selective protectionism, particularly under left-wing administrations.

A signaling effect amplifies this sector-specific protection: left-wing parties pub-

¹⁹For further details, see [CEPII Region Profiles](#)

licly express more protectionist agendas (Figure 1), and their parliamentary majorities send signals to politicians about societal preferences, which raises protectionist tendencies in government and in already shielded sectors. Additionally, the historically lower tariff rates in developed and European parliamentary systems create a greater margin for increases, making such policies more feasible for left-wing administrations to implement. While these political dynamics push toward selective protectionism, they operate within geographic contexts that simultaneously facilitate trade integration.

Geographically, parliamentary democracies predominantly exist in regions where lower transaction costs, proximity to major markets, and established historical trade relationships facilitate greater economic integration. For instance, the European Union can exploit easier market access to boost trade-to-GDP and exports while keeping imports relatively stable. These inherent geographical advantages create a complex interplay with the protectionist policies implemented by left-wing governments, allowing them to pursue selective protection without sacrificing the overall benefits of economic integration.

This geographic-policy tension manifests in the inconsistent effects on imports-to-GDP, which reflect competing economic forces operating simultaneously: left-wing parliaments impose tariffs that theoretically reduce imports, while regional integration advantages facilitate import flows. The outcome depends on which force predominates in a specific context; imports may rise when integration benefits outweigh tariff barriers. Otherwise, when protectionist measures predominate, imports decline. This distinctive “protective openness” strategy allows left-wing parliamentary governments to shield strategic domestic industries while maintaining robust international engagement simultaneously, an approach distinguishing left-wing parliamentary governance from the more straightforward protectionism observed in left-wing presidential systems.

7.3 Semi-Presidential Systems: Mechanisms, Evidence, and Implications

Semi-presidential systems display distinctively irregular trade positioning among political systems, mainly due to the predominance of post-socialist countries within this category and unique historical legacies that reshape conventional ideological trade preferences. Our analysis indicates that left-wing governments adopt the most protectionist trade policies within these systems.

As previously discussed, most post-socialist countries that later integrated into the

European Union adopted semi-presidential structures, creating complex policy trajectories. Poland exemplifies this pattern in semi-presidentialism; its gradual market liberalization, associated with persistent agricultural protectionism, resulted in substantial tariff adjustments upon EU accession. These historical contexts profoundly shape current trade positioning, producing ideological inversions where right-wing parties occasionally adopt more protectionist stances than their left-wing counterparts, as observed in [Figure 1](#).

Empirically, left-wing governments in semi-presidential systems reduce trade-to-GDP by 10.72 percentage points within just two years of taking office. This comprehensive protectionism manifests across all trade metrics: decreased exports, reduced imports, diminished overall trade openness, and elevated tariff barriers.

These pronounced effects significantly influenced our aggregated analysis of presidential elections. When separating pure presidential systems from semi-presidential ones, we observe the expected positive export effects under presidential executives, suggesting semi-presidential systems exerted disproportionate influence on our initial findings presented in [Table 7](#).

Unlike the strategic import substitution observed in presidential systems or the “protective openness” of parliamentary governance, left-wing governments in semi-presidential systems implement economic closure reflecting different preferences embedded in their historical economic structures.

8 Conclusion

This study investigated the relationship between left-wing governance and international trade policies, addressing significant gaps in the existing literature. While previous research suggested that left-wing governments typically adopt more protectionist trade policies, empirical analyses were often limited by constrained datasets focused on specific countries or brief time periods. Using a regression discontinuity design (RDD) spanning numerous countries over an extended timeframe, this research provides robust evidence on how left-wing administrations shape trade policy across diverse institutional contexts.

The findings confirm that left-wing governments generally implement more protectionist trade policies but reveal significant heterogeneity across political systems. Based on institutional frameworks, three distinct patterns emerge.

In presidential systems, left-wing executives pursue strategies resembling import-

substitution industrialization, increasing tariffs and promoting exports while systematically reducing imports-to-GDP and overall trade openness. This asymmetric intervention may reflect the concentrated decision-making authority available to presidents, enabling direct implementation of strategic trade policies.

Parliamentary systems under left-wing governance demonstrate what we call “protective openness”, a nuanced approach combining the highest tariff increases across political systems with enhanced export performance and overall trade openness. This paradoxical pattern reflects institutional constraints requiring coalition support and regional advantages facilitating trade integration. Particularly notable is the inconsistent impact on imports, which sometimes increase despite elevated tariffs. This ambiguity stems from competing forces: tariff barriers theoretically reduce imports, while regional integration benefits (lower transportation costs, established trade agreements, and cultural affinities) facilitate them. The net effect depends on which force predominates in specific contexts.

Semi-presidential systems under left-wing leadership implement the most comprehensive protectionist policies, systematically decreasing exports, imports, and overall trade openness while raising tariffs. This pattern, observed primarily in post-socialist economies, suggests path-dependent preferences shaped by historical economic structures.

This novel application of the RDD methodology in the political economy of international trade significantly advances our understanding of ideological influences on trade policies. Future research could explore industry-specific heterogeneities, as tariff impacts typically vary across sectors, with governments often protecting strategically important industries. Additionally, investigating whether left-wing governments preferentially increase trade with ideological allies (e.g., Russia, China) rather than traditional Western partners would extend insights provided by previous research, including [Dutt and Mitra \(2005\)](#).

These findings offer a robust global analysis of left-wing trade policy behaviors. They confirm protectionist tendencies while highlighting critical institutional variations fundamentally shaping how political ideology changes international trade outcomes.

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A Descriptive Statistics by Political Systems

A.1 Descriptive Statistics for Presidential Elections

Appendix Table A1. Descriptive Statistics—Presidential Systems

Political System: Presidentialism	Obs	Mean	S.D.	Min	Max
<i>All Elections</i>	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Left Margin (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	322	5.16	49.12	-100.00	100.00
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	170	40.09	34.65	0.22	100.00
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	152	-33.92	29.58	-100.00	-0.60
Left Victory: I[Left Margin ≥ 0]					
<i>All Sample</i>	322	0.53	0.50	0.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin ≥ 0]</i>	170	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin < 0]</i>	152	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left Government after Election					
<i>All Sample</i>	322	0.52	0.50	0.00	1.00
<i>Left</i>	169	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>Non-Left</i>	153	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
<i>Presidential Elections</i>					
Left Margin (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	283	7.23	50.08	-98.00	100.00
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	153	42.31	35.69	0.22	100.00
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	130	-34.05	28.37	-98.00	-0.60
Left Victory: I[Left Margin ≥ 0]					
<i>All Sample</i>	283	0.54	0.50	0.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin ≥ 0]</i>	153	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin < 0]</i>	130	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left Government after Election					
<i>All Sample</i>	283	0.54	0.50	0.00	1.00
<i>Left</i>	153	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>Non-Left</i>	130	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
<i>Legislative Elections</i>					
Left Margin (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	39	-9.92	38.80	-100.00	44.75
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	17	20.11	10.37	6.60	44.75
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	22	-33.13	36.71	-100.00	-3.00
Left Victory: I[Left Margin ≥ 0]					
<i>All Sample</i>	39	0.44	0.50	0.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin ≥ 0]</i>	17	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin < 0]</i>	22	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left Government after Election					
<i>All Sample</i>	39	0.41	0.50	0.00	1.00
<i>Left</i>	16	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>Non-Left</i>	23	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00

Notes: The election data in the table only includes presidential systems. The term “Left Margin” refers to the margin by which left-wing parties either win or lose an election. “Left Government” is a dummy variable used to indicate whether the government is left-leaning following the election.

A.2 Descriptive Statistics for Parliamentary Elections

Appendix Table A2. Descriptive Statistics—Parliamentary Systems

Political System: Parliamentarism	Obs	Mean	S.D.	Min	Max
<i>All Legislative Elections</i>	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Left Margin (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	567	-24.30	31.33	-93.96	82.05
<i>Left Margin ≥ 0</i>	114	15.55	16.44	0.00	82.05
<i>Left Margin < 0</i>	453	-34.32	25.70	-93.96	-0.29
Left Victory: I[Left Margin ≥ 0]					
<i>All Sample</i>	567	0.20	0.40	0.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin ≥ 0]</i>	114	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin < 0]</i>	453	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left Government after Election					
<i>All Sample</i>	552	0.26	0.44	0.00	1.00
<i>Left</i>	142	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>Non-Left</i>	410	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left-wing cabinet members (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	459	31.69	39.32	0.00	100.00
<i>Left $\geq 2/3$</i>	106	95.78	9.06	66.67	100.00
<i>Left $< 2/3$</i>	353	12.45	19.48	0.00	66.67

Notes: The election data in the table only includes Parliamentary systems. The term “Left Margin” refers to the margin of victory or loss for left-wing parties in an election. “Left Government” is a dummy variable that indicates whether a government is left-leaning after the election. “Left Cabinets” represents the share of cabinet positions held by left-wing parties.

A.3 Descriptive Statistics for Semi-Presidential Elections

Appendix Table A3. Descriptive Statistics — Semi-Presidential Systems

Political System: Semi-Presidentialism	Obs	Mean	S.D.	Min	Max
<i>All Elections</i>	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Left Margin (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	175	-18.83	41.17	-100.00	96.00
<i>Left Margin</i> ≥ 0	58	26.06	24.68	0.01	96.00
<i>Left Margin</i> < 0	117	-41.08	27.13	-100.00	-0.64
Left Victory: I[Left Margin ≥ 0]					
<i>All Sample</i>	175	0.33	0.47	0.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin</i> ≥ 0]	58	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin</i> < 0]	117	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left Government after Election					
<i>All Sample</i>	171	0.32	0.47	0.00	1.00
<i>Left</i>	55	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>Non-Left</i>	116	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left-wing cabinet members (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	58	34.59	40.00	0.00	100.00
<i>Left</i> $\geq 2/3$	15	91.14	11.82	68.75	100.00
<i>Left</i> $< 2/3$	43	14.86	24.17	0.00	65.00
<i>Presidential Elections</i>					
Left Margin (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	91	-6.54	42.43	-96.14	96.00
<i>Left Margin</i> ≥ 0	38	32.60	27.68	0.01	96.00
<i>Left Margin</i> < 0	53	-34.61	25.47	-96.14	-0.64
Left Victory: I[Left Margin ≥ 0]					
<i>All Sample</i>	91	0.42	0.50	0.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin</i> ≥ 0]	38	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin</i> < 0]	53	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left Government after Election					
<i>All Sample</i>	91	0.42	0.50	0.00	1.00
<i>Left</i>	38	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>Non-Left</i>	53	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left-wing cabinet members (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	2	62.50	53.03	25.00	100.00
<i>Left</i> $\geq 2/3$	1	100.00	–	100.00	100.00
<i>Left</i> $< 2/3$	1	25.00	–	25.00	25.00
<i>Legislative Elections</i>					
Left Margin (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	84	-32.14	35.44	-100.00	32.52
<i>Left Margin</i> ≥ 0	20	13.63	9.32	0.87	32.52
<i>Left Margin</i> < 0	64	-46.45	27.48	-100.00	-2.40
Left Victory: I[Left Margin ≥ 0]					
<i>All Sample</i>	84	0.24	0.43	0.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin</i> ≥ 0]	20	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>I[Left Margin</i> < 0]	64	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left Government after Election					
<i>All Sample</i>	80	0.21	0.41	0.00	1.00
<i>Left</i>	17	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00
<i>Non-Left</i>	63	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
Left-wing cabinet members (%)					
<i>All Sample</i>	56	33.59	39.72	0.00	100.00
<i>Left</i> $\geq 2/3$	14	90.51	12.00	68.75	100.00
<i>Left</i> $< 2/3$	42	14.62	24.41	0.00	65.00

Notes: The election data in the table only includes Semi-presidential systems. The term “Left Margin” refers to the margin of victory or loss for left-wing parties in an election. “Left Government” is a dummy variable that indicates whether a government is left-leaning after the election. “Left Cabinets” represents the share of cabinet positions held by left-wing parties.

B Manipulation Tests

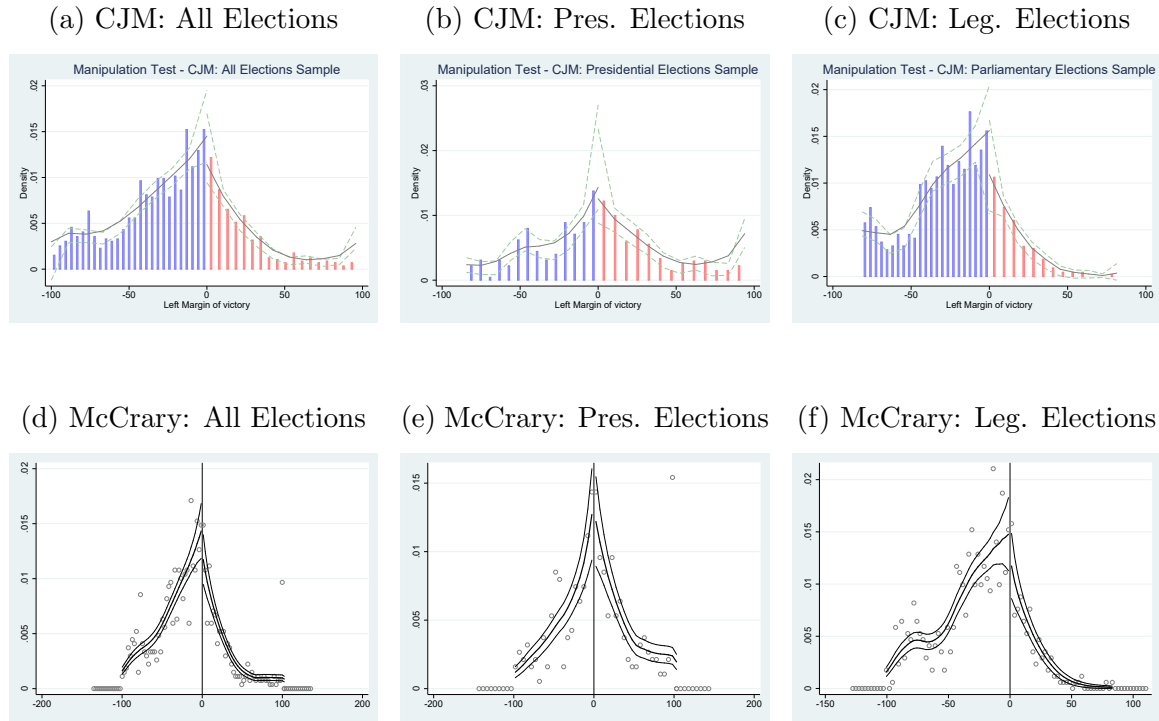
B.1 McCrary and CJM Manipulation Tests

Appendix Table B1. Tests for a discontinuity in the running variable at the threshold

	All elections		Presidential		Legislative	
	McCrary	CJM	McCrary	CJM	McCrary	CJM
T-stat	-1.25	0.82	-0.32	0.50	-0.91	0.36
p-value	0.22	0.41	0.75	0.62	0.37	0.72

Notes: The McCrary column reports the [McCrary \(2008\)](#) manipulation test. The CJM column reports the [Cattaneo et al. \(2020\)](#) rddensity test. Both test the null hypothesis of no discontinuity in the distribution of the running variable (the left margin in the election) at the cutoff.

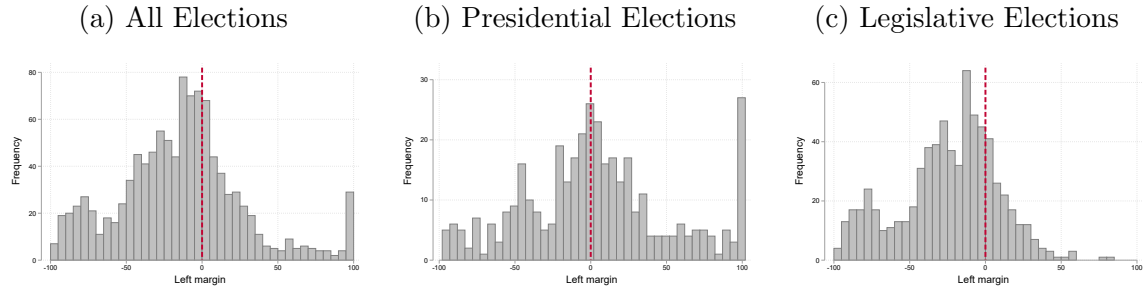
Appendix Figure B1. Tests for a discontinuity in the running variable at the threshold



Notes: The McCrary column reports the [McCrary \(2008\)](#) manipulation test. The CJM column reports the [Cattaneo et al. \(2020\)](#) rddensity test. Both test the null hypothesis of no discontinuity in the distribution of the running variable (the left margin in the election) at the cutoff.

B.2 Histogram of left margin of victory/loss around the threshold

Appendix Figure B2. Histogram of left margin of victory around the threshold



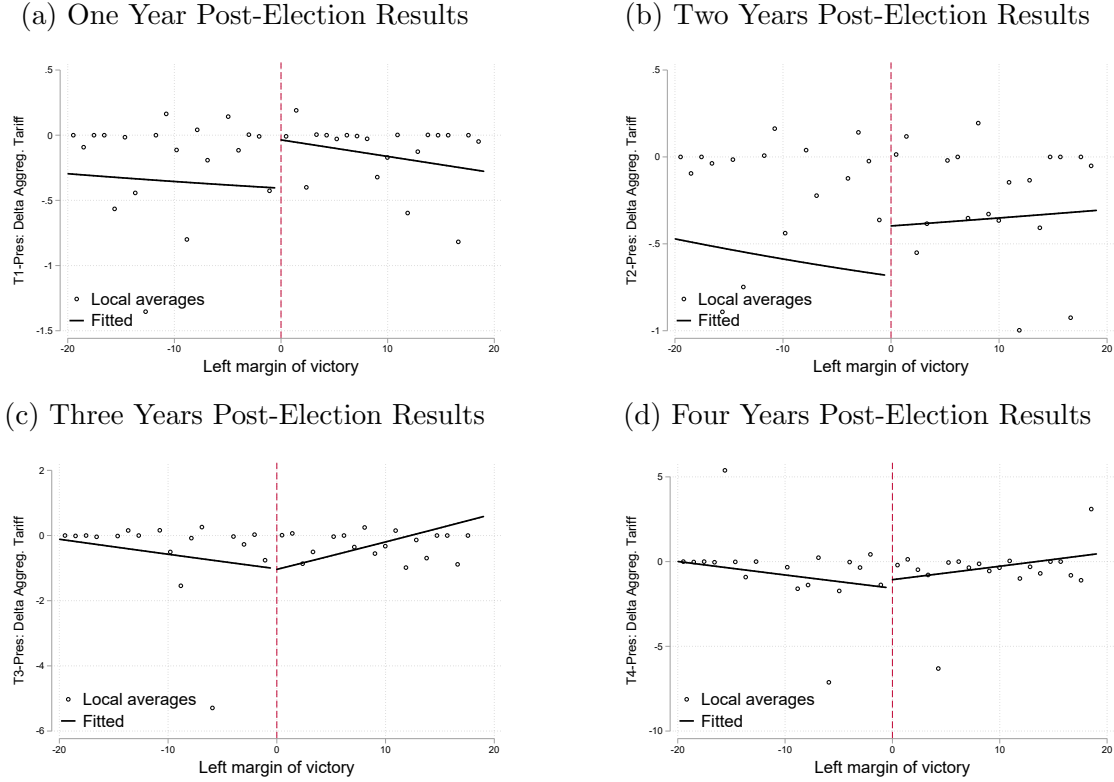
Notes: The figures show the distribution of the left margin of victory around the threshold. The threshold is at zero, where positive values indicate that the left-wing candidate won the election.

C Supplementary Results for Presidential and Legislative Elections

C.1 Appendix: Figures

C.1.1 Δ Tariff

Appendix Figure C1. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties in Presidential Elections and Aggregate Tariff Rate Adjustments (1966–2020)

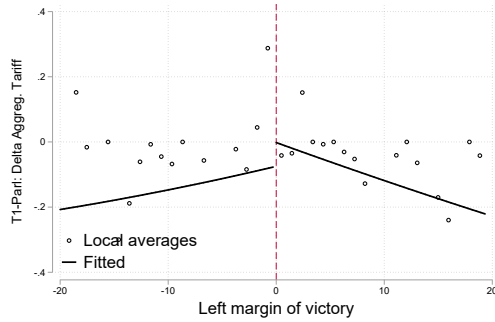


Notes: Figure C1a to Figure C1d depict the response of import aggregate tariffs following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in aggregated tariffs during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

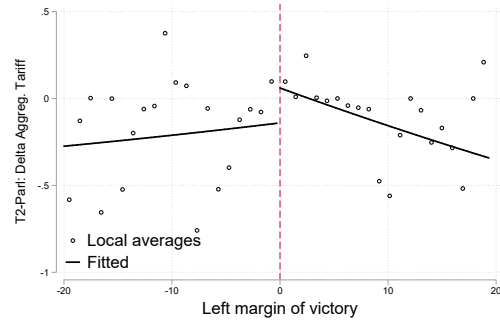
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Appendix Figure C2. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties in Legislative Elections and Aggregate Tariff Rate Adjustments (1966–2020)

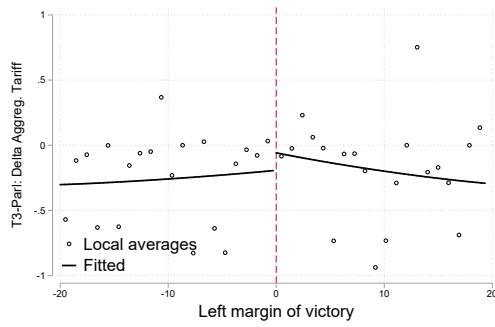
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



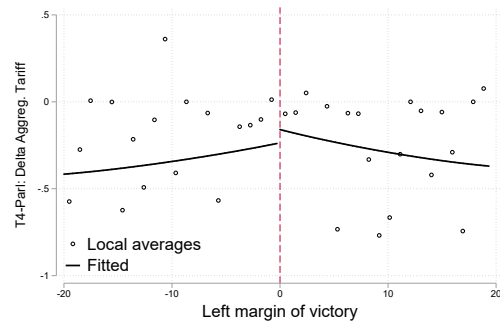
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



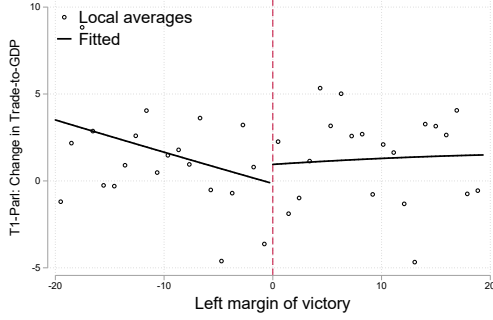
Notes: Figure C2a to Figure C2d depict the response of import aggregate tariffs following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in aggregated tariffs during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

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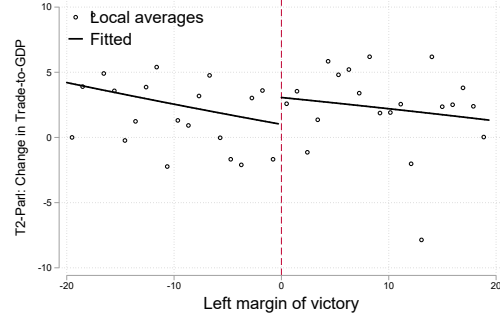
C.2 Δ Trade-to-GDP Ratio Figures

Appendix Figure C3. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties in Legislative Elections and Changes in Trade-to-GDP ratio (1948-2022)

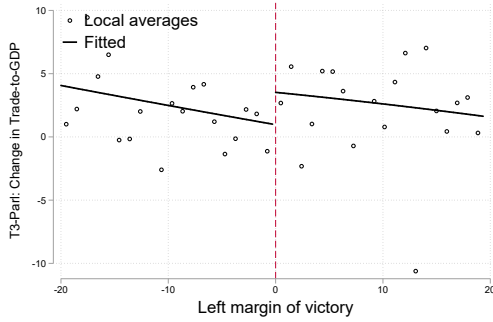
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



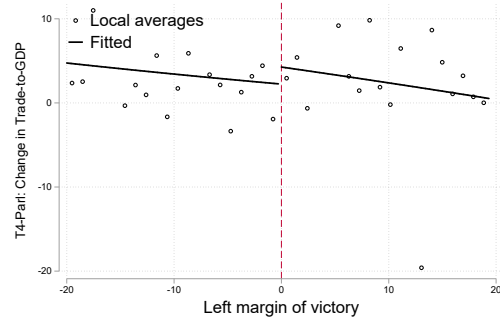
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



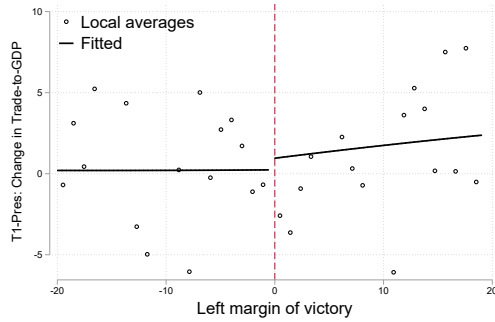
(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



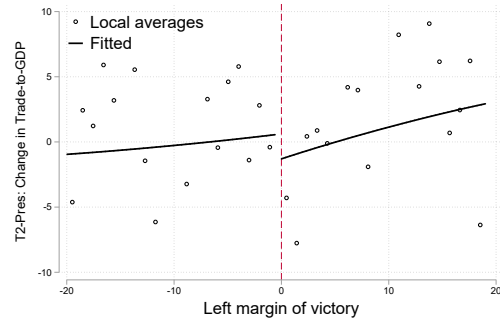
Notes: Figure C3a to Figure C3d depict the response of trade-to-GDP ratio following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in trade-to-GDP ratio during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

Appendix Figure C4. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties in Presidential Elections and Changes in Trade-to-GDP ratio (1948-2022)

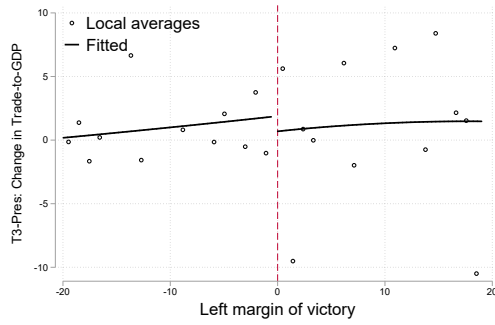
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



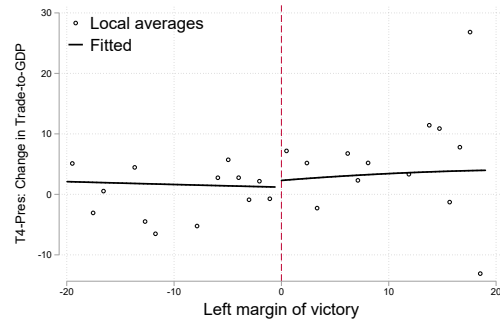
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure C4a to Figure C4d depict the response of trade-to-GDP ratio following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in trade-to-GDP ratio during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

D Disaggregated Analysis

D.1 Disaggregated Analysis: Δ Tariff

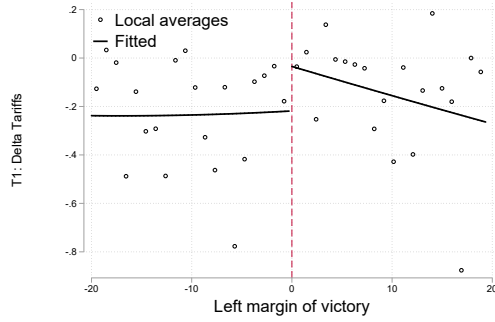
To complement our aggregated findings, we examine disaggregated bilateral tariff changes at the country-pair-industry level, as detailed in [Equation 4](#). This approach reveals how left-wing administrations adjust tariffs on specific trading partners across different industries.

[Figure D1](#) shows an apparent positive discontinuity in bilateral tariff changes ($\Delta Tariff$) at the electoral threshold, reinforcing our finding that left-wing governments systematically increase tariff protection. [Table D1](#) quantifies these bilateral effects, showing consistent and statistically significant tariff increases under left-wing administrations. As in our aggregated analysis, we observe a pattern where parliamentary systems implement larger tariff increases than presidential systems. Across all specifications and periods, the average bilateral tariff increase is approximately 0.40 percentage points per trading partner.

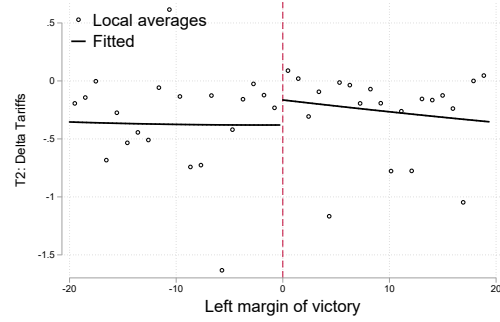
The bilateral analysis further suggests substantial heterogeneity across industries, political structures, and trading partners, with specific sectors likely experiencing more pronounced protectionist measures. This heterogeneity aligns with theoretical expectations that left-wing governments may strategically protect industries based on domestic political considerations, labor intensity, or perceived vulnerability to international competition.

Appendix Figure D1. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties and Tariff Rate Adjustments (1966–2020)

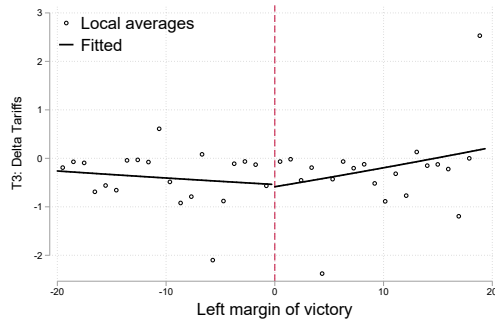
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



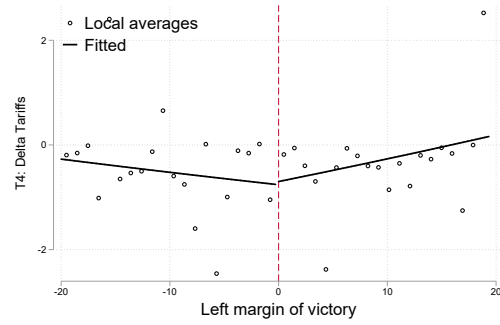
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure D1a to Figure D1d depict the response of import tariffs across industries following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in industry-specific tariffs during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

*

Appendix Table D1. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Tariff Rates: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1966–2020, TPe: Data from WITS)

Outcome: h (years)	Change in Tariff Rates between t-1 and t+h								
	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	0.27 (0.36)	0.44 (0.36)	0.19 (0.27)	0.25 (0.40)	0.39** (0.26)	0.85*** (0.16)	0.21 (0.60)	0.91* (0.79)	-0.04* (0.40)
+2	0.34 (0.44)	0.36 (0.46)	-0.04 (0.38)	0.22 (0.56)	0.43** (0.31)	1.23*** (0.16)	1.05 (0.92)	1.23 (1.00)	0.07 (0.48)
+3	0.06 (0.63)	0.22 (0.65)	-0.09 (0.48)	0.11 (0.78)	0.29 (0.53)	-0.99*** (0.20)	0.74 (0.86)	1.46 (1.34)	0.66 (0.94)
+4	0.20 (0.78)	0.36 (0.79)	0.17 (0.64)	0.41 (1.04)	0.83** (0.61)	-0.74** (0.28)	0.19 (0.74)	0.87 (1.04)	1.24 (1.54)
First stage	0.57*** (0.09)	0.50*** (0.08)	0.48*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.24 (0.15)	0.18 (0.10)	0.19 (0.11)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Country FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	1,049,517	1,049,517	1,049,517	406,971	406,971	406,971	642,546	642,546	642,546
Eff. obs	499,293	460,422	305,163	255,591	223,245	119,457	280,539	236,124	161,739

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the import tariffs adopted by the country after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and “All elections”) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. “First stage” refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. “Eff. obs” denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

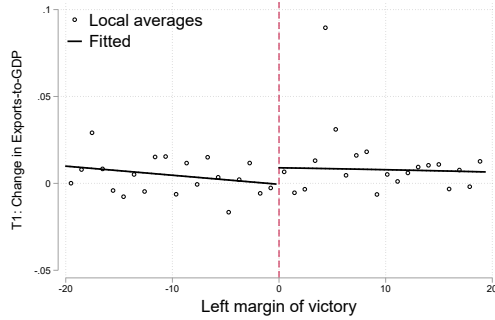
D.2 Disaggregated Analysis: Δ Exports-to-GDP

Disaggregated analyses confirm findings from our aggregated analyses. Visual evidence in [Figure D2](#) shows a positive effect of left-wing governance on trade, while [Table D2](#) quantifies these effects across different elections. Legislative elections consistently exhibit stronger positive effects compared to presidential elections, where we observe an initial positive effect followed by a negative trend.

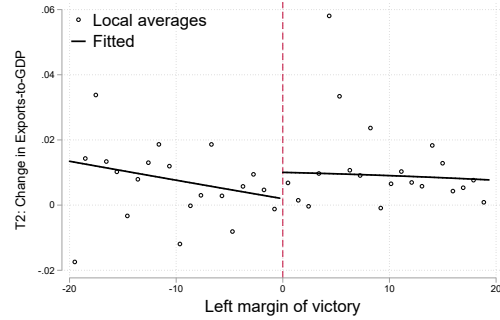
Further, the modest magnitude of these effects likely stems from two methodological factors. First, our dataset structure examines each country’s trade relationships with diverse partners simultaneously, from major economic powers to minor trading partners, standardized by the exporting country’s GDP. Second, the extended temporal window (1948–2020) encompasses substantial structural shifts in global trade patterns that may attenuate observable discontinuities.

Appendix Figure D2. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties and Disaggregated Changes in Exports-to-GDP ratio (1948-2022)

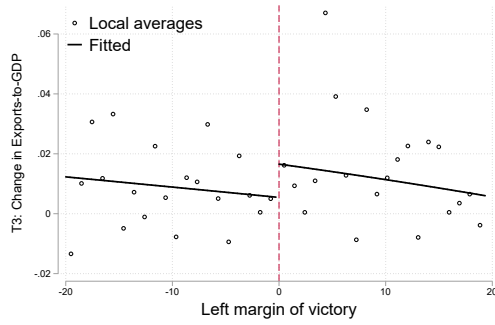
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



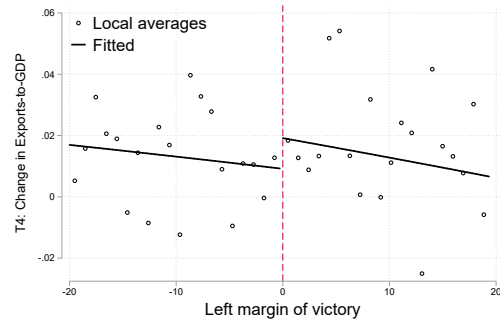
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Panels [Figure D2a](#) to [Figure D2d](#) depict the response of disaggregated exports-to-GDP ratio following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in exports-to-GDP ratio during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

*

Appendix Table D2. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:	Change in Exports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	0.01 (0.01)	0.03*** (0.01)	0.03*** (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	0.05*** (0.01)	0.11*** (0.01)	0.02 (0.03)	0.08** (0.05)	0.01 (0.02)
+2	0.01 (0.01)	0.04*** (0.02)	0.02* (0.01)	-0.00 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	0.05*** (0.01)	0.03 (0.03)	0.12** (0.07)	0.05** (0.02)
+3	0.02 (0.02)	0.04** (0.02)	0.04*** (0.02)	-0.00 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	0.10*** (0.01)	0.04 (0.04)	0.12* (0.09)	0.02 (0.03)
+4	0.02 (0.02)	0.04** (0.02)	0.05*** (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.04*** (0.02)	0.11*** (0.01)	0.03 (0.04)	0.11* (0.08)	-0.02 (0.03)
First stage	0.53*** (0.09)	0.46*** (0.07)	0.47*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.31** (0.13)	0.18 (0.09)	0.32*** (0.09)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Country FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	135539	135539	135539	40760	40760	40760	94779	94779	94779
Eff. obs	71083	68687	40908	21783	15739	15739	49715	36257	23130

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country’s exports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and “All elections”) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. “First stage” refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. “Eff. obs” denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

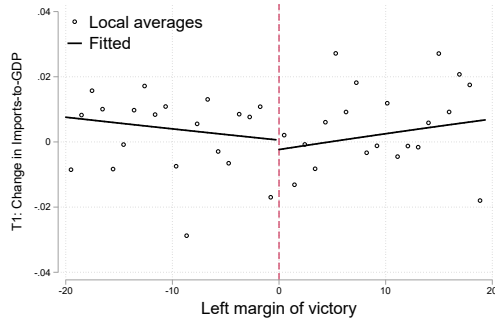
D.3 Disaggregated Analysis: Δ Imports-to-GDP

The disaggregated analysis largely corroborates the findings from aggregated data. As depicted in [Figure D3](#), left-wing governments typically decrease the imports-to-GDP ratio in the initial three years post-election, with a modestly positive discontinuity appearing in the fourth year.

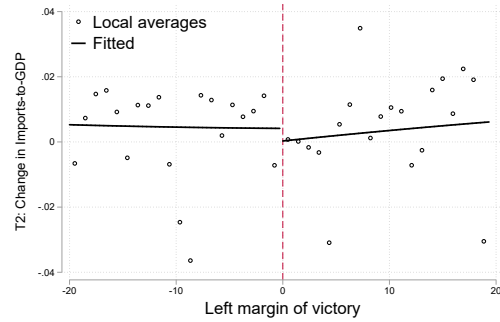
Regression estimates presented in [Table D3](#) align closely with aggregated results, consistently indicating reductions in imports-to-GDP ratios for both the pooled and presidential samples, whereas legislative elections demonstrate positive import responses.

Appendix Figure D3. Electoral Margin of Left-Wing Parties and Disaggregated Changes in Imports-to-GDP ratio (1948-2022)

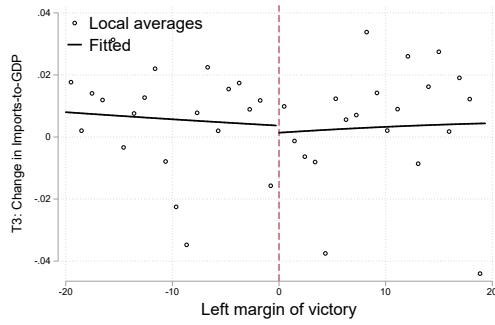
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



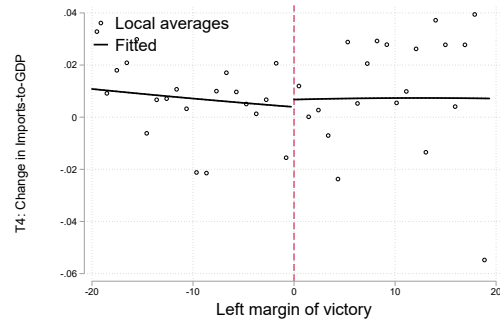
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Panels [Figure D3a](#) to [Figure D3d](#) depict the response of disaggregated imports-to-GDP ratio following electoral victories by left-wing parties. The vertical axis represents the percentage change in imports-to-GDP ratio during the four years after an election. The horizontal axis measures the electoral margin of victory for left-wing candidates. Each point in the scatterplot corresponds to average outcomes grouped by values of the forcing variable. The fitted lines are estimated using kernel-weighted local linear regression with an MSE-optimal bandwidth. Estimation employs a fuzzy regression discontinuity design (RDD) with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

*

Appendix Table D3. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Imports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:		Change in Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h							
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	-0.01 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	-0.01 (0.01)	-0.00 (0.01)	0.07*** (0.01)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.02)
+2	-0.01 (0.01)	0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	-0.03** (0.02)	-0.03** (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)	0.00 (0.03)	0.03 (0.04)	0.01 (0.02)
+3	-0.00 (0.01)	-0.00 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)	-0.03*** (0.02)	-0.01** (0.02)	0.00 (0.03)	0.02 (0.05)	-0.02 (0.04)
+4	0.00 (0.02)	0.00 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.03*** (0.01)	-0.03 (0.02)	0.01 (0.03)	0.04 (0.05)	-0.04* (0.03)
First stage	0.53*** (0.09)	0.46*** (0.07)	0.46*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.28* (0.13)	0.19 (0.08)	0.29*** (0.10)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Country FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	129023	129023	129023	40269	40269	40269	88754	88754	88754
Eff. obs	62853	59537	42281	17715	16157	10921	41069	38183	22198

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's imports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and “All elections”) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. “First stage” refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. “Eff. obs” denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

E Robustness Checks: Excluding Post-Socialist States

E.1 Δ Tariff excluding Post-Socialist States

Appendix Table E1. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Tariff Rates Excluding Post-Socialist States: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1966–2020, TPe: Data from WITS)

Outcome: h (years)	Change in Aggregated Tariff Rates between t-1 and t+h								
	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	0.19 (0.32)	0.29 (0.32)	0.05 (0.35)	0.33 (0.46)	0.47 (0.45)	0.39 (0.45)	-0.20 (0.36)	0.06 (0.41)	-0.19 (0.36)
+2	0.25 (0.42)	0.15 (0.40)	0.25 (0.40)	0.25 (0.60)	0.35 (0.60)	0.38 (0.60)	0.48 (0.47)	0.63 (0.55)	0.37 (0.47)
+3	0.13 (0.58)	0.06 (0.57)	0.12 (0.55)	0.27 (0.83)	0.39 (0.83)	0.42 (0.82)	0.29 (0.39)	0.18 (0.43)	0.27 (0.49)
+4	0.47 (0.75)	0.27 (0.73)	0.28 (0.70)	0.75 (1.18)	0.89 (1.17)	0.70 (1.16)	0.05 (0.40)	-0.08 (0.44)	-0.01 (0.51)
First stage	0.59*** (0.10)	0.59*** (0.09)	0.58*** (0.10)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.37** (0.18)	0.28* (0.14)	0.35** (0.16)
Out. Mean: h = 1	-0.15	-0.15	-0.15	-0.23	-0.23	-0.23	-0.10	-0.10	-0.10
Out. Mean: h = 2	-0.21	-0.21	-0.21	-0.31	-0.31	-0.31	-0.14	-0.14	-0.14
Out. Mean: h = 3	-0.27	-0.27	-0.27	-0.39	-0.39	-0.39	-0.19	-0.19	-0.19
Out. Mean: h = 4	-0.37	-0.37	-0.37	-0.57	-0.57	-0.57	-0.23	-0.23	-0.23
Decade FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	635	635	635	255	255	255	380	380	380
Eff. obs	316	349	274	146	144	146	128	185	130

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the import aggregated tariffs adopted by the country after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and “All elections”) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. “First stage” refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. “Eff. obs” denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. “Out. Mean” is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

E.2 Δ Exports-to-GDP excluding Post-Socialist States

Appendix Table E2. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Exports Excluding Post-Socialist States: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Exports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	1.71 (1.60)	1.92 (1.56)	1.81 (1.67)	1.71 (1.59)	2.20 (1.53)	1.93 (1.46)	1.48 (2.96)	2.26 (4.05)	2.05 (3.62)
+2	1.15 (1.46)	1.55 (1.35)	1.87 (1.51)	1.15 (1.43)	0.91 (1.35)	0.82 (1.29)	2.01 (3.17)	4.07 (4.38)	3.73 (3.97)
+3	2.07 (2.10)	2.93 (2.22)	2.39 (2.07)	1.25 (1.82)	1.18 (1.94)	0.23 (1.92)	5.10 (5.62)	5.42 (5.72)	5.13 (5.23)
+4	1.75 (2.36)	2.71 (2.49)	1.89 (2.40)	1.95 (2.83)	1.94 (2.92)	0.91 (2.84)	3.48 (5.58)	2.51 (4.56)	2.58 (4.46)
First stage	0.59*** (0.09)	0.59*** (0.09)	0.58*** (0.09)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.37** (0.13)	0.32** (0.13)	0.33** (0.12)
Out. Mean: h = 1	0.29	0.29	0.29	0.46	0.46	0.46	0.19	0.19	0.19
Out. Mean: h = 2	0.62	0.62	0.62	0.54	0.54	0.54	0.65	0.65	0.65
Out. Mean: h = 3	0.64	0.64	0.64	0.43	0.43	0.43	0.78	0.78	0.78
Out. Mean: h = 4	0.80	0.80	0.80	0.64	0.64	0.64	0.90	0.90	0.90
Decade FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	789	789	789	306	306	306	483	483	483
Eff. obs	494	493	414	160	154	149	325	248	254

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated exports after the election, excluding post-socialist countries. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. "Out. Mean" is the outcome variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

E.3 Δ Imports-to-GDP excluding Post-Socialist States

Appendix Table E3. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Imports Excluding Post-Socialist States: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome: h (years)	Change in Aggregated Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	-0.64 (1.48)	-0.67 (1.49)	-0.73 (1.52)	-0.64 (1.92)	-1.08 (1.85)	-1.33 (1.80)	-1.79 (2.11)	-1.86 (2.52)	-2.04 (2.33)
+2	-0.18 (1.67)	0.16 (1.62)	-0.16 (1.68)	-2.67* (2.06)	-3.16** (1.87)	-2.48* (1.83)	0.42 (2.79)	1.48 (2.94)	1.58 (2.93)
+3	-0.70 (1.88)	-0.25 (1.79)	0.02 (1.83)	-2.70 (2.50)	-3.24* (2.26)	-2.96 (2.20)	0.76 (4.20)	1.47 (3.90)	1.83 (3.55)
+4	-1.30 (2.16)	-1.03 (2.09)	-0.81 (2.07)	-2.92 (2.82)	-3.51* (2.49)	-4.04** (2.40)	0.24 (4.95)	0.85 (4.05)	0.71 (3.40)
First stage	0.59*** (0.09)	0.59*** (0.09)	0.58*** (0.09)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.37** (0.13)	0.33** (0.13)	0.34** (0.12)
Out. Mean: h = 1	0.26	0.26	0.26	0.08	0.08	0.08	0.37	0.37	0.37
Out. Mean: h = 2	0.18	0.18	0.18	-0.41	-0.41	-0.41	0.55	0.55	0.55
Out. Mean: h = 3	0.21	0.21	0.21	-0.45	-0.45	-0.45	0.61	0.61	0.61
Out. Mean: h = 4	0.41	0.41	0.41	-0.02	-0.02	-0.02	0.67	0.67	0.67
Decade FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	782	782	782	299	299	299	483	483	483
Eff. obs	468	416	406	124	132	131	308	263	277

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated imports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. "Out. Mean" is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

E.4 Δ Trade-to-GDP excluding Post-Socialist States

Appendix Table E4. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Trade Openness Excluding Post-Socialist States: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined Data)

Outcome: h (years)	Change in Trade Openness between t-1 and t+h								
	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	1.39 (2.43)	1.74 (2.40)	1.47 (2.49)	1.94 (2.57)	2.39 (2.55)	1.18 (2.44)	-0.22 (4.31)	0.38 (5.61)	0.24 (5.14)
+2	1.17 (2.72)	2.03 (2.57)	2.23 (2.80)	-2.10 (2.84)	-2.49 (2.74)	-2.65 (2.62)	2.45 (5.58)	5.31 (6.65)	5.21 (6.26)
+3	2.10 (3.35)	2.45 (3.44)	2.81 (3.49)	-1.98 (3.75)	-1.97 (3.67)	-2.98 (3.51)	5.24 (8.73)	6.37 (8.70)	6.52 (7.92)
+4	1.60 (3.67)	2.23 (3.71)	1.77 (3.71)	-0.61 (4.55)	-1.05 (4.46)	-2.83 (4.12)	3.50 (9.04)	3.82 (8.21)	3.29 (7.32)
First stage	0.59*** (0.09)	0.59*** (0.09)	0.58*** (0.09)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.37** (0.13)	0.32** (0.13)	0.33** (0.12)
Out. Mean: h = 1	0.51	0.51	0.51	0.43	0.43	0.43	0.56	0.56	0.56
Out. Mean: h = 2	0.79	0.79	0.79	0.12	0.12	0.12	1.20	1.20	1.20
Out. Mean: h = 3	0.85	0.85	0.85	-0.02	-0.02	-0.02	1.39	1.39	1.39
Out. Mean: h = 4	1.21	1.21	1.21	0.62	0.62	0.62	1.57	1.57	1.57
Decade FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	782	782	782	299	299	299	483	483	483
Eff. obs	483	473	420	138	144	131	317	251	252

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated Trade Openness after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. "Out. Mean" is the dependent variable mean for each period. Levels of significance: * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

F Robustness Checks: Winsorizing and Trimming

F.1 Aggregate Δ Tariff

F.1.1 Baseline Model

Appendix Table F1. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Tariff Rates: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1966-2020, TPe: Data from WITS)

Outcome:		Change in Aggregated Tariff Rates between t-1 and t+h																						
h (years)	All elections								Presidential								Legislative							
	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)			
+1	0.25 (0.31)	0.23 (0.25)	0.20 (0.24)	0.13 (0.19)	-0.14 (0.12)	0.07 (0.14)	-0.03 (0.09)	0.27 (0.37)	0.18 (0.33)	0.13 (0.31)	0.24 (0.23)	0.03 (0.14)	0.15 (0.17)	0.06 (0.14)	0.19 (0.45)	0.02 (0.44)	-0.07 (0.24)	-0.05 (0.30)	-0.17 (0.26)	-0.01 (0.23)	0.07 (0.17)			
+2	0.30 (0.40)	0.22 (0.32)	0.20 (0.31)	0.20 (0.29)	0.00 (0.26)	0.15 (0.23)	-0.01 (0.15)	0.18 (0.54)	0.01 (0.47)	-0.12 (0.47)	0.11 (0.36)	0.15 (0.32)	0.10 (0.33)	0.01 (0.28)	0.85 (0.69)	0.64 (0.52)	0.51 (0.52)	0.64 (0.53)	0.48 (0.50)	0.50 (0.41)	0.24 (0.31)			
+3	0.08 (0.55)	0.04 (0.42)	0.28 (0.34)	0.17 (0.35)	0.26 (0.29)	0.15 (0.26)	0.14 (0.17)	0.09 (0.74)	-0.10 (0.62)	-0.23 (0.58)	0.01 (0.48)	0.19 (0.34)	0.11 (0.35)	0.03 (0.25)	0.57 (0.64)	0.64 (0.65)	0.71 (0.68)	0.54 (0.54)	0.10 (0.24)	0.34 (0.39)	0.08 (0.28)			
+4	0.30 (0.71)	0.17 (0.53)	0.37 (0.45)	0.21 (0.43)	0.11 (0.37)	0.14 (0.36)	-0.07 (0.28)	0.43 (1.01)	0.07 (0.76)	0.02 (0.79)	0.12 (0.58)	0.53 (0.53)	0.22 (0.45)	0.22 (0.41)	0.20 (0.58)	0.19 (0.58)	0.11 (0.57)	0.16 (0.54)	-0.13 (0.44)	0.06 (0.46)	-0.11 (0.36)			
First stage	0.57 (0.09)	0.56 (0.09)	0.55 (0.09)	0.56 (0.09)	0.55 (0.09)	0.56 (0.09)	0.54 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.27 (0.15)	0.26 (0.16)	0.29 (0.18)	0.26 (0.16)	0.27 (0.17)	0.26 (0.16)	0.28 (0.15)			

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated import tariffs adopted by the country after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "all elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Calónico et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h=1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

F.1.2 Specification with Year Fixed Effects

Appendix Table F2. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Tariff Rates: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1966-2020, TPe: Data from WITS)

Outcome:	Change in Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h																				
h (years)	All elections						Presidential						Legislative								
	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)
+1	0.40 (0.33)	0.38 (0.28)	0.42 (0.26)	0.27 (0.19)	0.01 (0.11)	0.19 (0.14)	0.05 (0.07)	0.46 (0.22)	0.26 (0.23)	0.26 (0.24)	0.37 (0.18)	0.24 (0.10)	0.29 (0.13)	0.17 (0.09)	0.89 (0.73)	0.72 (0.61)	0.26 (0.40)	0.43 (0.46)	-0.06 (0.34)	0.31 (0.33)	0.13 (0.24)
+2	0.32 (0.43)	0.19 (0.32)	0.26 (0.31)	0.26 (0.28)	0.17 (0.26)	0.23 (0.22)	0.14 (0.15)	0.14 (0.30)	-0.25 (0.33)	-0.27 (0.33)	-0.10 (0.30)	0.21 (0.27)	-0.00 (0.26)	0.16 (1.00)	1.39 (0.77)	1.45 (1.08)	1.29 (0.90)	1.28 (1.03)	1.01 (0.68)	0.62 (0.50)	
+3	0.19 (0.60)	0.25 (0.43)	0.53 (0.35)	0.42 (0.35)	0.43 (0.32)	0.36 (0.26)	0.25 (0.15)	0.38 (0.46)	-0.05 (0.47)	-0.23 (0.50)	0.31 (0.34)	0.55 (0.31)	0.37 (0.28)	0.11 (0.21)	1.45 (1.31)	1.56 (1.31)	1.66 (1.39)	1.36 (1.13)	0.38 (0.54)	0.91 (0.79)	0.64 (0.66)
+4	0.40 (0.74)	0.36 (0.52)	0.58 (0.43)	0.46 (0.40)	0.34 (0.31)	0.40 (0.32)	0.14 (0.24)	0.81 (0.58)	0.15 (0.55)	0.26 (0.56)	0.43 (0.43)	0.79 (0.41)	0.68 (0.33)	0.44 (0.24)	0.97 (1.06)	0.99 (1.06)	1.32 (1.23)	0.94 (0.97)	0.09 (0.52)	0.54 (0.65)	0.04 (0.38)
First stage	0.49 (0.08)	0.47 (0.09)	0.46 (0.09)	0.47 (0.09)	0.48 (0.08)	0.47 (0.09)	0.49 (0.07)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.16 (0.10)	0.16 (0.10)	0.17 (0.11)	0.16 (0.10)	0.15 (0.11)	0.17 (0.10)	0.15 (0.13)	
Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated import tariffs adopted by the country after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "all elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Calónico et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h=1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

F.1.3 Specification with Fixed Effects for Year and Region

Appendix Table F3. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Tariff Rates: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1966-2020, TPe: Data from WITS)

Outcome: h (years)		Change in Aggregated Tariff Rates between t-1 and t+h																			
		All elections						Presidential						Legislative							
		Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)
+1	0.14 (0.36)	0.29 (0.27)	0.38 (0.25)	0.21 (0.19)	-0.03 (0.10)	0.13 (0.13)	0.00 (0.07)	0.43 (0.21)	0.26 (0.23)	0.25 (0.24)	0.31 (0.18)	0.20 (0.10)	0.23 (0.13)	0.04 (0.08)	0.36 (0.49)	0.43 (0.47)	0.20 (0.33)	0.31 (0.36)	-0.07 (0.27)	0.21 (0.27)	0.16 (0.25)
+2	-0.04 (0.44)	0.26 (0.31)	0.39 (0.30)	0.31 (0.28)	0.24 (0.27)	0.29 (0.21)	0.24 (0.14)	0.14 (0.31)	-0.11 (0.32)	-0.10 (0.32)	-0.05 (0.30)	0.23 (0.28)	0.05 (0.27)	0.23 (0.62)	0.76 (0.61)	0.80 (0.63)	1.03 (0.59)	0.92 (0.61)	0.85 (0.53)	0.84 (0.27)	0.37 (0.25)
+3	0.18 (0.60)	0.31 (0.44)	0.58 (0.36)	0.49 (0.37)	0.54 (0.32)	0.39 (0.26)	0.25 (0.14)	0.57 (0.47)	0.12 (0.49)	0.12 (0.49)	0.38 (0.36)	0.53 (0.31)	0.40 (0.29)	0.18 (0.88)	0.99 (0.88)	0.99 (0.91)	1.07 (0.73)	0.82 (0.45)	0.24 (0.53)	0.30 (0.46)	
+4	0.16 (0.80)	0.38 (0.57)	0.76 (0.49)	0.50 (0.42)	0.47 (0.29)	0.46 (0.32)	0.34 (0.23)	1.08 (0.59)	0.28 (0.51)	0.44 (0.60)	0.64 (0.43)	0.74 (0.40)	0.65 (0.33)	0.43 (0.23)	0.52 (0.72)	0.55 (0.72)	0.47 (0.71)	-0.12 (0.66)	0.24 (0.52)	-0.12 (0.48)	
First stage	0.50 (0.09)	0.51 (0.09)	0.49 (0.09)	0.50 (0.09)	0.50 (0.08)	0.50 (0.09)	0.48 (0.07)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.19 (0.11)	0.19 (0.11)	0.21 (0.13)	0.19 (0.12)	0.20 (0.12)	0.19 (0.12)	0.15 (0.13)	
Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	
Region FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated import tariffs adopted by the country after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "all elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Calónico et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h=1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

F.2 Aggregate Δ Exports-to-GDP

F.2.1 Baseline Model

Appendix Table F4. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:		Change in Aggregated Exports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h																			
h (years)	All elections						Presidential						Legislative								
	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)
+1	1.67 (1.75)	0.95 (1.33)	-0.06 (1.09)	0.49 (1.19)	-0.33 (1.02)	0.36 (1.09)	-0.14 (0.97)	0.76 (1.56)	0.78 (1.54)	0.21 (1.28)	0.32 (1.25)	-1.26 (0.98)	0.10 (1.12)	-0.41 (0.88)	3.98 (4.77)	1.97 (3.35)	-0.15 (3.09)	1.10 (3.04)	1.17 (2.90)	1.07 (2.74)	0.01 (3.17)
+2	1.10 (1.72)	1.03 (1.67)	0.74 (1.50)	0.79 (1.45)	-0.33 (1.33)	0.54 (1.38)	-0.58 (1.16)	-0.46 (1.48)	-0.10 (1.44)	0.14 (1.39)	-0.09 (1.39)	-0.87 (1.42)	-0.20 (1.35)	-0.95 (1.32)	4.18 (5.19)	3.10 (5.02)	2.55 (4.27)	3.07 (4.13)	0.87 (3.77)	2.22 (3.19)	1.77 (3.01)
+3	1.92 (2.27)	1.47 (2.11)	0.23 (1.86)	0.91 (1.87)	0.22 (1.58)	0.74 (1.73)	-0.04 (1.29)	-0.02 (1.82)	0.03 (1.83)	-0.05 (1.91)	-0.44 (1.76)	-0.02 (1.49)	-0.34 (1.68)	5.96 (6.25)	3.99 (5.24)	-0.01 (4.72)	2.73 (4.46)	-0.40 (5.20)	2.42 (4.05)	0.58 (4.36)	
+4	1.81 (2.61)	1.66 (2.52)	1.09 (2.24)	1.35 (2.38)	1.29 (1.94)	1.17 (2.17)	0.09 (1.54)	1.01 (2.70)	1.02 (2.67)	0.32 (2.43)	0.93 (2.50)	1.05 (2.06)	0.83 (2.43)	0.12 (1.93)	4.02 (6.43)	2.96 (5.66)	1.08 (5.50)	2.37 (5.16)	1.33 (4.18)	1.91 (4.64)	1.12 (3.34)
First stage	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.56 (0.09)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.31 (0.14)	0.30 (0.14)	0.29 (0.14)	0.30 (0.14)	0.30 (0.14)	0.30 (0.14)	0.28 (0.16)

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's Aggregated Exports-to-GDP ratio after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Coblenz et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

F.2.2 Specification with Fixed Effects for Year

Appendix Table F5. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome: h (years)	Change in Aggregated Exports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h																							
	All elections						Presidential						Legislative											
	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)			
+1	4.17 (1.78)	3.22 (1.35)	1.67 (1.18)	2.56 (1.23)	1.01 (1.19)	2.16 (1.12)	1.19 (1.13)	4.20 (1.53)	4.06 (1.50)	2.52 (1.23)	3.11 (1.26)	-0.09 (0.92)	2.33 (1.12)	0.20 (0.85)	12.35 (7.86)	12.58 (7.88)	11.07 (6.87)	12.34 (8.01)	13.72 (9.66)	11.31 (7.20)	11.57 (9.13)			
+2	3.54 (1.66)	3.52 (1.61)	2.87 (1.54)	2.95 (1.48)	1.33 (1.47)	2.54 (1.41)	0.50 (1.23)	-0.16 (1.37)	-0.14 (1.37)	-0.16 (1.33)	-0.19 (1.31)	-0.63 (1.19)	-0.31 (1.31)	-0.78 (1.14)	18.44 (10.54)	17.95 (10.53)	16.04 (9.89)	16.56 (10.18)	10.89 (8.19)	14.53 (8.65)	20.76 (18.63)			
+3	4.16 (2.23)	3.78 (2.06)	2.20 (1.79)	2.72 (1.74)	0.81 (1.61)	2.26 (1.57)	0.81 (1.48)	0.25 (1.57)	0.25 (1.57)	0.58 (1.62)	0.03 (1.46)	-1.03 (1.25)	-0.11 (1.40)	-0.66 (1.25)	16.57 (9.33)	14.50 (8.17)	10.13 (7.31)	11.88 (7.05)	6.31 (6.16)	10.59 (6.21)	11.26 (9.76)			
+4	4.35 (2.66)	4.12 (2.57)	1.79 (2.25)	3.36 (2.38)	1.77 (2.15)	2.68 (2.13)	-0.12 (1.65)	1.95 (2.50)	1.90 (2.46)	-0.28 (2.08)	1.20 (2.28)	0.42 (1.84)	0.81 (2.19)	-0.75 (1.45)	14.95 (11.29)	13.13 (10.08)	11.13 (9.32)	12.10 (9.48)	6.33 (6.61)	10.78 (8.67)	8.41 (6.29)			
First stage	0.49 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.48 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.46 (0.07)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.17 (0.09)	0.16 (0.10)	0.17 (0.09)	0.16 (0.10)	0.15 (0.09)	0.17 (0.09)	0.13 (0.08)			
Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓			

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's Aggregated Exports-to-GDP ratio after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Coblenz et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

F.2.3 Specification with Fixed Effects for Year and Region

Appendix Table F6. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome: h (years)		Change in Aggregated Exports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h																			
		All elections						Presidential						Legislative							
		Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)
+1	3.31 (2.02)	2.34 (1.39)	1.34 (1.16)	1.95 (1.18)	0.46 (1.04)	1.65 (1.06)	0.84 (1.08)	3.10 (1.46)	3.00 (1.43)	1.83 (1.25)	2.35 (1.21)	0.25 (0.93)	1.91 (1.10)	0.56 (0.87)	7.31 (6.89)	8.52 (5.48)	6.80 (4.70)	8.15 (5.27)	7.60 (5.12)	7.79 (5.04)	10.12 (8.11)
+2	3.70 (1.78)	3.33 (1.64)	2.46 (1.45)	2.70 (1.49)	0.69 (1.43)	2.05 (1.35)	-0.22 (1.21)	-1.18 (1.35)	-1.19 (1.35)	-1.16 (1.30)	-1.13 (1.32)	-1.77 (1.23)	-1.28 (1.30)	-1.57 (8.50)	14.71 (8.06)	13.61 (8.06)	12.32 (7.12)	12.01 (7.39)	8.32 (6.12)	10.97 (6.81)	14.00 (11.06)
+3	3.25 (2.19)	2.95 (2.05)	1.38 (1.75)	2.07 (1.78)	0.10 (1.54)	1.63 (1.60)	-0.52 (1.59)	-1.32 (1.51)	-1.32 (1.51)	-1.31 (1.51)	-1.51 (1.46)	-1.90 (1.30)	-1.64 (1.41)	-1.57 (1.24)	11.99 (9.04)	10.61 (7.67)	7.12 (5.23)	8.49 (6.26)	4.96 (5.42)	7.75 (5.54)	12.76 (11.39)
+4	2.74 (2.50)	2.84 (2.53)	1.05 (2.34)	2.38 (2.37)	1.18 (2.24)	1.93 (2.14)	-0.52 (1.83)	0.58 (2.41)	0.54 (2.38)	-2.49 (1.98)	-0.09 (2.22)	-0.86 (1.80)	-0.29 (2.14)	-2.54 (1.53)	7.66 (7.66)	8.00 (7.39)	7.20 (6.29)	7.77 (6.96)	5.83 (5.98)	7.04 (6.31)	7.32 (5.71)
First stage	0.47 (0.07)	0.47 (0.07)	0.47 (0.07)	0.48 (0.07)	0.49 (0.06)	0.48 (0.07)	0.46 (0.07)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.19 (0.10)	0.19 (0.11)	0.20 (0.10)	0.19 (0.11)	0.19 (0.10)	0.19 (0.11)	0.13 (0.08)
Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Region FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's Aggregated Exports-to-GDP ratio after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Coblenz et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

F.3 Aggregate Δ Imports-to-GDP

F.3.1 Baseline Model

Appendix Table F7. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Imports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948-2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:		Change in Aggregated Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h																						
h (years)	All elections								Presidential								Legislative							
	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)			
+1	-0.79 (1.48)	-0.94 (1.45)	-1.24 (1.42)	-1.06 (1.41)	-1.21 (1.39)	-0.96 (1.30)	-0.70 (1.20)	-0.58 (1.84)	-0.54 (1.84)	0.08 (1.70)	-0.30 (1.78)	-0.65 (1.68)	-0.37 (1.71)	0.02 (1.57)	-2.09 (3.26)	-2.07 (3.04)	-2.59 (3.41)	-2.16 (3.00)	-1.04 (2.70)	-1.82 (2.76)	-0.76 (2.85)			
+2	-0.86 (1.69)	-0.87 (1.61)	-0.96 (1.54)	-1.04 (1.51)	-1.41 (1.35)	-0.99 (1.40)	-0.69 (1.12)	-3.57 (2.23)	-2.37 (2.18)	-1.13 (1.93)	-2.54 (1.89)	-2.57 (1.82)	-2.58 (1.86)	-2.14 (1.75)	0.12 (3.80)	0.15 (3.75)	-0.09 (3.68)	-0.09 (3.44)	-2.32 (3.26)	-0.51 (3.04)	-1.94 (3.38)			
+3	-0.56 (1.81)	-0.81 (1.82)	-1.03 (1.74)	-1.11 (1.61)	-1.22 (1.48)	-1.01 (1.45)	-0.67 (1.38)	-3.06 (2.29)	-2.07 (2.23)	-2.01 (2.27)	-2.28 (2.14)	-2.40 (2.03)	-2.15 (1.89)	-1.84 (3.93)	0.59 (3.53)	-0.10 (3.60)	-2.80 (3.07)	-0.67 (2.45)	-0.45 (3.11)	-0.80 (3.48)	0.56 (3.56)			
+4	0.19 (2.11)	-0.10 (1.97)	-0.65 (1.77)	-0.28 (1.74)	-0.27 (1.50)	-0.25 (1.63)	-0.81 (1.31)	-1.63 (2.41)	-1.23 (2.43)	-1.00 (2.45)	-1.74 (2.37)	-1.86 (2.27)	-1.69 (2.27)	-0.98 (2.02)	0.29 (4.38)	0.02 (3.97)	-0.63 (3.58)	0.08 (3.76)	1.14 (3.60)	-0.03 (3.36)	-0.39 (2.78)			
First stage	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.58 (0.09)	0.58 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.58 (0.09)	0.56 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.30 (0.14)	0.31 (0.13)	0.31 (0.14)	0.31 (0.13)	0.32 (0.14)	0.31 (0.13)	0.34 (0.16)			

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's Aggregated Imports-to-GDP ratio after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Cohokio et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; and "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

F.3.2 Specification with Fixed Effects for Year

Appendix Table F8. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Imports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948-2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h																					
h (years)	All elections						Presidential						Legislative									
	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	
+1	0.21 (1.45)	-0.11 (1.39)	-0.48 (1.38)	-0.39 (1.36)	-0.99 (1.46)	-0.35 (1.25)	0.04 (1.01)	0.08 (1.36)	0.24 (1.32)	0.39 (1.27)	0.37 (1.27)	0.30 (1.22)	0.40 (1.21)	0.47 (1.10)	-0.55 (3.76)	-0.73 (3.51)	-1.64 (3.51)	-0.94 (3.39)	1.23 (3.08)	-0.35 (3.14)	1.84 (2.72)	
+2	0.51 (2.04)	0.43 (1.90)	0.49 (2.09)	0.11 (1.86)	-0.97 (1.53)	0.04 (1.77)	0.08 (1.21)	-3.11 (1.98)	-2.85 (1.68)	-1.24 (1.35)	-2.60 (1.30)	-2.46 (1.25)	-2.59 (1.12)	-2.17 (5.15)	4.28 (5.39)	4.39 (5.48)	4.52 (5.16)	3.82 (5.16)	1.84 (4.11)	3.05 (4.84)	2.82 (4.48)	
+3	-1.76 (2.39)	-1.27 (2.05)	-1.71 (2.33)	-2.17 (1.98)	-2.12 (1.79)	-2.12 (1.81)	-1.02 (1.48)	-3.41 (1.84)	-3.45 (1.59)	-3.43 (1.52)	-3.31 (1.45)	-3.03 (1.29)	-3.34 (1.33)	-2.97 (1.26)	0.16 (8.60)	-3.05 (7.33)	-9.55 (7.85)	-4.75 (6.62)	-1.13 (4.11)	-3.44 (5.94)	3.06 (4.40)	
+4	-0.31 (2.23)	-0.46 (2.09)	-1.55 (2.00)	-0.77 (1.91)	-0.38 (1.55)	-0.77 (1.80)	-1.47 (1.41)	-3.28 (1.67)	-2.28 (1.74)	-2.67 (1.71)	-3.25 (1.60)	-3.46 (1.49)	-3.39 (1.48)	-1.58 (1.24)	2.31 (8.50)	-1.69 (8.58)	-1.05 (8.80)	-0.76 (8.44)	7.29 (9.76)	-0.27 (7.64)	2.28 (4.99)	
First stage	0.49 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.50 (0.07)	0.48 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.47 (0.07)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.17 (0.09)	0.17 (0.09)	0.18 (0.09)	0.17 (0.08)	0.19 (0.09)	0.18 (0.08)	0.21 (0.09)	
Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's Aggregated Imports-to-GDP ratio after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Cohokio et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; and "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

F.3.3 Specification with Fixed Effects for Year and Region

Appendix Table F9. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Imports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948-2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome: h (years)		Change in Aggregated Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h																					
		All elections						Presidential						Legislative									
		Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	
+1	-0.24 (1.45)	-0.50 (1.40)	-0.94 (1.36)	-0.84 (1.37)	-1.78 (1.50)	-0.81 (1.26)	-0.39 (0.94)	-1.75 (1.27)	-1.69 (1.26)	-0.23 (1.18)	-0.04 (1.18)	-1.17 (1.13)	0.01 (1.12)	-0.34 (1.06)	-1.73 (3.73)	-1.75 (3.68)	-2.35 (3.59)	-1.84 (3.59)	0.26 (3.38)	-1.35 (3.35)	1.25 (2.82)		
+2	1.34 (1.82)	1.15 (1.67)	0.96 (1.63)	0.57 (1.62)	-0.92 (1.39)	0.20 (1.51)	-0.85 (1.35)	-4.63 (1.95)	-4.21 (1.71)	-1.35 (1.33)	-3.70 (1.21)	-3.63 (1.27)	-3.68 (1.15)	-3.62 (4.15)	3.11 (4.14)	3.10 (4.19)	3.19 (4.15)	3.65 (4.15)	1.33 (3.62)	2.96 (3.27)	1.79 (3.70)		
+3	-0.25 (2.00)	-0.23 (1.91)	-0.96 (2.07)	-1.19 (1.72)	-1.42 (1.62)	-1.40 (1.59)	-1.53 (1.47)	-4.85 (1.86)	-4.93 (1.65)	-4.17 (1.55)	-4.60 (1.49)	-3.98 (1.31)	-4.52 (1.37)	-4.14 (1.31)	1.64 (6.39)	2.05 (4.50)	-2.03 (3.75)	-0.09 (3.90)	-1.30 (3.67)	-0.41 (3.85)	3.73 (3.25)		
+4	-0.57 (2.08)	-0.60 (1.96)	-1.13 (1.78)	-0.69 (1.77)	-0.13 (1.53)	-0.59 (1.66)	-1.05 (1.38)	-6.72 (1.68)	-5.83 (1.61)	-5.31 (1.65)	-6.43 (1.55)	-5.12 (1.41)	-5.83 (1.44)	-2.63 (1.26)	-0.76 (6.81)	3.56 (5.51)	-0.98 (6.76)	3.46 (5.09)	5.20 (6.57)	1.53 (5.56)	2.00 (4.58)		
First stage	0.49 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.48 (0.07)	0.49 (0.07)	0.47 (0.07)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.19 (0.10)	0.19 (0.10)	0.20 (0.10)	0.19 (0.10)	0.18 (0.10)	0.19 (0.10)	0.20 (0.10)		
Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		
Region FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓		

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's Aggregated Imports-to-GDP ratio after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Cohokio et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; and "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

F.4 Aggregate Δ Trade-to-GDP

F.4.1 Baseline Model

Appendix Table F10. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Trade-to-GDP: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948-2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Trade-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h																				
h (years)	All elections						Presidential						Legislative								
	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)
+1	0.82 (2.49)	0.30 (2.29)	-0.84 (2.18)	-0.17 (2.17)	-1.82 (2.29)	-0.39 (2.00)	-1.08 (1.91)	0.55 (2.55)	0.61 (2.56)	0.85 (2.53)	0.48 (2.56)	-0.70 (2.47)	0.20 (2.48)	-0.86 (2.20)	1.68 (7.16)	-0.20 (4.68)	-4.90 (7.00)	-0.94 (4.97)	-2.17 (4.58)	-1.00 (3.90)	-0.54 (5.29)
+2	0.00 (2.82)	-0.16 (2.81)	-0.32 (2.70)	-0.06 (2.69)	0.38 (2.51)	0.15 (2.59)	0.48 (2.44)	-4.35 (3.11)	-3.67 (3.05)	-2.00 (2.75)	-3.40 (2.77)	-2.85 (2.68)	-3.30 (2.73)	-2.43 (2.66)	4.52 (8.00)	3.59 (6.65)	2.26 (6.07)	3.49 (7.19)	1.74 (6.21)	3.30 (6.85)	3.15 (5.16)
+3	1.12 (3.42)	0.39 (3.10)	-1.01 (2.76)	-0.03 (2.88)	-0.73 (2.55)	0.02 (2.72)	1.35 (2.40)	-2.81 (3.55)	-2.75 (3.55)	-2.60 (3.57)	-2.61 (3.51)	-2.11 (3.42)	-2.55 (3.48)	-2.23 (3.47)	6.33 (9.28)	4.37 (7.60)	-0.58 (6.21)	2.64 (6.36)	0.06 (7.73)	2.47 (5.89)	-0.01 (6.03)
+4	1.79 (3.78)	1.74 (3.62)	0.70 (3.31)	1.60 (3.44)	0.76 (3.12)	1.43 (3.16)	1.39 (2.52)	-0.79 (4.09)	0.20 (4.03)	0.59 (4.00)	-0.47 (4.03)	1.21 (3.65)	-0.31 (3.80)	0.56 (3.43)	4.02 (9.82)	3.03 (8.56)	1.62 (7.96)	2.83 (8.09)	2.78 (7.11)	2.66 (7.26)	2.38 (6.68)
First stage	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.56 (0.10)	0.57 (0.09)	0.58 (0.09)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.30 (0.14)	0.32 (0.13)	0.29 (0.16)	0.30 (0.14)	0.31 (0.13)	0.32 (0.13)	0.29 (0.17)

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's Aggregated Trade-to-GDP ratio after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Calónico et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h=1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are conventional coefficients.

F.4.2 Specification with Fixed Effects for Year

Appendix Table F11. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Trade-to-GDP: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948-2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:		Change in Aggregated Trade-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h																				
h (years)		All elections						Presidential						Legislative								
		Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)
+1		4.97	4.19	2.63	3.22	0.74	2.61	1.52	4.33	4.20	4.02	3.85	1.94	3.40	1.36	11.59	10.40	10.31	9.25	10.30	9.24	10.83
	(2.54)	(2.30)	(2.28)	(2.17)	(2.04)	(2.04)	(1.86)	(2.62)	(2.55)	(2.40)	(2.30)	(2.08)	(2.23)	(1.91)	(1.83)	(8.11)	(9.28)	(7.48)	(9.36)	(6.79)	(7.30)	
+2		4.90	4.56	4.31	3.99	2.66	3.69	2.36	-3.05	-2.58	-1.68	-2.12	-2.05	-2.15	-2.64	22.56	21.19	18.37	18.59	14.67	17.73	19.52
	(3.18)	(3.12)	(3.39)	(2.98)	(2.90)	(2.87)	(3.12)	(2.58)	(2.45)	(2.26)	(2.15)	(2.07)	(2.09)	(2.01)	(14.45)	(12.45)	(11.53)	(10.62)	(11.09)	(10.21)	(13.51)	
+3		4.00	2.95	0.98	2.11	0.52	1.76	2.10	-2.67	-2.76	-2.81	-2.75	-2.42	-2.71	-2.44	19.74	14.72	3.83	11.06	13.04	10.79	11.09
	(3.84)	(3.46)	(3.06)	(3.18)	(2.75)	(2.98)	(2.37)	(2.79)	(2.68)	(2.51)	(2.56)	(2.42)	(2.49)	(2.37)	(16.46)	(14.25)	(10.10)	(12.14)	(10.94)	(11.41)	(10.31)	
+4		4.43	3.84	2.02	3.36	1.83	2.90	1.40	-1.27	-1.62	-1.65	-1.59	1.40	-1.36	-0.73	17.77	13.48	10.39	12.27	8.31	11.71	10.05
	(4.02)	(3.86)	(3.55)	(3.70)	(3.30)	(3.42)	(2.75)	(3.29)	(3.22)	(3.19)	(3.19)	(3.08)	(3.02)	(2.83)	(18.00)	(15.72)	(13.53)	(15.09)	(10.27)	(13.74)	(9.23)	
First stage		0.48	0.48	0.48	0.48	0.50	0.48	0.49	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	1.00	0.17	0.17	0.17	0.17	0.17	0.18	0.18
	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.07)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.00)	(0.09)	(0.09)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.09)	(0.08)	(0.08)
Year FE		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's Aggregated Trade-to-GDP ratio after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Calónico et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; and "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h=1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

F.4.3 Specification with Fixed Effects for Year and Region

Appendix Table F12. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Trade-to-GDP: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948-2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:		Change in Aggregated Trade-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h																				
h (years)		All elections						Presidential						Legislative								
		Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)	Raw	W(1 99)	T(1 99)	W(3 97)	T(3 97)	W(5 95)	T(5 95)
+1		3.00 (2.53)	2.13 (2.29)	0.39 (2.51)	1.15 (2.18)	-0.41 (2.15)	0.68 (2.16)	1.87 (2.11)	1.02 (2.53)	0.93 (2.40)	0.93 (2.26)	0.77 (2.12)	-1.19 (1.97)	0.28 (2.05)	-0.56 (1.80)	5.30 (8.20)	5.07 (6.05)	4.30 (5.84)	6.00 (5.99)	6.26 (6.73)	6.39 (5.91)	12.71 (10.23)
+2		4.72 (3.12)	4.25 (2.91)	3.83 (2.84)	3.62 (2.68)	1.93 (2.82)	3.35 (2.60)	2.03 (2.70)	-5.60 (2.58)	-4.87 (2.47)	-4.03 (2.19)	-4.33 (2.14)	-4.30 (2.03)	-4.43 (2.06)	-4.85 (1.91)	16.09 (11.14)	14.95 (10.51)	13.11 (9.42)	13.33 (9.53)	12.07 (9.39)	13.96 (9.85)	15.08 (9.72)
+3		3.81 (3.71)	2.72 (3.34)	0.49 (3.00)	1.62 (3.08)	-0.61 (2.74)	1.15 (2.89)	0.96 (2.50)	-5.98 (2.75)	-6.09 (2.63)	-6.40 (2.47)	-6.04 (2.50)	-5.34 (2.32)	-5.97 (2.43)	-5.53 (2.29)	11.18 (14.18)	7.03 (11.46)	-1.09 (8.44)	5.66 (9.24)	8.01 (7.85)	6.17 (8.40)	7.03 (6.93)
+4		3.15 (3.89)	2.15 (3.73)	-0.04 (3.57)	1.55 (3.64)	0.41 (3.45)	1.41 (3.35)	0.53 (2.61)	-6.09 (3.12)	-6.48 (3.10)	-6.44 (3.11)	-3.12 (3.08)	-5.46 (3.06)	-2.16 (2.91)	6.14 (11.77)	5.95 (11.88)	5.55 (10.79)	9.44 (11.87)	5.10 (8.17)	8.68 (8.17)	6.83 (10.40)	7.16 (10.60)
First stage		0.48 (0.07)	0.48 (0.07)	0.47 (0.08)	0.48 (0.07)	0.48 (0.07)	0.47 (0.08)	0.48 (0.08)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.19 (0.10)	0.20 (0.10)	0.21 (0.10)	0.19 (0.09)	0.20 (0.10)	0.19 (0.10)	0.16 (0.09)

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's Aggregated Trade-to-GDP ratio after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t-1$ and $t+h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Calónico et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the use of a dataset winsorized (W) or trimmed (T) at the: "(1 99)" means 1st and 99th percentiles; and "(3 97)" means 3rd and 97th percentiles; and "(5 95)" means 5th and 95th percentiles. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h=1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

G Alternative Bandwidth Selection Criteria

G.1 Δ Tariff

Appendix Table G1. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Tariff Rates: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1966–2020, TPe: Data from WITS)

Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Tariff Rates between t-1 and t+h														
h (years)	All elections					Presidential					Legislative				
	MSE1	MSE2	IK1	CER1	CER2	MSE1	MSE2	IK1	CER1	CER2	MSE1	MSE2	IK1	CER1	CER2
+1	0.25 (0.31)	0.35 (0.31)	0.25 (0.30)	0.20 (0.31)	0.28 (0.31)	0.27 (0.37)	0.37 (0.35)	0.27 (0.38)	0.29 (0.38)	0.38 (0.36)	0.19 (0.45)	0.26 (0.49)	0.14 (0.45)	0.10 (0.45)	0.17 (0.47)
+2	0.30 (0.40)	0.45 (0.41)	0.28 (0.40)	0.25 (0.39)	0.47 (0.42)	0.18 (0.54)	0.32 (0.54)	0.22 (0.53)	0.21 (0.54)	0.32 (0.55)	0.85 (0.69)	1.05 (0.82)	0.78 (0.68)	0.88 (0.72)	0.96 (0.75)
+3	0.08 (0.55)	0.08 (0.55)	0.09 (0.56)	0.11 (0.56)	0.27 (0.55)	0.09 (0.74)	0.06 (0.72)	0.12 (0.73)	0.13 (0.74)	0.12 (0.73)	0.57 (0.64)	0.94 (0.77)	0.49 (0.57)	0.35 (0.51)	0.55 (0.49)
+4	0.30 (0.71)	0.28 (0.70)	0.29 (0.71)	0.31 (0.72)	0.49 (0.71)	0.43 (1.01)	0.36 (1.02)	0.51 (1.02)	0.53 (1.03)	0.52 (1.03)	0.20 (0.58)	0.63 (0.68)	0.09 (0.54)	-0.10 (0.53)	0.37 (0.45)
First stage	0.57 (0.09)	0.55 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.56 (0.10)	0.56 (0.09)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.27 (0.15)	0.26 (0.15)	0.26 (0.15)	0.26 (0.15)	0.26 (0.15)

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated tariff after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t - 1$ and $t + h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Calonico et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the bandwidth selection criterion: "MSE" and "CER" are the MSE- and CER-optimal bandwidths (Calonico et al., 2017); "1" means a single bandwidth is used on both sides of the threshold; and "2" means different bandwidths below and above the cutoff; and "S" means for the sum of regression estimates. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

G.2 Δ Exports-to-GDP

Appendix Table G2. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Exports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h														
h (years)	All elections					Presidential					Legislative				
	MSE1	MSE2	MSES	CER1	CER2	MSE1	MSE2	MSES	CER1	CER2	MSE1	MSE2	MSES	CER1	CER2
+1	1.67 (1.75)	1.62 (1.71)	1.68 (1.73)	1.99 (1.86)	1.96 (1.82)	0.76 (1.56)	0.84 (1.56)	0.75 (1.55)	0.91 (1.53)	0.69 (1.51)	3.98 (4.77)	2.16 (4.12)	4.09 (4.82)	3.89 (5.24)	1.74 (4.30)
+2	1.10 (1.72)	1.13 (1.64)	1.23 (1.75)	0.89 (1.82)	1.07 (1.76)	-0.46 (1.48)	-0.29 (1.44)	-0.41 (1.49)	-0.57 (1.45)	-0.60 (1.45)	4.18 (5.19)	3.23 (4.42)	3.71 (4.09)	3.62 (5.12)	1.90 (4.24)
+3	1.92 (2.27)	2.32 (2.11)	1.98 (2.30)	1.84 (2.44)	2.10 (2.29)	-0.04 (1.82)	0.28 (1.79)	-0.04 (1.85)	-0.16 (1.96)	-0.11 (1.89)	5.96 (6.25)	5.69 (6.12)	5.99 (6.26)	5.68 (6.57)	4.99 (6.00)
+4	1.81 (2.61)	2.03 (2.47)	1.87 (2.63)	2.22 (2.81)	2.36 (2.67)	1.01 (2.70)	1.48 (2.66)	1.15 (2.73)	1.39 (2.85)	1.57 (2.77)	4.02 (6.43)	3.67 (6.13)	4.05 (6.35)	3.85 (6.64)	3.08 (6.10)
First stage	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.56 (0.09)	0.56 (0.09)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.31 (0.14)	0.31 (0.14)	0.30 (0.14)	0.30 (0.14)	0.32 (0.14)

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated exports after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t - 1$ and $t + h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Calonico et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the bandwidth selection criterion: "MSE" and "CER" are the MSE- and CER-optimal bandwidths (Calonico et al., 2017); "1" means a single bandwidth is used on both sides of the threshold; and "2" means different bandwidths below and above the cutoff; and "S" means for the sum of regression estimates. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

G.3 Δ Imports-to-GDP

Appendix Table G3. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Imports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined Data)

Outcome:		Change in Aggregated Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h													
h (years)	All elections					Presidential					Legislative				
	MSE1	MSE2	MSES	CER1	CER2	MSE1	MSE2	MSES	CER1	CER2	MSE1	MSE2	MSES	CER1	CER2
+1	-0.79 (1.48)	-0.98 (1.45)	-0.84 (1.49)	-1.08 (1.51)	-1.23 (1.48)	-0.58 (1.84)	-0.10 (1.71)	-0.27 (1.81)	-0.94 (1.85)	-0.69 (1.69)	-2.09 (3.26)	-2.25 (3.43)	-2.09 (3.22)	-2.73 (3.58)	-2.52 (3.64)
+2	-0.86 (1.69)	-1.10 (1.70)	-0.90 (1.69)	-1.81 (1.75)	-1.96 (1.75)	-3.57 (2.23)	-2.41 (1.87)	-2.36 (2.19)	-4.20 (2.41)	-3.12 (1.90)	0.12 (3.80)	0.19 (4.07)	0.20 (3.66)	-0.79 (4.11)	-0.46 (4.14)
+3	-0.56 (1.81)	-0.91 (1.82)	-0.66 (1.83)	-1.62 (1.88)	-1.99 (1.88)	-3.06 (2.29)	-2.73 (1.93)	-3.02 (2.30)	-3.71 (2.48)	-2.82 (1.98)	0.59 (3.93)	0.45 (3.70)	0.58 (3.90)	-0.22 (4.23)	0.04 (4.13)
+4	0.19 (2.11)	0.07 (2.06)	0.10 (2.13)	-0.87 (2.04)	-1.07 (2.00)	-1.63 (2.41)	-1.37 (2.21)	-1.32 (2.46)	-2.46 (2.41)	-1.56 (2.29)	0.29 (4.38)	0.14 (4.44)	-0.05 (4.58)	-1.19 (4.68)	-1.39 (4.18)
First stage	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.56 (0.09)	0.56 (0.09)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.30 (0.14)	0.31 (0.14)	0.30 (0.14)	0.30 (0.15)	0.31 (0.14)

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated imports-to-GDP after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t - 1$ and $t + h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Calonico et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the bandwidth selection criterion: "MSE" and "CER" are the MSE- and CER-optimal bandwidths (Calonico et al., 2017); "1" means a single bandwidth is used on both sides of the threshold; and "2" means different bandwidths below and above the cutoff; and "S" means for the sum of regression estimates. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

G.4 Δ Trade-to-GDP

Appendix Table G4. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2022, Gravity: Combined data)

Outcome:		Change in Aggregated Trade-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h													
h (years)	All elections					Presidential					Legislative				
	MSE1	MSE2	MSES	CER1	CER2	MSE1	MSE2	MSES	CER1	CER2	MSE1	MSE2	MSES	CER1	CER2
+1	0.82 (2.49)	0.64 (2.45)	0.83 (2.48)	0.82 (2.60)	0.62 (2.58)	0.55 (2.55)	0.52 (2.55)	0.45 (2.56)	-0.06 (2.52)	-0.06 (2.52)	1.68 (7.16)	-1.27 (6.12)	1.88 (6.76)	1.18 (7.72)	-1.32 (6.32)
+2	0.00 (2.82)	-0.19 (2.84)	-0.06 (2.85)	-0.70 (3.00)	-0.95 (3.00)	-4.35 (3.11)	-2.90 (2.64)	-2.74 (3.09)	-5.45 (3.34)	-3.47 (2.70)	4.52 (8.00)	4.09 (8.07)	2.93 (9.14)	3.13 (8.55)	2.02 (7.82)
+3	1.12 (3.42)	1.28 (3.35)	1.12 (3.44)	0.08 (3.63)	0.37 (3.55)	-2.81 (3.55)	-2.54 (3.36)	-1.41 (3.24)	-4.12 (3.74)	-3.92 (3.52)	6.33 (9.28)	5.75 (9.18)	5.07 (7.89)	5.16 (9.84)	4.17 (9.29)
+4	1.79 (3.78)	1.63 (3.81)	1.77 (3.76)	1.10 (3.90)	0.90 (3.92)	-0.79 (4.09)	-0.11 (3.98)	0.11 (4.03)	-0.59 (4.24)	-0.97 (4.03)	4.02 (9.82)	2.90 (9.22)	3.21 (8.33)	2.35 (10.13)	2.10 (8.74)
First stage	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.57 (0.09)	0.56 (0.09)	0.56 (0.09)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.30 (0.14)	0.32 (0.14)	0.30 (0.14)	0.30 (0.15)	0.33 (0.14)

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated trade-to-GDP after the election, estimated via Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Each row reports the effect of a left-wing victory on the change in the outcome between $t - 1$ and $t + h$, with t being the election year. We use kernel-weighted local linear regressions (triangular kernel) following the bias-corrected procedure of (Calonico et al., 2014). Column headings indicate the bandwidth selection criterion: "MSE" and "CER" are the MSE- and CER-optimal bandwidths (Calonico et al., 2017); "1" means a single bandwidth is used on both sides of the threshold; and "2" means different bandwidths below and above the cutoff; and "S" means for the sum of regression estimates. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. Standard errors (in parentheses) are bias-corrected and clustered at the country level. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients.

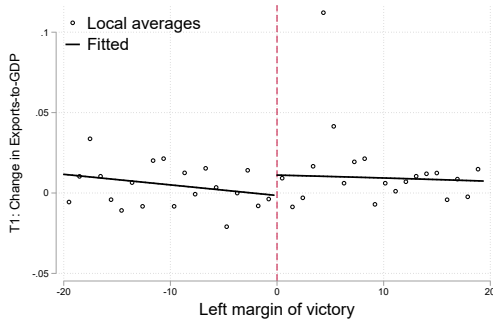
H Robustness Checks with IMF, COMTRADE, and GMD Data

H.1 Exports-to-GDP

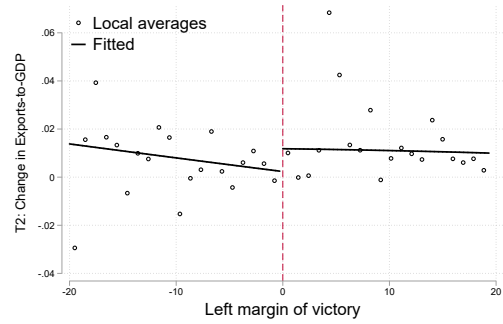
H.1.1 Disaggregated Exports-to-GDP - IMF Data

Appendix Figure H1. Left-Wing Electoral Margin and Exports - (1948-2020)

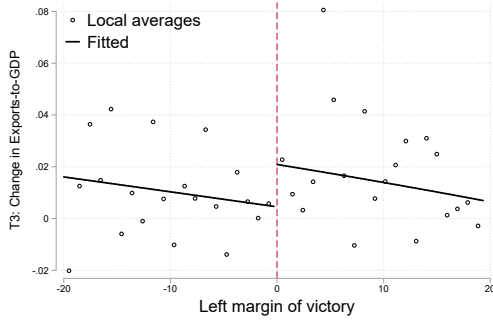
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



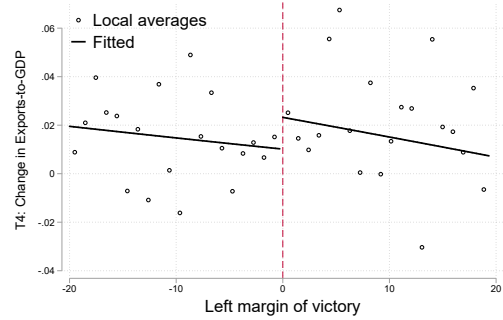
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure H1a to Figure H1d illustrate changes in exports-to-GDP. The vertical axis shows the percentage change in the Disaggregated Exports-to-GDP ratio over four years post-election. The horizontal axis reflects the left's margin of victory. Points on the scatterplot represent the mean outcomes of the forcing variable. Fitted lines are derived using kernel-weighted local linear regression with MSE-optimal bandwidth. We perform Fuzzy RD estimation with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

*

Appendix Table H1. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2020, Gravity: IMF Data Reported by Country of Destiny)

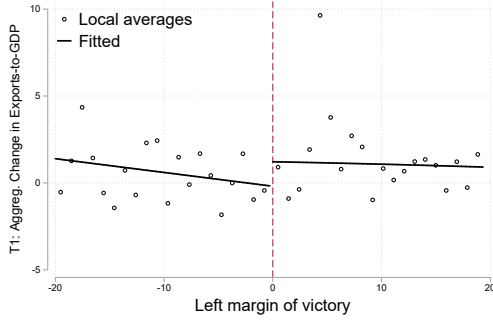
Outcome:		Change in Exports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)		All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1		0.02 (0.02)	0.04*** (0.02)	0.05*** (0.02)	0.01 (0.01)	0.06*** (0.02)	0.15*** (0.02)	0.04 (0.04)	0.11** (0.06)	0.04 (0.03)
+2		0.01 (0.01)	0.04*** (0.02)	0.03* (0.02)	-0.01 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.03*** (0.01)	0.04 (0.04)	0.15** (0.09)	0.06** (0.03)
+3		0.02 (0.02)	0.05** (0.02)	0.06*** (0.02)	0.00 (0.02)	0.03* (0.02)	0.13*** (0.01)	0.05 (0.05)	0.16** (0.11)	0.02 (0.04)
+4		0.02 (0.02)	0.05* (0.03)	0.06*** (0.02)	0.00 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.11*** (0.02)	0.04 (0.05)	0.15* (0.10)	-0.02 (0.04)
First stage		0.53*** (0.09)	0.46*** (0.07)	0.47*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.28* (0.13)	0.18 (0.09)	0.29*** (0.09)
Year FE			✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Country FE				✓			✓			✓
Obs		105,715	105,715	105,715	32,444	32,444	32,444	73,271	73,271	73,271
Eff. obs		61,363	53,219	33,422	18,160	12,805	12,840	38,462	30,092	20,184

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's exports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and “All elections”) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. “First stage” refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. “Eff. obs” denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

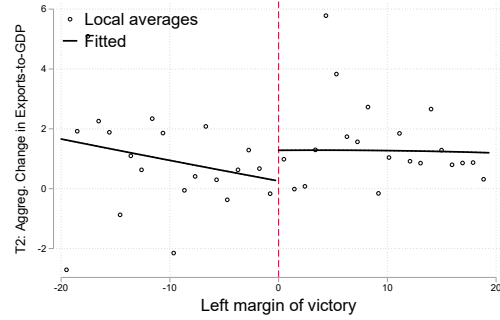
H.1.2 Aggregated Exports-to-GDP - IMF Data

Appendix Figure H2. Left-Wing Electoral Margin and Aggregated Exports - (1948-2020)

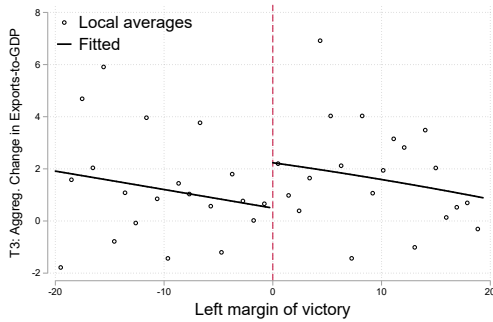
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



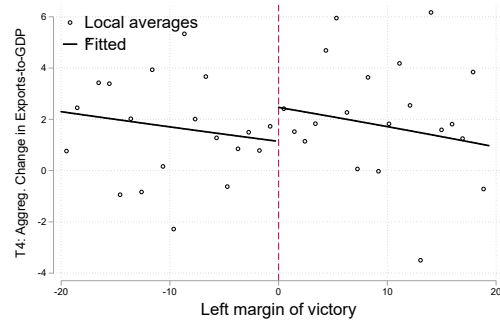
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure H2a to Figure H2d illustrate changes in aggregated exports-to-GDP. The vertical axis shows the percentage change in the Aggregated Exports-to-GDP ratio over four years post-election. The horizontal axis reflects the left's margin of victory. Points on the scatterplot represent the mean outcomes of the forcing variable. Fitted lines are derived using kernel-weighted local linear regression with MSE-optimal bandwidth. We perform fuzzy RD estimation with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

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Appendix Table H2. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2020, Gravity: IMF Data Reported by Country of Destiny)

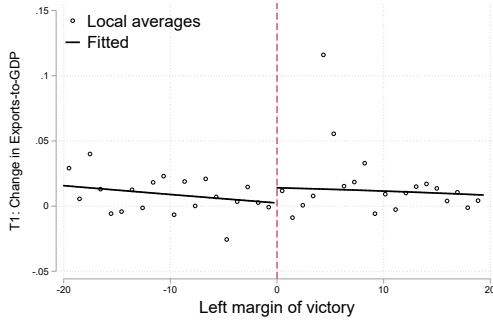
Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Exports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	1.89 (1.72)	4.07*** (1.75)	3.22 (2.12)	1.05 (1.54)	4.47*** (1.55)	3.29** (1.47)	4.09 (4.70)	10.64*** (5.72)	6.13 (6.43)
+2	1.08 (1.56)	3.12** (1.51)	3.04** (1.56)	-0.50 (1.36)	-0.40 (1.25)	-1.42* (1.23)	3.69 (4.82)	16.05*** (8.76)	11.65 (7.19)
+3	2.51 (2.30)	4.71** (2.24)	3.88* (2.24)	0.67 (1.78)	1.47 (1.58)	-0.17 (1.47)	6.10 (5.86)	15.83** (9.73)	10.07 (8.03)
+4	1.76 (2.61)	3.36 (2.47)	2.41 (2.46)	0.31 (2.30)	-1.15 (2.07)	-3.78** (1.95)	4.24 (6.57)	14.59* (10.70)	7.86 (7.73)
First stage	0.57*** (0.09)	0.49*** (0.07)	0.47*** (0.08)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.31** (0.14)	0.19 (0.08)	0.20 (0.10)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	948	948	948	352	352	352	596	596	596
Eff. obs	479	464	353	182	124	125	281	280	204

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated exports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

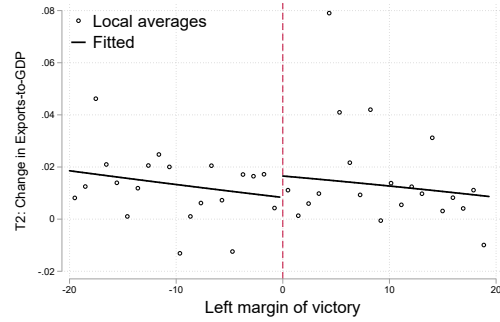
H.1.3 Disaggregated Exports-to-GDP - Comtrade Data

Appendix Figure H3. Left-Wing Electoral Margin and Exports - (1962-2020)

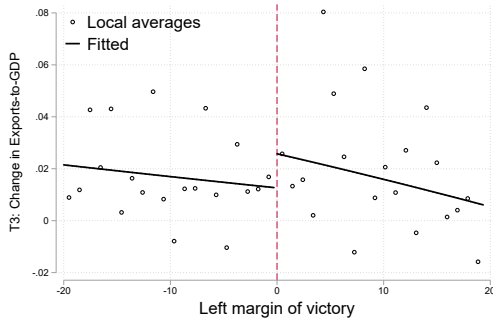
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



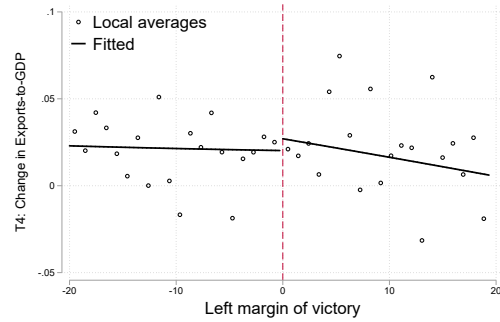
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure H3a to Figure H3d illustrate changes in exports-to-GDP. The vertical axis shows the percentage change in the Disaggregated Exports-to-GDP ratio over four years post-election. The horizontal axis reflects the left's margin of victory. Points on the scatterplot represent the mean outcomes of the forcing variable. Fitted lines are derived using kernel-weighted local linear regression with MSE-optimal bandwidth. We perform fuzzy RD estimation with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at country level.

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Appendix Table H3. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1962–2020, Gravity: Comtrade Data Reported by Country of Destiny)

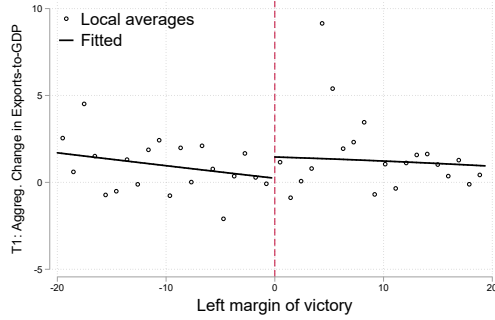
Outcome:	Change in Exports-to-GDP ratio between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	0.02 (0.02)	0.04*** (0.02)	0.04*** (0.01)	0.00 (0.02)	0.06*** (0.02)	0.23*** (0.02)	0.04 (0.03)	0.15 (0.13)	0.07*** (0.03)
+2	0.00 (0.02)	0.02 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.06*** (0.02)	0.04 (0.05)	0.21 (0.19)	0.08** (0.04)
+3	0.01 (0.02)	0.03 (0.03)	-0.10*** (0.00)	-0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.13*** (0.01)	0.06 (0.07)	0.20 (0.20)	0.04 (0.05)
+4	0.00 (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)	0.03** (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.02)	0.12*** (0.01)	0.04 (0.07)	0.18 (0.18)	-0.04 (0.04)
First stage	0.54*** (0.10)	0.47*** (0.08)	0.45*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.26 (0.14)	0.13 (0.11)	0.21* (0.09)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Country FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	89,954	89,954	89,954	30,378	30,378	30,378	59,576	59,576	59,576
Eff. obs	41,745	44,027	29,669	16,281	11,803	9,585	29,958	18,791	16,897

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's exports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and “All elections”) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. “First stage” refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. “Eff. obs” denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

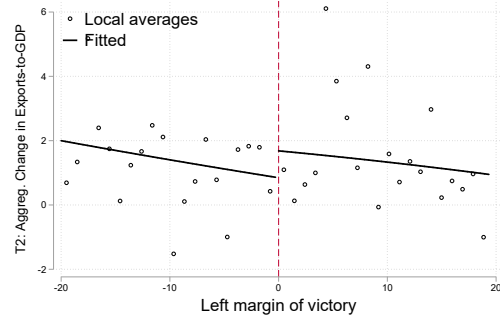
H.1.4 Aggregated Exports-to-GDP - Comtrade Data

Appendix Figure H4. Left-Wing Electoral Margin and Exports - (1962-2020)

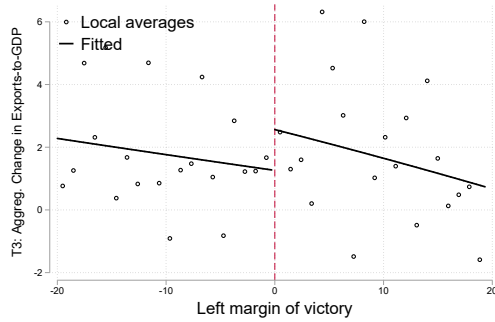
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



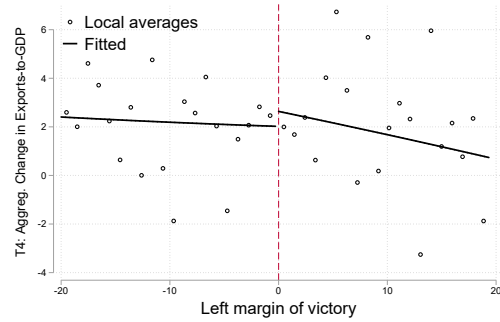
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure H4a to Figure H4d illustrate changes in aggregated exports. The vertical axis shows the average percentage change in the Aggregated Exports-to-GDP ratio over four years post-election. The horizontal axis reflects the left's margin of victory. Points on the scatterplot represent the mean outcomes of the forcing variable. Fitted lines are derived using kernel-weighted local linear regression with MSE-optimal bandwidth. We perform fuzzy RD estimation with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at country level.

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Appendix Table H4. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Exports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1962–2020, Gravity: Comtrade Data Reported by Country of Destiny)

Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Exports-to-GDP ratio between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	1.21 (1.36)	3.16** (1.45)	2.34 (1.58)	0.20 (1.50)	3.56*** (1.40)	2.94** (1.36)	2.33 (3.98)	13.75** (10.01)	7.61 (6.75)
+2	0.18 (1.50)	1.57 (1.59)	1.53 (1.53)	-1.21 (1.39)	-0.99 (1.24)	-1.87** (1.23)	3.00 (4.96)	17.63** (13.17)	12.68 (10.70)
+3	1.19 (1.92)	2.53 (2.15)	2.24 (2.15)	-0.80 (1.58)	-0.15 (1.46)	-0.98 (1.36)	6.48 (6.89)	12.47** (8.52)	13.20 (13.46)
+4	-0.06 (2.26)	1.03 (2.50)	0.97 (2.46)	-1.94 (2.10)	-2.44 (1.64)	-3.80*** (1.52)	3.98 (7.35)	15.61* (12.57)	4.50 (9.42)
First stage	0.58*** (0.09)	0.51*** (0.08)	0.49*** (0.09)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.29 (0.17)	0.14 (0.10)	0.17 (0.12)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	875	875	875	343	343	343	532	532	532
Eff. obs	427	415	319	172	122	122	186	181	172

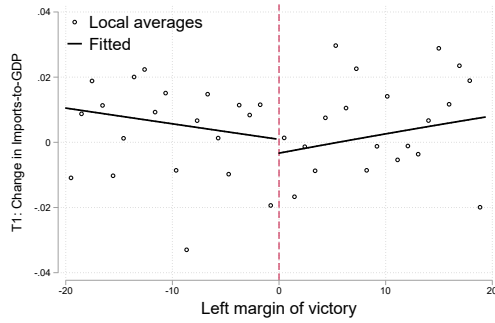
Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated exports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and “All elections”) and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. “First stage” refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. “Eff. obs” denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

H.2 Imports-to-GDP

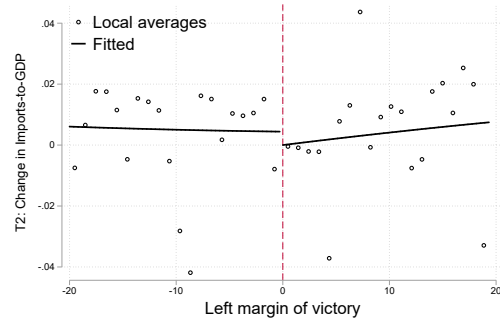
H.2.1 Disaggregated Imports-to-GDP - IMF Data

Appendix Figure H5. Left-Wing Electoral Margin and Imports - (1948-2020)

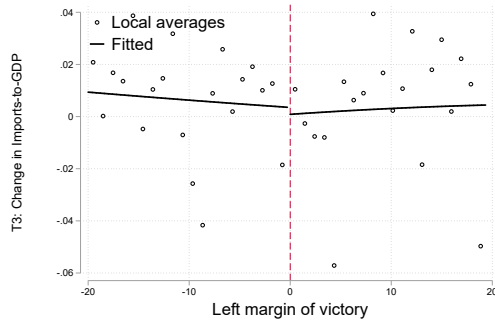
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



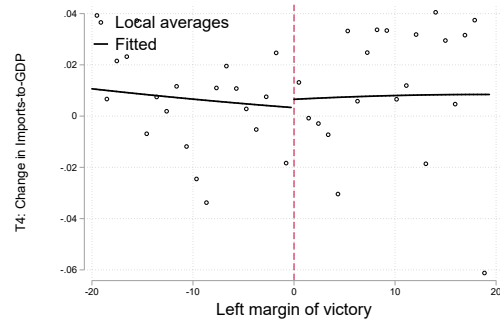
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure H5a to Figure H5d illustrate changes in imports-to-GDP. The vertical axis shows the percentage change in the Disaggregated Imports-to-GDP ratio over four years post-election. The horizontal axis reflects the left's margin of victory. Points on the scatterplot represent the mean outcomes of the forcing variable. Fitted lines are derived using kernel-weighted local linear regression with MSE-optimal bandwidth. We perform fuzzy RD estimation with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

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Appendix Table H5. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Imports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2020, Gravity: IMF Data Reported by Country of Destiny)

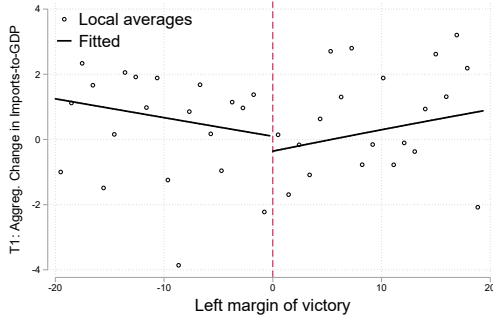
Outcome:	Change in Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	-0.01 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	0.01 (0.01)	-0.01 (0.02)	0.00 (0.01)	0.06*** (0.01)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.03 (0.02)
+2	-0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	-0.04** (0.02)	-0.03** (0.02)	-0.04 (0.02)	0.01 (0.03)	0.04 (0.04)	0.00 (0.05)
+3	-0.01 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.03 (0.02)	-0.04** (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	0.00 (0.03)	0.02 (0.05)	-0.03 (0.06)
+4	-0.00 (0.02)	0.00 (0.02)	-0.02 (0.02)	-0.03* (0.02)	-0.04*** (0.02)	-0.09*** (0.02)	0.01 (0.04)	0.05 (0.06)	-0.03 (0.04)
First stage	0.52*** (0.09)	0.46*** (0.07)	0.48*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.28* (0.13)	0.20* (0.08)	0.33*** (0.10)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Country FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	107,085	107,085	107,085	32,541	32,541	32,541	74,544	74,544	74,544
Eff. obs	52,067	49,901	35,334	14,723	14,471	10,012	35,137	32,407	17,761

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's imports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

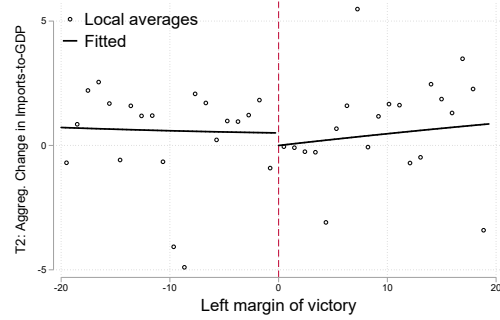
H.2.2 Aggregated Imports-to-GDP - IMF Data

Appendix Figure H6. Left-Wing Electoral Margin and Aggregated Imports - (1948-2020)

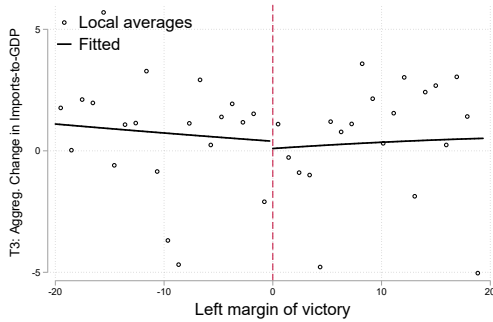
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



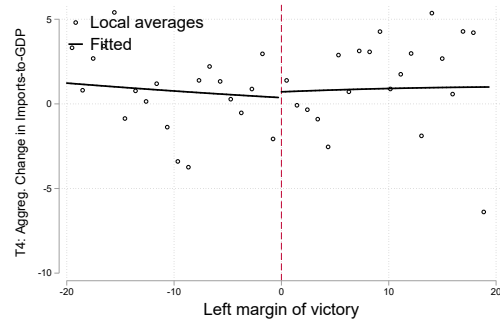
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure H6a to Figure H6d illustrate changes in aggregated imports-to-GDP. The vertical axis shows the percentage change in the Aggregated Imports-to-GDP ratio over four years post-election. The horizontal axis reflects the left's margin of victory. Points on the scatterplot represent the mean outcomes of the forcing variable. Fitted lines are derived using kernel-weighted local linear regression with MSE-optimal bandwidth. We perform fuzzy RD estimation with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at the country level.

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Appendix Table H6. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Aggregated Imports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1948–2020, Gravity: IMF Data Reported by Country of Destiny)

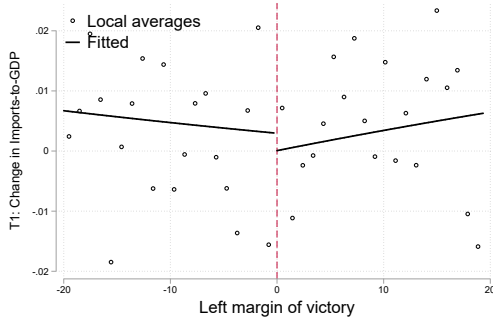
Outcome:	Change in Aggregated Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	-0.98 (1.48)	0.24 (1.41)	-0.24 (1.37)	-0.69 (1.77)	0.34 (1.34)	-1.39 (1.27)	-1.95 (2.96)	-0.71 (3.37)	-1.48 (3.39)
+2	-0.80 (1.64)	0.57 (2.01)	1.23 (1.80)	-3.70** (2.18)	-3.45** (2.02)	-5.35*** (2.09)	0.25 (3.63)	4.64 (4.56)	3.34 (3.81)
+3	-0.50 (1.75)	-2.07 (2.54)	-1.22 (2.15)	-2.99 (2.32)	-3.32** (2.07)	-4.76*** (2.08)	0.37 (3.73)	0.22 (6.67)	0.72 (5.77)
+4	0.01 (2.13)	-0.21 (2.24)	-0.65 (2.03)	-3.16* (2.48)	-3.49** (1.74)	-7.68*** (1.63)	0.50 (4.12)	0.50 (8.70)	-1.64 (6.48)
First stage	0.56*** (0.09)	0.49*** (0.07)	0.50*** (0.07)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.30** (0.13)	0.18 (0.09)	0.20 (0.10)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	941	941	941	348	348	348	593	593	593
Eff. obs	468	451	470	157	129	137	283	230	212

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated imports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

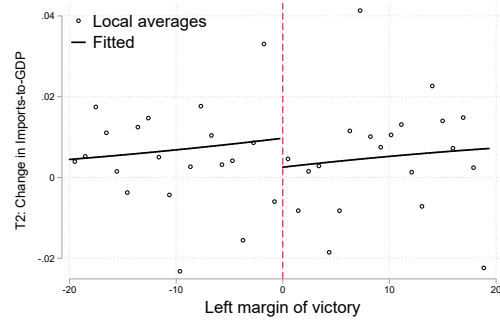
H.2.3 Disaggregated Imports-to-GDP - Comtrade Data

Appendix Figure H7. Left-Wing Electoral Margin and Imports - (1962-2020)

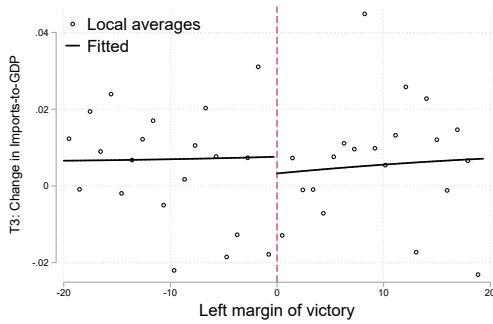
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



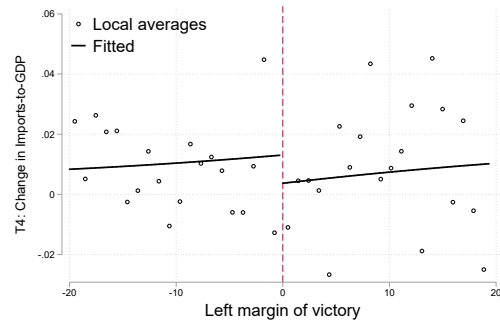
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure H7a to Figure H7d illustrate changes in imports-to-GDP. The vertical axis shows the percentage change in the Disaggregated Imports-to-GDP ratio over four years post-election. The horizontal axis reflects the left's margin of victory. Points on the scatterplot represent the mean outcomes of the forcing variable. Fitted lines are derived using kernel-weighted local linear regression with MSE-optimal bandwidth. We perform fuzzy RD estimation with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at country level.

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Appendix Table H7. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Imports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1962–2020, Gravity: Comtrade Data Reported by Country of Destiny)

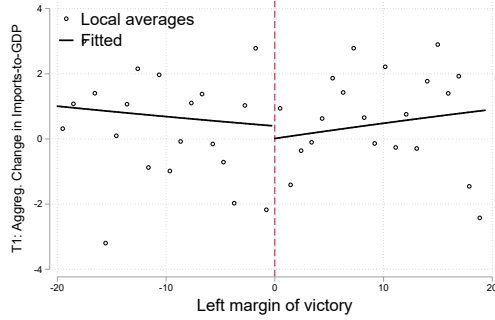
Outcome:	Change in Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h								
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	-0.01 (0.02)	-0.00 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.02)	-0.00 (0.01)	0.00 (0.01)	-0.00 (0.01)	-0.01 (0.04)	-0.02 (0.07)	-0.33** (0.19)
+2	-0.02 (0.02)	0.00 (0.02)	-0.02** (0.02)	-0.03** (0.02)	-0.02** (0.01)	-0.07*** (0.01)	-0.02 (0.04)	-0.02 (0.06)	-0.26** (0.17)
+3	-0.01 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.03)	-0.06** (0.03)	-0.01 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.02)	0.11*** (0.01)	-0.02 (0.07)	-0.00 (0.09)	-0.26*** (0.13)
+4	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.02 (0.03)	-0.06* (0.04)	-0.01 (0.02)	-0.01 (0.01)	0.07*** (0.01)	-0.04 (0.07)	-0.01 (0.10)	-0.30*** (0.13)
First stage	0.51*** (0.10)	0.44*** (0.08)	0.40*** (0.06)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.26 (0.14)	0.15 (0.09)	0.19** (0.09)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Country FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	109,157	109,157	109,157	31,126	31,126	31,126	78,031	78,031	78,031
Eff. obs	57,731	53,949	47,283	16,277	12,529	7,121	41,472	36,584	17,950

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's imports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

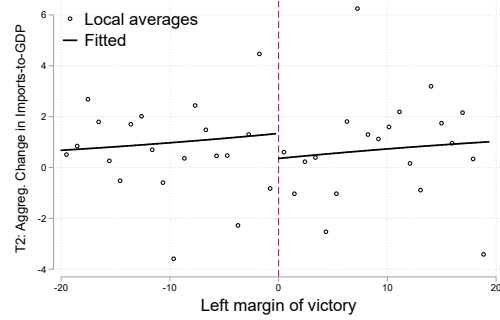
H.2.4 Aggregated Imports-to-GDP - Comtrade Data

Appendix Figure H8. Left-Wing Electoral Margin and Imports - (1962-2020)

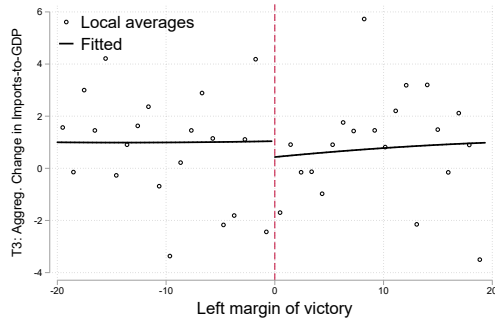
(a) One Year Post-Election Results



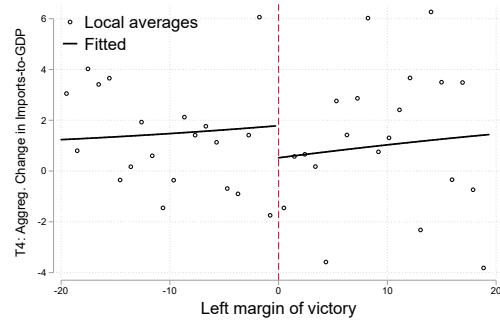
(b) Two Years Post-Election Results



(c) Three Years Post-Election Results



(d) Four Years Post-Election Results



Notes: Figure H8a to Figure H8d illustrate changes in aggregated imports-to-GDP. The vertical axis shows the average percentage change in the Aggregated Imports-to-GDP ratio over four years post-election. The horizontal axis reflects the left's margin of victory. Points on the scatterplot represent the mean outcomes of the forcing variable. Fitted lines are derived using kernel-weighted local linear regression with MSE-optimal bandwidth. We perform fuzzy RD estimation with robust bias-corrected standard errors clustered at country level.

*

Appendix Table H8. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Imports: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1962–2020, Gravity: Comtrade Data Reported by Country of Destiny)

Outcome:		Change in Aggregated Imports-to-GDP between t-1 and t+h							
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	-0.88 (2.39)	0.15 (2.31)	-0.80 (2.33)	-0.33 (1.70)	0.03 (1.01)	-0.15 (0.95)	-1.15 (6.25)	-1.82 (8.69)	-38.94 (47.59)
+2	-2.02 (2.18)	0.08 (2.14)	-1.65 (2.49)	-2.88** (1.88)	-2.18*** (1.04)	-2.85*** (1.04)	-3.07 (4.97)	-2.58 (8.65)	-12.28 (14.47)
+3	-1.50 (3.50)	-1.09 (3.61)	-0.84 (3.65)	-1.27 (2.66)	-0.50 (1.79)	-0.03 (1.74)	-4.09 (10.96)	-13.46 (23.41)	-32.84* (36.16)
+4	-2.66 (3.12)	-2.61 (3.51)	-2.50 (3.79)	-1.79 (2.48)	-1.04 (1.54)	-2.71** (1.47)	-8.47 (10.95)	-4.27 (14.84)	-33.29* (33.62)
First stage	0.55*** (0.10)	0.47*** (0.08)	0.45*** (0.08)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	1.00*** (0.00)	0.28 (0.14)	0.17 (0.09)	0.09 (0.10)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	772	772	772	264	264	264	508	508	508
Eff. obs	408	386	357	137	109	108	254	253	165

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's aggregated imports after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10, ** < 0.05, *** < 0.01.

H.3 Δ Trade-to-GDP Table - GMD Database

Appendix Table H9. Impact of Left-Wing Electoral Victories on Trade Openness: Fuzzy RDD for Legislative and All Elections and Sharp RDD for Presidential Elections (1944–2022, Global Macro Database)

Outcome:		Change in Trade Openness between t-1 and t+h							
h (years)	All elections			Presidential			Legislative		
+1	0.11 (3.68)	4.83** (3.37)	2.80 (3.22)	1.15 (4.35)	2.11 (3.12)	2.15 (2.80)	-3.66 (6.57)	4.38 (8.00)	-1.35 (6.49)
+2	-4.04 (4.10)	2.05 (5.23)	-3.48** (4.25)	-10.71** (6.38)	-2.05 (4.02)	-3.94 (3.84)	-5.36 (6.78)	3.84 (9.37)	0.75 (7.98)
+3	1.86 (5.84)	-0.16 (4.90)	-2.26* (5.18)	-7.27 (7.61)	-3.22 (5.36)	-4.41 (5.01)	2.39 (8.71)	11.76 (18.43)	7.73 (14.61)
+4	1.64 (7.44)	-1.57 (5.88)	-3.83* (5.55)	-5.87 (7.37)	-6.67* (6.51)	-4.61 (6.04)	1.18 (8.50)	9.27 (18.22)	3.73 (14.06)
First stage	0.58*** (0.12)	0.48*** (0.09)	0.51*** (0.09)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	1.00 (0.00)	0.31** (0.13)	0.16 (0.09)	0.20 (0.10)
Year FE		✓	✓		✓	✓		✓	✓
Region FE			✓			✓			✓
Obs	1,028	1,028	1,028	370	370	370	658	658	658
Eff. obs	345	305	273	121	119	119	286	225	201

Notes: This table shows the effect of electoral victories by left-wing parties on the country's openness to international trade after the election. The estimates were obtained using Fuzzy RDD (for legislative and "All elections") and Sharp RDD (for presidential elections). Standard errors (in parentheses) are robust to bias correction and clustered at the country level. "First stage" refers to the first stage of the Fuzzy RDD for $h = 1$. "Eff. obs" denotes the number of observations within the optimal bandwidth for $h = 1$. Coefficients are the conventional coefficients. Levels of significance: * < 0.10 , ** < 0.05 , *** < 0.01 .